

Media and Marginals in India

Medium, Message
and Meaning

Edited by

Manoj Kumar Jena



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BOYDELL • MANOHAR

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Preface

This book is the result of endless efforts and contributions of extremely renowned scholars from various inter-disciplinary backgrounds. The idea for this book was conceptualized while teaching a course on media studies and organizing a Seminar at the Department of Sociology at Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi, which finally took its shape at CSSS, JNU, New Delhi. My teaching of the course on social theory and supervision of PhD students in the media studies further galvanized me to develop a book on the issue of media and marginals.

I am immensely grateful to two institutions, the Jawaharlal Nehru University and Jamia Millia Islamia; and all my students and colleagues for their immense support. This book is dedicated to my students, and the teachers at the said universities.

The book is prepared for scholars in sociology, media studies, marginal studies, and social sciences, in general. It is a multidisciplinary work on media and marginal studies with the objective of exploring and understanding the issues related to marginals in Indian society, references to medium, message and its meaning. In continuation of the sociological and media studies tradition for understanding marginals, this volume moves beyond the conventional methodological practices.

The book is an outcome of the collective endeavour of all contributors, and enables scholars to understand and explore the question of media and marginals from the macro to the micro level. The introduction provides a background to this book while discussing the question of the marginal. All the chapters have emphasized on the different dimensions and approaches of the medium, message and meaning. It engages with various questions from sexuality to feminism; the Dalit to disability in cinema; minority to agitation and social movement; labour to theatre; and representation to ideological domination. It uncovers the ontological and epistemological ques-

tions related to media and marginals. In general, all the chapters in this book present an entwined analysis of the question related to media and marginals.

I am thankful to Prof Biswajit Das, Prof Neshat Quaiser, Dr Vibodh Parthasarathi, and all my colleagues, students, departmental staff and library staff members of the JNU for their constant support.

I would personally like to thank Mr. Ajay Kumar Jain and Mr. Ananya Jain of Manohar Publications and Distributors for publishing this volume. Many thanks to the anonymous readers of the manuscript for their detailed comments, and the entire Manohar team.

Many thanks to my family members for their unwavering support.

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Introduction

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Media has always been one of the central questions to social structure and its processes, and is integral to the social world. It mediates the social, political and economic relationships and reshapes our imagination of them. Many of the cultural commentators have often argued that 'we' live in a world of situated culture, and within a 'culture of mediation'. As one of the fundamental social units, the media plays a critical role in creating, shaping, and reflecting public opinion in a democratic society, however, public opinion is the engine that keeps the wheels of democracy turning.¹ In a profound sense, media/communication is one of the unique products and producers of society's development.²

The medium, message and meaning are essential components of communication process. Marshal McLuhan argued 'medium is the message',³ one can move further towards the question of meaning which is central to social relations. Messages and Meanings are vital components of the social world, as Stuart Hall argues, the meaning is a social product associated with social practices, and language and symbolizations are the certain means by which meaning is produced.⁴ The media, in any form, whether cinema, visual, print, or theatre, are carriers of meaning and are part of social structure and functions. The study of media and communication process is dynamic, because of changing nature of message and meaning processes. For instance, semiotics sees media as associated with social meaning and as the product of the relationships constructed between the 'signs'. The 'sign' is a basic unit of communication, which could be in the form

of a photograph, a traffic signal, a word, a sound, an object, or a smell, whatever the culture finds significant.⁵ The mediated image has multiple meanings that vary from place to place, and person to person. The content created by media and the flow of information services shaped/reshaped the social terrain; it has its own time space and ideological specificity, the routine social life revolves around the media identities, media fantasies, and media constructed realities. The fundamental question in the present context is whether the media is constructing a representational reality in the form of media reality or vice-versa. Whether media is structuring or restructuring people's sensibilities and taken for granted realities? This is indeed an ontological question. Jim Willis argues that, 'today, what we know comes almost entirely from the news media. However, since the media gives us only a representation of reality—a kind of shadow world with varying degrees of accuracy—our behaviour and reactions may or may not be valid or consistent with what really has transpired.'⁶

Willis also argues that, the media sets the public agenda, and the role of the media is to mobilize public support for special interests that dominate government and society.⁷ There are also questions of reproduction and legitimation of dominance, and how growing technological innovation brought about more and more control of the medium, which is ideologically specific and market-driven. Media production is intrinsically interlinked with capital, in fact, global capital with hegemonic ideological base. As has been argued, in a democratic set up, the media is the foremost tool for public discourse activities, however, the existing public sphere in a democratic social space is always contested in spite of a controlled situation where few control many. Hence, it is essential to critically analyse media and marginal question which is intrinsically associated with medium, message and meaning.

Questions related to marginals are always topical in sociology and media studies. The question about marginal and mainstream needs to be appropriately addressed. The term 'marginal' according to the Merriam-Webster Dictionary is 'of relating to, or situated at a margin or border, excluded from or existing outside the mainstream of society'.⁸ According to Collins' dictionary, marginal can be viewed as insignificant; they are not involved in the main events or

developments in society because they are poor or have no power'.⁹ They are socially stigmatized and vulnerable socially, economically, and politically. The question of marginal is also embedded in sociological writings. According to sociological literature, the marginal man concept relates to Robert Park's original interests in race and ethnic relations and migration.¹⁰ Park (1928) highlighted the question of marginal man; for him, 'the marginal man; the man who, emerging from the ghetto in which he lived in Europe, is seeking to find a place in the freer, more complex and cosmopolitan life of an American city.'¹¹ C.A. Goldberg argues that although Park conceived the marginal man as a general social type, he closely associated the type with the Jews of the modern era. Park was a student of and strongly influenced by Simmel, he explicitly identified the marginal man with Simmel's own notion of the stranger, the 'classic example' of which for Simmel ([1908] 1971:144) was 'the history of European Jews'.¹² E.V. Stonequist's work *The Marginal Man* is more on the sociological analysis, as 'it was a kind of sociological frame of reference', he argued 'the marginal man is a personality type that arises at a time and a place where, out of the conflict of races and cultures, new societies, new peoples, and cultures are coming into existence. The fate which condemns him to live, at the same time, in two worlds is the same which compels him to assume, in relation to the worlds in which he lives, the role of a cosmopolitan and a stranger'.¹³

The marginal could also be considered as a sociological category in the Indian context on the basis of complex social differentiations, based on sexuality, gender relations, physical and mental disability, caste, class, ethnicity, religion, minority, etc. The difference and distinctiveness as a social category are intersectional and intermixed with various other categories. The marginals in India, particularly women, Dalits, disabled, and various ethnic and religious minorities, are socially, politically, and economically marginalized. The communities, groups, and individuals on the basis of caste, gender, ethnicity, religion and disabilities categories are classified as marginal on the basis of their identities and social locational specificity. They are subjected to a dominant and ossified reality constructed by the upper echelons of society. Also, they are pushed towards a culture of

marginalization. These marginal groups form a major chunk of the population in Indian society, which were excluded and discriminated against on the basis of their structural position. Their voice and sufferings are never adequately represented in mainstream media. They are out of the medium, message, and meaning processes. This issue is related to historical, situational, and textual contexts. The existing dominant institutional structure, values, norms, and ideologies downgrade the marginal position.

Because of its structural locations, marginals are differently segmented, and are neglected in media production process. Here, one could see through the sociological lens how they are not only adversely affected by entrenched structural inequality but also suffer by systematic social exclusionary process. The marginal groups often confront challenges on the basis of their primordial identity; most suffered are Dalits, women, and religious minorities on the basis of their predetermined differences and negation. The dominant groups control medium message and meaning in the mainstream society. On one hand, the dominant groups are idealizing and glorifying their past and foregrounding their lineage, and on the other hand, they negate the marginal because of their lineage and social locations.

The book is an attempt to explore the relationships between marginal and different forms of communication processes. Furthermore, this book tries to unravel the linkages between the media and the caste, class, gender, minority, political and ideological structures of Indian society in general.

ABOUT THE BOOK

This book attempts to highlight the role and relationship of media and marginals in India precisely in terms of gender, Dalit, disability, labour, the Sikh minority and ethnic minorities in India. The book addresses issues about the interrelationship between the communication process, the economic, political and ideological structures of Indian society, and their relationships with marginal, particularly at structural and meaning levels. It also tries to determine how the mediated phenomena have led to a shift in the discourse on marginals. It aims to present new and emerging analyses of caste, gender, and

minority questions in the Indian media pertaining to structure, process, representation, production, consumption, and meaning-making process. It also tries to figure out how the mediated phenomena have brought a shift in the discourse on the question of marginal in India.

The book is intended to understand the key concerns of marginals in India, specifically with reference to women, Dalits, minorities, marginal labourers, and people with disabilities in various mediums, including cinema and theatre. The nine chapters of the book from well-known scholars in sociology, media studies, gender studies, labour studies, and linguistic studies from India and abroad, focus on several new dimensions in the Sociology and media research with a particular thrust on areas like women, Dalits, and minorities, including Sikhs and Muslims. These chapters reflect on a range of topics affecting the life of the marginals by the existing social realities, structural imbalances, violence, reinforcement of stereotypes, negations and negotiations. All the chapters illustrate conceptual and methodological questions related to the social positioning of the marginals covering empirical and theoretical aspects. The book's strength lies in exploring the experiential narratives and lived realities of marginals. The issues of women's agency and empowerment through cultural production, representation of gender, caste, and violence in popular culture are integral part of the book. The book provides a newer perspective on the sociology of media.

The first chapter, *Gender, Sexuality and Cinema: Reinforcing the Stereotypes* deals with the issue of cinema, gender and sexuality. It focuses on how violence is inherent in the actual depiction of women and mainstream media, including defining and redefining their identity. The chapter analyses the relationship between mainstream media and women, particularly how violence occurs inherent in the very depiction of women and mainstream media, as well as in defining women's identity.

The second chapter, *Hindi Cinema and Caste Question: Ideology and Reproduction of Dominance* analyses Hindi cinema from a sociological vantage point, particularly Hindi cinema as an institution and art form, as well as its social, cultural and ideological role in society. The chapter tries to understand narration, image/photography,

the power of visual imagery, technology and creative processes. Furthermore, it addresses the questions of ideology and the reproduction of caste domination in Hindi cinema. It argues how the cultural domination of Hindi cinema produces a subservient and passive self, contemporary cinema producing and reproducing dominant characters, normalising violence and subjugation through various representations. It is often argued that Hindi cinematic communication produces a dominant ideological pattern that negates marginal subjects. It has been observed that Hindi cinema storylines are more or less centred around upper-class/caste narratives, and reproduce a specific class and caste ideology.

The third chapter, *Realities of the Marginal Worker, as reflected in the Medium of Cinema* argues that, initially, cinema was a medium of entertainment. However, gradually, it became a powerful analytical tool for examining and reflecting the conditions of the marginals of the society. The marginals are the 'Dalits', sex workers, disadvantaged workers such as agricultural labourers, distressed marginal farmers, slum dwellers, street vendors, small artists and many others. This chapter provides an overview of the cinema industry and examines how some films reflect and narrate the realities of the existence of marginalised groups in Indian society, through some movies produced in Hindi. The purpose is to see to what extent the films narrated the existing conditions and what message the directors and producers attempted to deliver to the audience.

Chapter four, *Disability in Cinema: A Case Study of Selected Hindi Films* argues that cinema is an essential manner of representational medium, and is crucial in presenting various social realities on the screen. As cinema in general, and Hindi film in particular, has a large audience and a significant global reach, it is also essential to examine the nuances of its operation and appreciate its ideological implications and the hegemonic discourse of ableism within which it exists. In this context, the chapter highlights the question of disability in Hindi cinema and critically analyses the disability narrative in Hindi cinema. This chapter has studied selected contemporary Hindi Cinema to understand disability questions.

The fifth chapter, *Epistemic Ashrāfiya-Morality and Urdu Theatre Public Sphere in Nineteenth-Century Bihar: Muslim Internal-*

Decoloniality argues that the introduction of Western-style stage theatre in nineteenth-century India emerged not only as a site to legitimise colonial power but also to contest colonial rule and ideologies. This chapter through the prism of Urdu theatre in the last quarter of the nineteenth century in the Indian province of Bihar, argues that beyond this grand binary division, the theatre also became a site to contest local caste-class-race-religion-based ideologies of domination. It examines how epistemic *ashrāfiya* morality that excluded shudra-dalit Muslims from knowledge production responded to the popularity of theatre and its 'corrupting influences'; participation of 'lowly' women and men in theatre; threatening *ashrāfiya* moral authority; casteist prejudices; *ashrāfiya* collaboration with colonial power; marketised desire and consumption and other related issues.

The sixth chapter, *Consuming and Producing Feminism through Indian Media: Analysis of Empowerment, Commodification in Culture Industry* elucidates the 'girl power' rhetoric articulated in the popular and feminist discourses. While using the idea of commodification, this chapter demonstrates that not all 'girl power' rhetoric extends the desired opportunity for women to transcend individual consumption, proposing collective change in social relations. Furthermore, this chapter binds together the concepts of agency, empowerment and commodification in subsequent sections. This chapter demonstrates the fierceness of the 'girl power' rhetoric. With the support of empirical examples, this paper depicts the extent to which the commodified 'girl power' rhetoric has distorted feminist notions.

The seventh chapter, *Mediations and the Body-Politic: The Problem of Representation Revisited* argues how the question of representation has always been central to the analyses of media texts, especially in the context of studying images of the body. Subjecting textual configurations towards unravelling body politics in the context of analysing the 'marginalized' social groups remains a common way of approaching the problem of representation in contemporary media studies. This chapter takes a slight turn in its approach to the problem of representation and body politic by attempting a methodological realignment to underline the practices and effects that stem from text and its surroundings.

The eighth chapter *Media, Minority Consciousness, Memory: Sikhs and 1984* addresses the question of Sikh minority and media, and what were some representations that Indian mass media constructed and popularised? How did these texts create a process of Sikh marginalisation? Why are these representations being contested most emphatically in the diaspora, and what are some components of new narratives that diasporic Sikhs are creating via digital technology? This chapter draws on a combination of methods, including content analysis of print media (English dailies), radio and television reports, commentaries from journalists and scholars, narrative analysis of 1984 websites and personal interviews with Sikhs in North America, the U.S. and Canada. This chapter also provides a critical appraisal of media imagery while highlighting the hitherto neglected Sikh point of view.

The ninth chapter *Media, Social Media and the Gorkhaland Agitation in Darjeeling* highlights the media and Gorkhaland agitation in Darjeeling. The chapter argues that media, primarily print capitalism, is considered an essential medium through which nationalism and collective identity were forged, but not until the advent of social media and 24x7 news channels did Gorkhaland movement receive any attention from the fourth pillar of democracy. This happened not only because of the ignorance of the region and the cause of the people by the media, but also due to the appalling situation of the media itself. Though the media plays an important role in a movement, it did not contribute anything to propagating the issues of the Gorkhaland movement at the national level. The use of social media helped the movement in taking the ground realities to people across the globe. With the help of social media, the movement gained momentum and protests and demonstrations were held not just in Darjeeling and other places in the country, but across different countries where even a handful of people from Darjeeling were residing. The use of social media in the agitation of 2017, and helping the leaders and, most importantly, the majority of the people to be legally, constitutionally and socially erudite and fight the state in their just and rightful demand of separation from the state of West Bengal.

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CHAPTER 1

Gender, Sexuality and Cinema Reinforcing the Stereotype

RENUKA SINGH

INTRODUCTION

In 2015, a man in Australia escaped conviction on charges of stalking. Sandesh Baliga, who arrived in Australia from India three years prior, was arrested on charges of aggressively pursuing two different women—whom he made acquaintances with on separate occasions—while referring to himself as their boyfriend.¹ In court, Mr. Baliga confessed that his behaviour was influenced by Bollywood movies which convinced him of the efficacy of relentless pursuit of women; the defence argued that obsession in such matters is ‘quite normal behaviour’ for Indian men.² *Acknowledging* the peculiarity of the defendant’s cultural background, the Magistrate’s Court exempted him from conviction, on condition of good behaviour for the next five years. This event could be interpreted variously as a testament to the formidable influence of mass media in determining social norms and behaviour, as well as its capacity as a framework for constructing cultural stereotypes. Generalization of a deviant act—despite appropriate punishments existing—by describing it as ‘normal behaviour’ for *Indian men*, and the Court’s subsequent decision to sustain that argument in favour of exemption, is certainly a testament to a patriarchal substratum underlying modern jurisprudence, transcending socio-political and cultural boundaries.

However, the conviction in such obsessive and relentless pursuit of romantic gratification is not particular to any region such as *India*, nor is its depiction in mass media. The idea of a woman’s predisposition

to succumb to the force of relentless pursuit is a ubiquitous conviction that forms much of the basis of modern sexual practices and performances of gender roles. Modes of pursuit and their varied depictions are periodically updated, revolving perpetually along the orbit of resolute male desire and a woman's fait accompli of giving in to the same. The stubbornness of male desire and a woman's inability (or desire) to overcome it, is understood as innate characteristics of *masculine* and *feminine* sexuality, and respectively act as boundaries for both. This *natural* and body-based understanding of social behaviour has neither been perpetual nor linear. Mapping the origins of social choices on a framework of gender is a practice that has a genesis, and is entwined with the evolution of a certain socio-political dispensation central to which is the concept of a self-conscious and *knowing* subject. Normalization of gendered discourses and gender identities routinely influence juridical decisions and punitive quantum. Conversely, such excesses get absorbed within the folds of embodied identities, as part of the law's normalizing discourse. These discourses in turn constitute a larger vision of collective existence central to which are the requisites of confession and consent. Within this vision, violence, especially that of different forms of sexual crime and harassment, is understood variously, as the breakdown of the law's deterrence against an individual's natural and embodied instincts, as well as a lapse in social control. And it is within the moral contours of this vision that consent and its breach are appraised.

In contractarian and self-governing societies, mass media assumes its importance in terms of both, as a mirror of reflecting popular ideas as well as constructing and disseminating them. The scope of a particular medium is determined by the rules that govern the object of its engagement. In terms of research, Michel Foucault's works provide a particularly well-calibrated framework to theorize the discourse between mass media and gender and sexuality. In terms of method, it implies that instead of the intent behind a certain discourse, it is the technology of the latter that is the unit of analysis. This at once relativizes agency to a certain technology of power rather than to certain biological and cultural determinisms and frees up space for more expansive mapping of gender politics.

SOCIAL BEHAVIOUR

The Industrial Revolution and the emergence of capitalism could be an ideal point of departure in constructing a genealogical understanding of the relationship between mass media and social behaviour. With the onslaught of the revolution, the state progressively assumes an inward gaze, preoccupying itself with problems on settled populations, increasingly routinized through strict discipline enforced in workhouses and factories, and generally in the course of everyday life in the nascent metropolis. The breakdown of feudalism followed by the emergence of free enterprise gave rise to new relationships of exploitation between individuals as well as, between individuals and their environment. Laws and customs, from this time on, are progressively aligned with the maintenance of this emerging relational network which simultaneously sustains the structure of civic life, while remaining at the centre of its engagements. However, the tautological nature of this emergent socio-economic order entails that its problems are also lingering. Due to the persistent nature of these problems, the concepts of *degeneration* and *endemic* serve as powerful models for explaining and dealing with them (Foucault: 2003). It also affects an inversion in terms of social security as henceforth, the logic and possibilities of both, crisis and security, are increasingly to be found within the society itself. Further, management or mitigation of these problems necessitates constant surveillance instead of zero-sum measures. A civic existence, therefore, is a constantly surveillant existence whereby the inward-gazing individual is a microcosm of the inward-gazing society. Society must be defended against itself as does the individual against its own. The responsibility of self-governance predicated upon knowledge of the self and its surroundings ensures the cultivation of a society that is both confessional and consensual. It marks the commencement of the journey of the *knowing subject*: a subject that is inward gazing while at the same time, responsible for and partaking in a collective and mutually consensual existence. Henceforth, it is this collective (population) that is the object of law; individual interest is displaced as the target of law, by what Foucault defines as 'man-as-species'.³ It

marks the emergence of a new form of rule—focussed upon fixing the parameters of a self-contained collective existence—which Foucault terms ‘biopolitics’.⁴ Thus, the knowing subject is essentially *biopolitical*, inducted into the process of *knowing* itself and its milieu from the earliest stages of its life. Public space is cultivated as a confessional space as it would constitute an important part of an individual’s *learning* discourse. However, neither is public space the only one for discursive learning nor is confession within this space unbridled by rules.

Public and Private Domain

The production of public-private dichotomy and characterization of the public space as *liberating* was achieved in no small measure by arrogating sexuality to the private domain. However, such a characterization of the *public* could find moral purchase only based on various confessional practices in myriad discourses of civic life. It is one’s confession of individual choices and practices of the private—expressed through various walks of public life—is what discursively integrates the public space as one of accountability, liberty and equality. Therefore, the *true* nature of public space derives its authority from this elementary factor of confession which in turn, derives its moral authority from the Christian concept of liberty through confession. The privation of sexuality, however, posed a problem for exhaustive confession in public discourse. Specifically, confession or expression of sexual matters had to bypass the prohibitions of bourgeois etiquette, yet be expressive enough to be considered as true. This was important because not only were the sexual practices and choices of the population increasingly becoming a core concern for the modern state, but because the very practices of expression and confession were instrumental in constituting certain discursive mechanisms and institutions that would assume authority in matters of determining meaning in modernity.

Rules of etiquette, decreeing a code of silence around sexuality and sexual matters in public discourse, and sourced out of old ascetic views of treating the body as an adversary, compelled innovation of counter codes, based upon two fundamental principles: *first*, fashion

silence itself as a language of expression and *second*, secularize the body, consequently turning it into an object of legal rather than religious intervention. As an object of right, therefore, the body is personal. This is both, the formative concept of individual rights, as well as the stepping stone to a public life. Similarly, the practice of self-control in public life is intrinsic, both to individual character development as well as to the internal cohesion of society. However, the secularization of the body—a process that commenced with the Renaissance—never totally displaces religious and ascetic ideals but only renders their visibility much more obscure (Synott: 1992, 90-1). Thus, traditionally extolled virtues of heterosexuality, monogamy and so on, were institutionalized as ideal practices while prohibited practices were divided and re-channelized variously into domains of the law and those of the Church.

A basic modern impulse to keep public discourse *sanitized* and civil required proactive and constant surveillance against *disruptive* possibilities. The resultant vigilant character of the society was reified through *incitement to discourse* (Foucault: 1978)—something that is also key to understanding how meanings come to proliferate and normalize through the evolution of modernity. Essentially, not only had the society to be defended against imminent and ongoing attacks, but newer possibilities were to be apprehended and neutralized. Privation of sexuality, coupled with the essential value of its control to the health of the population, necessitated a paradoxical obligation to maintain a civilized silence around it while concurrently talking about it in as many discursive ways; this widespread proliferation of sexuality in public discourse occurs in the way of a stocktaking, as a practice in accountability and hence, the obligation to do so.⁵ The gaze that *took stock* of the body through various institutional mechanisms stripped the body of its various cultural attributes and replaced them with biological determinisms. This delocalization of the body from its cultural contingencies is precisely what secularizes it. Accordingly, sex is no longer simply an object of condemnation, but of administration and optimization. It is towards these ends that increasing policing of sex from the eighteenth century onwards is directed at, transforming it (sex) into a 'public potential'.⁶ Thus, the essentialization of the *public* as an expressly confessional space

wherein everything—tastes, opinions, practices—is considered to be a conscious avowal of what one truly is. It is also a pedagogical process as every decree and obligation to confess comes with the rider of knowing oneself, facilitating a better understanding of one's true impulses and potential. This is therefore a society in which authority is predicated predominantly upon knowledge and predictability.

While modern, secular law becomes one of the most prominent institutions to *discursive* the body, the latter's objectification and display in public discourse also occurs majorly through the discourse of medicine. Discovered as an object of medical intervention, the body is conditioned by that *true* scientific discourse as the boundary of individual existence; sexuality, sexual desire and pleasure become the basis of all motivation and therefore, their control and management accrue as matters of social control. In medicine, a certain power develops that is predicated upon the act of *investigation*, of prying open the human body and laying bare the roots of every anatomical working that simulates various *unnatural* pleasures (homosexuality, bestiality, necrophilia and so). The authority of medicine is owed to the existence of the body as its object, while at the same time, medicalized descriptions of human behaviour and choices increasingly gain currency in public discourse as reflections of true discourses. Consequently, morality itself, deviance, and crime are increasingly discovered as owing out of biological impulses and stimuli rather than out of the displacement of faith. Cumulatively, these practices constitute a normalizing discourse, central to which is a double impetus of *pleasure* and *power*.⁷ Accordingly, medicinal power derives its vitality and specific pleasures from monitoring, questioning, prying open, and having authority over the most personal of objects—the body—and its minute and obscure workings. Against this, a very different kind of pleasure emerges, one which derives not out of conformation but out of evasion of not just medicinal but various other kinds of normalizing discourses. It is important to note here that the scope for the latter kind of pleasure is determined by the points on which a certain mechanism chooses to apply itself. In essence, the *normalization* of heteronormativity and monogamy in modernizing discourses, has had just as much effect in expanding the scope of sexuality and sexual choices by having placed the body in the

middle of a tug-of-war between pleasure and power. It is within the binding effect of this dual pull that modern subjectivity emerges. With every prohibition leading to the possibility of a concomitant evasion, modernity emerges as an optimizing discourse.

BODY AND THE GENDER DICHOTOMY

Secularization of the body is generally considered as a transformative step through which the body—otherwise a *private* object—is discovered both as the basis of *truth*, as well as a yardstick against which truth or authenticity can be measured. This discovery of the ubiquity of the body with its relationship to truth serves as the basis of society's justification for monitoring, controlling, classifying, and managing bodies—all as matters of social security which is an obligation borne out of the social contract to constantly guard against possibilities of exposure to the state of nature. Reduction of the body as an *a priori* object of nature, and conflating its control with social security, conceptualizes it (body) as the very fabric of social existence; thus, the body is the first line of security against the state of nature as well as something which would invariably challenge social cohesion if not controlled and channelized. This is also how sex is transformed into a public potential, its control accruing as a matter of sustaining a certain vision of existence that is predicated upon constantly mapping the body in search of signs of truth. The matter of investigation and permissibility of margins of error in its methods derive their authority and sanction from the supreme obligation to defend the social contract. As such, these are necessary preconditions to the enjoyment of rights. The cartography of the body, however, is not an open-ended exercise; the scope of mapping the body is determined along the lines of gender binaries. Accordingly, *masculinity* and *femininity* are the basic yardsticks against which narratives of normality and abnormality or marginality are thrashed out. The stabilization of gender dichotomy as *true*, is caused by what could be termed as a *pan-sexualization* of the body,⁸ a process which simultaneously *naturalizes* the body while at the same time places it in an adversarial position vis-à-vis the progress of civilization. Reduction of the body to its sexuality on one hand, and the discovery

of bodily desire at the basis of every human motivation on the other, cumulatively authorizes the secularization of the body as well as its channelization into productive categories. Gender binaries, heterosexuality, public-private dichotomy and so on, are categories that are stabilized through optimization and channelization, a process that Menon describes—in the context of law's normalizing discourse—as *violence of categories* (Menon: 2007, 17). This foundational violence is constitutive of both, individual rights and the public-private dichotomy. Appropriation of women within the realm of the private and projection of the public sphere as most appropriate for the man is achieved based on perceived gender-based determinisms: male bodies, perceived as clearly bounded and solid, are considered as lending naturally to control and hence, reflecting the ideal condition of a well-guarded public space. On the other hand, women's bodies, perceived as disorderly, penetrable, subject to cyclical changes and divisible through reproduction, challenge the very idea of a closed and controllable body surface. The resultant hierarchy between man and woman, and the superiority of the former in relation to the latter, is one upon which the public-private dichotomy is mapped. This perceived gender hierarchy is cemented not through recourse to religion but through science.⁹ Optimization and channelization of the sexualized body occur along the lines of avowedly *scientific truths*. Depiction of sexual violence as well as methods of such depictions, reinforce gender binaries while at the same time expanding the scope of discovering newer peculiarities that can either be explained along binary lines or referred to the normalizing discourses of medicine and/or the law. Censorship therefore is based on moral codes that claim to derive out of (perceived) true discourses and prohibit or permit depending upon what is perceived as normal or otherwise. The conflation of the natural, the normal, and the moral into a singular framework of interpretation are what colours the concepts of rights, consent, desire, and so. An incitement to discourse, therefore, is also an incitement to categorize whereby confession and control are authorized for the sake of ever-increasing scope for prediction, apprehension and prevention of threats to the social fabric. Additionally, categories also facilitate the channelization of the body into productive relationships with each other and the environment,

a process that allows for seamless convergence between social security and capitalism.

REEL AND THE REAL

Over three decades after the film *Last Tango in Paris* (1972) was released and found critical acclaim all over the world as an excellent erotic drama, the lead actress in the movie, Maria Schneider revealed the real-life violation that occurred as part of making this masterpiece. The scene in question was a rape scene in which Marlon Brando uses butter as a lubricant before forcing himself onto Schneider. The actress, who died in 2011, had revealed that although she was aware of the rape scene, she wasn't aware of the specific detail up until the part was being played out. The 'sequence of the butter', as it turns out, was an off-script improvisation that director Bernardo Bertolucci came up with and subsequently, took Brando into confidence about. In an interview from 2013, Bertolucci *confessed* that he did not update Schneider about the improvisation because he wanted the latter to 'react as a girl, not as an actress'. And that he wanted her 'to react humiliated'. When Bertolucci's interview resurfaced on the internet in 2016, he reacted to the ensuing controversy by saying that it was based on a 'ridiculous misunderstanding'.¹⁰

The decision to forego the consent of the actress portraying the condition of being raped, is based *first*, on a certain drive to distinguish the work as pushing the boundaries of *authentic* depiction and *second*, a well-entrenched scepticism about the capacity of professional performers—in this case, a woman—of being able to capture this projected reality in all its realistic authenticity, or at least not to the degree that the director deems as adequately authentic. In other words, the director wanted the actress to not just *act* but to *feel* raped, *be* raped. True to his expectations, Schneider confessed to feeling humiliated and 'a little raped'.¹¹ As much is also clear, Bertolucci's justification of his decision—most importantly to himself—is expressed in his capacity as a director and the craft of his art. Consent can be foregone or taken for granted, only if in the name of authenticity in the pursuit of art. The setting in which Bertolucci's imagination flared up, is also immensely relevant in the entire affair.

According to the director, he and Brando were having breakfast one day during the shoot; and there was on the table, a baguette and butter. Of his submission, he and Brando then 'looked at each other' and both knew what they wanted.¹² This apparent silence around what is, an act of fetish, viz., usage of butter as a lubricant, is in itself a confession of proscribed desires, its confessional nature testified even further through the apparent, express, and ready convergence of both men's assumptions and their mutual understanding and acknowledgement of the same. Further, the usage of butter as an external implement in the act of sex reflects a very particular tendency that equates the pan-sexualization of public space with liberation. This fetishization of sex by optimizing bodily functions through external implementation is what Foucault describes as the *desexualisation* of the body, an act that leads to an *intensification of pleasure* (Foucault: 1996, 212). An exhaustive codification of pleasure according to the laws of sex makes the latter the limit of the former. Subsequently, a 'decoding' or revealing of all secrets of pleasure (in terms of sex) is still widely viewed as 'liberating'.¹³ This liberation through an active and participative process of experiencing, learning, and archiving the secrets of pleasure and sex, is what is largely responsible for not just pornographic depictions but also the deployment of taboo tactics such as non-consensual recording or documentation (as in the 'sequence of the butter'), thereby simulating a pornographic trope in real life. While behind the lens it is this particularly calibrated deployment of a taboo that leads to the experience of rape; in front of the lens, the taboo is something that intensifies pleasure and liberates senses; the rape and its peculiarities, on screen, assumes a liberatory potential by uncovering a supposedly repressed truth.

There is another substratum of violence underlining it all, and something inherent in the pivot of filmmaking itself that is, the camera. Functioning as a symbol of the fourth wall in filmmaking, the camera is an offshoot of the neutral gaze of science, expressed in the perceived authenticity of the visual register itself. The construction of real life through the camera is limited only through the intentions of the one directing it. Conversely, the authority of the director ought to be understood as emanating out of the infallibility of the technology

that he is wielding. In *The Question Concerning Technology* (1977), Heidegger points out that etymologically, the name *technology* stems from the Greek term *technicon*, which is an element of *technē*. *Technē* denotes both, activities and skills of craftsmen as well as arts of the mind and fine arts, and is linked from the earliest time, with the word *epistēmē* (Heidegger: 12-13). Technology, therefore, functions essentially in the field of knowledge but according to a very particular method. Technology is a *mode of revealing* that brings forth the truth about the form of something before its actual appearance. Modern technology too is a mode of revealing, but not in the more poetic sense as in Classical Greek narrative (*Poiēsis*) but in the form of a challenge to nature, of its exploitation.¹⁴ This conflation of the philosophy of knowledge through revelation, with the exploitation of nature (sexualized body as a *natural object*), and its subsequent deployment in the directed depiction of real life, is the primary source of acceptability and desire of not just specific forms of depiction but also of methods that guide the screening of such depictions. In *Last Tango*, the rape scene not only fetishizes and desexualizes the human body but clearly, the exceptionality of that sequence is highlighted even further in the context of Bertolucci's decision to hide it from Schneider who in this scene, would be the one 'taking it' while Brando would be the one 'giving/doing it'. After all, it is to accentuate Brando's appendage that the butter is used. The assumed latency of Schneider's role in the situation could be regarded as part reason for her being left out of the information regarding updating the script. Any assumption of the actress' latency in the scene reflects an unquestionable conviction in the neutral gaze of the camera (and the crew) and a lacuna of appreciation of differences that underlie between a naked man and a naked woman when positioned in front of that neutral gaze of technology. This can be theorized in the context of Brando's confession that he felt 'humiliated' while shooting a full frontal nude scene for the same movie when he failed to achieve a full erection on account of it being cold.¹⁵ *First*, it is important to note here that Brando's self-consciousness and humiliation are despite being in front of the neutral gaze. *Second*, his humiliation is borne not *per sé* out of nudity but the inability to attain the full measure that is captured in the nude state. The

essentialization of sexual vitality that is captured in this event is only further constitutive of ideal body types and capacities. Therefore, if Brando could indeed achieve a full erection—which he doubtless did in the later course of shooting—his nudity would verily serve as a signifier of power and virility in all its open glory. For a woman, to be revealing herself in front of the camera's gaze in a candid fashion as such, is vastly different because the privation, concealment, and presentation of the woman's body and its sexual being are readily conflated with her honour and dignity. The rule of modesty dictates that the visibility of a woman's body is narrowly streamlined according to the purpose that is being served and the space that the body inhabits. It is precisely due to the difficulty of maintaining decreed standards of modesty in the public space that the latter is usually deemed as less conducive for a woman's being. Consequently, the very desire of a woman to step out in the public sphere is variously considered suspect, risky, disruptive, a lack of self-control and so forth. The interoperability of rape, promiscuity, and moral turpitude in various discourses is a fact that is not particular to any culture or time.¹⁶ However, violence is not the essence of technology but a permanent capacity of it, something that is triggered as per the direction of its wielding, and according to the rules that guide its object. It is certainly pedagogical as positioning against its gaze instills as well as awakens the *true* feelings of one's gender and its various natural attributes.

The 2000 movie *Bawandar*—depicting the 1992 gangrape and struggle of Bhanwari Devi, a women's welfare worker affiliated with the Government of Rajasthan—directed by Jagmohan Mundhra, was fairly extolled for its candid and daring depiction of a violent and disturbing reality, while also being harshly criticized for being unnecessarily graphic and prurient in those depictions. The criticism assumed more heft when it turned out that Mundhra's interactions with Devi had been limited to one meeting leading up to the production of the film, and that Devi had neither seen the film nor received any money from the director.¹⁷ Mundhra of course refuted these allegations with appropriate counters. While this certainly problematizes the entire process of making the film and casts it in a light of ethical suspicion, the particularities of the film itself inspire

a strong suspicion regarding consultation with the rape survivor about the paradigms of the event. While the gangrape was perpetrated by Gurjars and doubtless had an obvious caste dimension to it, to *even out* this factor in the movie, Devi's lawyer is depicted as being a Gurjar while in real life her lawyer was a Rajput.¹⁸ There is, politely put, scant reason to doubt that this rather sophisticated policy of a *balanced* portrayal of caste values, was run by Bhanwari Devi and sanctioned with the stamp of her approval. Further, in a much more stupendous blunder, a much younger actress (Nandita Das) was cast in the role of the survivor while the latter was forty years old at the time of her encounter (1992). Not enough can be said about the damage that this omission causes to the legacy of the survivors, particularly contingent experience and struggle. In his justification, Mundhra states that although inspired by Devi's case, the film is not a biography and that certain *amends* are required to *add drama* to a film.¹⁹ He does not explain whether this requisite to add drama is one that is generic to the logic of Hindi movies, or one that is particular to the depiction of sexual and caste violence that is rampant in society and to which, people are desensitized; to the latter intention of raising awareness through cinematic depiction is robbed of its apparent progressive value if attempted without consent of the rape survivor. Notwithstanding his clarification, as much is clear that in the depiction of the event, the director prioritizes the power of his imagination over the actual event. In doing so, he decouples the gravity of the event from the event itself thereby, taking the final product as far away as possible from reality. This then is a truth that essentially hinges upon the imagination of the authority and authority of that imagination.

Films that normalize sexual violence in reinforcing gender binaries are dime-a-dozen and one is spoilt for choice. Let's consider the movie *Tum Mere Ho* (1990) in which the lead roles characters are played by the-then-newcomers Aamir Khan and Juhi Chawla. The film is one of the several *Nagin* films, a fad that characterized Bollywood for quite a while. As such, the movie can already be reckoned as inside a ready trope. At one point in the movie, Khan's snake charmer cum medicine man mentor explains to one of their clients (*Khurana Saab*) that on the night of *nag panchami*, it is a

customary practice among his *Pahari Kabila* (hilly tribes) for the unmarried men to try and forcefully carry away whichever maiden they like, and if the hijack is a success, the twain are married off. He explains how this is not an easy task and that the woman aggressively tries to repel the man's advances *because*, as he explains, women like to have husbands who are 'stronger' than them.²⁰ Khurana Saab is then invited to stay back and see it all for himself. Khurana excuses himself from the inevitable, and on the night of *nag panchami*, Khan (*Shiva*), mock assaults Chawla (*Paro*), while the latter does everything that is expected of her, i.e. mock repel the attack on her mock integrity, finally being real-time carried away on Khan's shoulders inside a small hut,²¹ while a cheering crowd cheers away almost gratefully. In this, the trope of rape is skilfully deployed yet casually, but in a way that manages to pass the censor board's scrutiny, camouflages it under the garb of *riwaz* (custom) and a song and dance routine; this routine itself is indicative of the acceptability of the trope both within the story as well as to the viewers. Now, consider this as a prelude to the influence that later Bollywood movies probably exerted over the Indian-origin man arrested in Australia on charges of stalking. The masculine belief that access, not to consent, but to a woman's sexuality can be obtained in ways that still do not pose an ethical problem, is sustained based on *faith* in the resolve of masculine desire and a deep-seated inability in a woman to repel that desire. The idea of woman as embodying nature and its various quirks—not least of which is explained away through the archaic but still floating concept of hysteria and a woman's inability to cope with her sexuality—is something that is ancient and has evolved particularly to historical developments across time and space. As such, the relational essence of heterosexuality is essentially adversarial in which a man's pursuit of a woman is essentially in the way of a conquest. A conquest of *feminine* sexuality, which does not lend itself too easily to control, is very much like nature itself and hence, has to be similarly *opened up*. The trope of adversity and conquest in *Tum Mere Ho* is much more explicit and self-explanatory in Khan's struggles with his arch nemesis, the *nagin* (played by Kalpana Iyer; as per the industry norms in Bollywood, most human-snake hybrid creatures that end up bagging roles in movies happen to be females!). The mythical,

mystical creature that the *nagin* is, can only be defeated by magic, faith, and resolve (achievable through, among other things), the snake charmer's flute, and another conquered creature of nature, Shiva's pet snake, *Naagraj* (*Snake King/King of Snakes*). Shiva is an alpha male who is scoring all kinds of wins against nature! Some, he wants to win (conquer), some, he has to!

Woman as a conduit of mystical powers and natural forces, and her sexuality as one of the chief sources as well as means of wielding that power, is a cumulative perception that is normalized in various discourses, from men's rights activism to modern day witch-hunting, to explanations for romantic incompatibility. A most recent instance is the unfortunate death of budding actor Sushant Singh and the widespread public deliberation on the matter that has ensued following that event. Allegations about Singh's girlfriend Rhea Chakraborty—of being a gold digger and a disloyal partner—scaled a new low when she was branded a witch, engaging in *jaadu tona* (black magic) to trap eligible men. The attack was specific in pointing out Chakraborty's Bengali ethnicity while highlighting the fact that 'Bengali girls are dominating'. There is just too much load to unpack over here but, the obvious fetishization of a woman's sexuality and the dangers that would befall anyone who *misjudges* it turns all heterosexual pursuit into a conquest and a guilty pleasure for man. For him, a heterosexual desire is always under the shadow of a constant caveat of existential threat; the woman can be approached either by walking on eggshells or by proving the masculine mettle by taking nature (woman) on and following through to victory. Else, it is akin to riding the tigress. And thereby accrues the intensification of pleasure.

NOTES

1. 'A Man in Australia Accused of Stalking Women Blamed it on Bollywood.' *The Washington Post* (Dated 2 February 2015) . <https://www.google.com/amp/s/www.washingtonpost.com/news/world-views/wp/2015/02/02/a-man-in-australia-accused-of-stalking-women-blamed-it-on-bollywood-his-case-was-dismissed/%3foutputType=amp>
2. Ibid.

3. Ibid., p. 242.
4. Ibid., p. 243.
5. Ibid., pp. 23-4.
6. Ibid., p. 24.
7. Ibid., p. 45.
8. Commenting on the transformation of sexuality from the sixteenth century onwards, Foucault opines that sexuality henceforth, is no longer a relational concept but something that implicates the entire body. This obfuscation of sexuality as contingent and discursive, and concomitantly its projection as a universal truth, is achieved through what Foucault describes as the global organization of the desiring body. Henceforth, sexual relation is progressively displaced by the desiring body—a truth unto itself—as the site of intervention and as the basic unit of analysis. From a critical approach then, it has to be noted that sexuality's relation to truth is not because sexuality is a gateway to truth but because the authority of truth is what grants access to sexuality. Certain mechanisms gain access to sexuality precisely based on their authority and recognition as true discourses (Foucault: 1996, 165-7).
9. Ibid., p. 30.
10. 'Why the "Last Tango in Paris" Rape Scene is Generating Such an Outcry Now.' *The Washington Post* (Dated 5 December 2016). <https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/arts-and-entertainment/wp/2016/12/05/why-the-last-tango-in-paris-rape-scene-is-generating-such-an-outcry-now/?outputType=amp>
11. Ibid.
12. Ibid.
13. Ibid.
14. Ibid., p. 14.
15. n. 10
16. In *Jayanti Rani Panda v. State Of W.B.* (1984) the Calcutta High Court passed a judgement on a rape plea brought in by a woman who was seduced into sexual intercourse on the promise of marriage but was instead abandoned by the accused when she became pregnant. The court rejected the plea because the committed act does not come within the meaning of *misconception of fact*; to qualify for the act to be considered as rape based on alleged misconception of fact, the promise made has to make the prosecutrix feel like she is already married (to the accused). But, it is an act of *promiscuity* if a 'full-grown girl' consents to have sex based on the promise of marriage at an unknown

time in the future. The court also iterated that to qualify as a misconception of fact, the said fact has to be of immediate relevance. It is no secret that in the course of investigation of rape charges, delay in complaining is often considered as suspect grounds for promiscuity and hence, embellishment of facts. Further, the test of misconception is made even tougher with an absurd requisite of belief in already having married; in this, the law finds itself a squeezed space of not acknowledging the fact of marital rape, while at the same time reinforcing the institution of marriage as sacrosanct by terming sex outside marriage as 'promiscuous'. But at the same time, the outrage and charge of rape brought in by the prosecutrix stems out of the ground as the law's, i.e. the permissibility of sex only within marriage.

17. 'Bawandar: Jagmohan Mundhra's Film Based on Rape Victim Bhanwari Devi Runs into Controversy.' *India Today* (Dated 10 December 2001). <https://www.indiatoday.in/magazine/society-the-arts/story/20011210-bawandar-jagmohan-mundhras-film-based-on-rape-victim-bhanwari-devi-runs-into-controversy-774890>, accessed on 10 December 2001.
18. Ibid.
19. Ibid.
20. For the sake of illustration, a few translations go as follows: '*humare kabile ki ladkiyan apne se zyada takatvar shauhar pasand karti hai. Woh apne aap ko itna aasani se le jane nahi deti, woh pehle nohti hai, kathti hai, maarti hai, yeh kaam itna aasan nahi hai...*' (the girls of our tribe have a penchant for husbands who are stronger than them. They (girls) don't concede so easily, first they scratch, then they bite, they hit, this is not an easy task at all...).
21. The image of the hero carrying away the heroine on his shoulders is a vision that has often been used in Hindi movies as an indicator of the strength of true love but also of a difficult situation in which consent, either of the heroine, or her family, or both, is not easily forthcoming. Consider the famous poster of the *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* (1995).

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Judgement

Jayanti Rani Panda v. State Of W.B. [1984 Crlj 1535] (available at: <https://indiankanoon.org/doc/607485/>).

CHAPTER 2

Hindi Cinema and Caste Question Ideology and Reproduction of Dominance

MANOJ KUMAR JENA

INTRODUCTION

Cinema evolved out of photographic and sound technology as well as the convergence of all techniques and skills of artistic form. Cinema also incorporates different technologies in production, including cinematography, editing, location and sound. Its main form is cinematography, which expedites the process of visual storytelling to the audience with sound. It is an expressive art of reality and imagination. Stanley Cavell (1979) argues that ‘the world of moving picture is screened’. He also argues that ‘the screen *is* a frame; the frame is the whole field of the screen—as a frame of film is the whole field of a photograph, like the frame of a loom or a house’.¹ As Gilles Deleuze rightly said, ‘the cinema does not just present images; it surrounds them with a world’.² Cinema, as a powerful communicative medium carrying messages with embedded meaning, can influence the mind, body and soul of any individual and community at large. Cinema is a reflector of social reality; it mirrors the social transformations, cultural relations/tensions and new trends that are surfacing in society in significant ways. ‘The history of cinema aligned early on with the epistemic and pragmatic concerns of industrial labour and capital accumulation. Not surprisingly, one of the first films made by Auguste and Louis Lumière—the Frenchmen known for their invention of the *cinématographe*—portrayed a group of workers (mostly females) marching out the gate to the brothers’ factory in the Lyon suburbs’.³ ‘Moving pictures appeared in

the major cities of the British Empire in the late nineteenth century, while they were being introduced in Europe and North America. Over the first two decades of the twentieth century, the medium spread from the large urban centres of the West Indies, India, southern Africa, and British Malaya into provincial towns and villages. By the end of the First World War, 'going to the pictures' had become a fixture of public leisure for hundreds of thousands of imperial subjects, who were seeing movies in a wide array of urban and rural venues'.⁴

Cinema is a vital adjunct of the public sphere moulding the views, attitudes and opinions of the vast movie-going public.⁵ Furthermore, cinema establishes a relationship between capital and consumers; content creators are producers (capital), and audiences are sometimes seen as potential consumers in the cinema industry. Cinematic expression has always been associated with culture, language, myth, experience, and desire and has also reinforced belief, morality, ethics and work as a persuasive instrumental role in society at large. Cinema/Movies/Films often function in an ideological role in society where cinematic content carries a specific kind of meaning and fosters a particular state of mind. Movies, which carry images through cinematic production, further influence audiences at both conscious and unconscious levels. There has been a strong connection between cinema and public culture since the very beginning of the industrialization and modernization process in the West and India. In India, cinema has been playing a vital role in disseminating an urban consciousness; facilitating the transition from feudal and agricultural societies to urban and industrial societies; and from there to consumer and postmodernist societies. Cinema has been a facilitator of social transformation in India in complex ways.⁶ The cinematic medium influences and shapes public opinion and is also oriented toward public awareness and concern with public issues. Cinema has modified and reinforced structural change, maintaining and redefining cultural traits and patterns in society at large and further bringing structural transformation within and outside of society. Media commentators argue that the development of Media/Movies/Cinema is interlinked with institutional transformation, which is one of the factors shaping modern society. In this context

the chapter studies Hindi Cinema from a sociological vantage point, particularly Hindi cinema has also been studied as an institution and art form, as well as for its social, cultural and ideological role in society. Additionally, the chapter tries to understand narration, image/photography, the power of visual imagery, technology and creative processes. Furthermore, it has addressed the questions of ideology and reproduction of caste domination in Hindi Cinema.

*Sociology of Cinema and Society:
Culture and Consciousness*

As discussed earlier, Cinema is an integral and embedded aspect of our social life and can be seen as a taken-for-granted reality for many people. In modern industrial settings, Cinema/Movies are perceived as text and medium and are associated with technology that is evolving every other day. Cinematic production has always been intertwined with our sociocultural and political imagination, including economic activities. As Turner argues, Cinema is integrated with larger cultural production. 'Culture' came to be redefined as the processes that construct a society's way of life: its systems for producing meaning, sense, or consciousness, especially those systems and media of representation that give images their cultural significance.⁷ Likewise, consciousness itself thus results from a relationship between identification with and the taking in or introjection of signs (like a name), terms, and concepts that shape and mould behaviours and identity. Signs and symbols are thus the hallmark of consciousness more than some essence of personhood.⁸ Whether it is cinema, theatre, literature, the printing press, or television to the internet, all communicative media are integral parts of the cultural system. It not only reverberates our thought categories but also enhances and enables us to interpret, reinterpret, perceive and know about ourselves and others. Moreover, it functioned as an amplifier in a time-space sequence. Various forms of media, including symbols, signs, language, literature, images, and visual imagery, are the most dominant and determinant powerful forces for bringing change in society. For Graeme Turner (1999), 'Film as a social practice, and the understanding of its production and consumption, its pleasures and

its meanings, is enclosed within the study of the workings of culture itself'.⁹ His argument centred around the social process of making images, sounds and signs.

Cinema/movies have always been an enabling factor for new forms of social action within and outside geographical boundaries, and they have a large global impact. Siegfried Kracauer argues that 'Film actually reproduces the raw material of the physical world within the work of art'.¹⁰ It is a cultural product and is shaped by the inner dimension of individual life, even community life at large. One can analyse from Adorno, Fromm, Horkheimer and Marcuse's points of view the socio-psychological dimension of relations between individuals and culture in particular.¹¹ One can comprehend, how there is a direct link between people's lives and cultural context. Therefore, to argue, Cinema shapes perception with a specific ideological base to form and conform to the submissive self. One can argue that Cinema produces particular kinds of self that are subservient to the dominant system. They are passive consumers and saleable products. One can perceive how the cultural domination of Hindi cinema produces a subservient and passive self when it is marginal. What Adorno argues about the end of individualism in the contemporary period. In a critical sense, the contemporary order overpowers individuals through standardized, monotonous mass culture, leaving little room for genuine individualism. The cinema and culture industry essentially fulfils all the need for control and repression. Cinema also gives rise to different kinds of authoritarian structures, cultivating particular types of what Horkheimer and Adorno called 'Sado-masochistic character'.¹² Contemporary cinema produces and reproduces dominant characters normalizing violence and subjugation through various genres.

In the contemporary phase, the gravity, intensity and reach of media, particularly cinema, have strengthened in many ways. It not only mediates social relationships but also takes the front stage to socialize every aspect of life. The social structure and process are encompassed by the culture of mediation, which is embedded with messages and meaning. Various media outlets are continuously disseminating information and misinformation, to sizeable and

diversified audiences in Indian society. These messages certainly influence many aspects of social, political and economic patterns.

Cinematic Power, Image and Meaning

As in any human relationship projected on a screen, film narratives are mostly subject to the complexity, spontaneity, and level of sophistication that the relation with the 'other' requires.¹³ Cinematic significance is associated with the combination of the camera technique of framing, the angle of the camera, the depth of field, the composition and the size of the aperture. Similarly, for Turner,

images, as well as words, carry connotations. A filmed image of a man will have a denotative dimension—it will refer to the mental concept of 'man'. However, images are culturally charged; the camera angle employed, his position within the frame, the use of lighting to highlight certain aspects, and any effect achieved by colour, tinting, or processing all have the potential for social meaning. When we deal with images, it is especially apparent that we are not only dealing with the object or the concept they represent but also dealing with how they are represented.¹⁴

Camera angles can identify a shot with a character's point of view by taking a position that corresponds to that which we imagine the particular character would be occupying. We see what the character would be seeing.¹⁵ The camera can be viewed as a power of mingling with an image, and the movement of an image is connected with cinematic expression. In Hindi Movies, the position of the camera angle represents the dominant position of a particular person who represents the upper echelon of society. Representation of a particular marginal image on a cinematic screen reproduces identical cultural traits for instance, about their livelihood, appearance, location and occupation. Cinematic narration is another powerful element of a cinematic screen. Which influenced the audience's mind? Within a specific period, audience engagement with the silver screen establishes intrinsic bonding. In the dark room, which is only on a silver screen, cinema narrates the story that the audience assumes to be the real story and not the reel story. In this situation, individuals are completely engrossed with the sound, image and frame of

the cinematic screen. Cinema narrates and tells a story about our physical and existential world. However, who tells the story in what context and to whom matters a lot. This question prevents all media sociologists from answering how this happens. 'Film is uniquely equipped to record and reveal physical reality and hence gravitates towards it'.¹⁶ According to Turner,

With the development of cinematic technique, a screen became a power source where the life on the screen was life and the audience engages themselves with this powerful expressive medium. Therefore, the film incorporates the separate technologies and discourses of the camera, lighting, editing, set design, and sound—all contributing to the meaning.¹⁷ Furthermore, 'the positioning of the camera is possibly the most apparent of the practices and technologies which contribute to the making of a film'.¹⁸

Hindi Cinema and the Emergence of a Dominant Cultural System

The Indian cinema industry, which is now the largest in the world in terms of the quantity of output, has traversed a long course, marked by the forgotten efforts of countless people and the faded signs of innumerable phases and trends.¹⁹ Hindi Cinema (popularly known as Bollywood cinema) is one of the dominant language cinema types in India and has influenced our perceptions of culture and the construction of cinematic reality. Indian cinema is diverse in terms of language and cultural setting. Cinema is produced in various languages in India, ranging from Jammu & Kashmir to Tamil Nadu and from Gujarat to Assam. India is the largest producer of cinema in South Asia.

The Bombay film/Hindi Film industry is aesthetically and culturally distinct from Hollywood, but as prolific and ubiquitous in its production and circulation of narratives and images. As the dominant media institution within India, the Bombay film industry plays an important role in constructing and defining dichotomies such as 'traditional/modern', 'global/local', 'Western/Eastern' and categories such as 'culture', 'nation', and 'Indian'.²⁰

The history of the Indian film industry is quite fascinating. Cinema arrived in India at a time when rapid population growth was creating an archipelago of sprawling, polyglot metropolises across the

subcontinent. These cities are remarkable for their ethnic, religious, and cultural diversity.²¹ Cinematic screens have a long history in India. Cinema was shown for the first time in India by the Lumière brothers on 7 July 1896 at the Watson Hotel in Mumbai. This was just six months after the first show in Paris (the Lumière brothers who invented the cinematography started the projection of short films for the Parisian public on 28 November 1895).²² *The Times of India* glowingly referred to it as the ‘miracle of the century’. Westerners, who were quick to realize the value of India as a site of filmmaking because of both its natural beauty and its ‘exotic’ culture, were inspired to make films that used Indian scenery and culture—for example, *Coconut Fair* (1897), *Our Indian Empire* (1897), *A Panorama of Indian Scenes and Procession* (1898) and *Poona Races ‘98’* (1898).²³ The earliest short films to be photographed in India were by unknown foreign cameramen in 1897. An Indian ventured to make his short films in 1899. India’s first narrative feature came in 1912. The Indian talkie film arrived in 1931.²⁴

In India, at least 80 per cent of films shown in the late 1920s were American, even though twenty-one studios manufactured local films, eight or nine of them in regular production. Although its narrow range of distribution restricted its cinematic and social influence, Indian film production later burgeoned, with production levels exceeding those of any other country, including the United States, from the 1970s on.²⁵

The Hindi movies content is distinct in terms of its ‘linguistic, regional, religious, and caste origins and the identities of its members; what is striking is the intensification of kinship networks within the contemporary industry’.²⁶ Hindi Cinema/Movies in India has been considered a dominant, influential and persuasive medium since the very beginning, in fact since the production and release of *Raja Harishchandra* by Dadasaheb Phalke on 3 May 1913. Hindi Cinema Industry has extended its tentacle; one may view it as an ‘ideological octopus’ in and around both the Hindi-speaking and non-Hindi-speaking states of India. The Hindi Cinema industry is one of the prominent infotainment mediums for the general masses as it produces various genres of movies each year. The Hindi Movies elucidate contrasting realities and myriad circumstances carrying contradicting meaning. Movies also bring cinematic genres

of various kinds. Samir Dayal argues that 'Hindi cinema has been, to change metaphors, a dream machine, producing images of collective or national identity that, with every iteration, prove more transitional, contradictory, and elusive or enable us to screen truths about ourselves from ourselves'.²⁷ Hindi cinema, is particularly, popular or 'hit' films, stars and songs, irrespective of their artistic merits. These films have become part of contemporary Indian folklore. The songs in them are sung by generations, the idioms used by millions of people.²⁸ Bollywood, particularly Hindi cinema, controls the culture, language, and style idioms of everyday imaginary of individuals. The viewers are perpetually influenced by Bollywood cinema, which has an enormous impact on larger Hindi and non-Hindi audiences.

*Ideology and Cinematic Communication:
Reproduction of Caste/Class Domination*

It is argued that Hindi Cinematic communication produces a dominant ideological pattern that negates marginal subjects. Ideology arises in association with processes of communication and exchange. Ideology involves the reproduction of the existing relations of production. Ideology operates as a constraint, limiting us to certain places or positions within these processes of communication and exchange.²⁹ Furthermore, ideology refers to sets of ideas that give some account of the social world; ideas that are usually partial (in both senses) or selective (as all positions are); and the relationship of these ideas or values to how power is distributed socially.³⁰

Marx and Engel argue that ruling ideas are nothing more than the ideal expression of dominant material relations; the dominant material relations grasped as ideas; hence of the relations which make the one class the ruling one, therefore the idea of its dominance.³¹

For Raymond Williams (1977), ideology is defined as (i) a system of beliefs characteristic of a particular class or group, (ii) a system of illusory beliefs—false ideas or false consciousness—which can be contrasted with true or scientific knowledge; (iii) the general process of the production of meanings and ideas.³²

From William's point of view, Hindi cinema produces a particular

dominant kind of belief pattern of upper class/caste essence and appearance.

Alen Swingewood argues

ideology becomes of crucial importance for the value associated with mass production and consumption of comics, pulp fiction and newspapers combine effect of television, cinema and radio corrupt and deradicalize the proletariat. For him sociologically mass society lacking strong, independent social groups and institutions, a society dominated from above.³³

For Bill Nichols, ideology uses the fabrication of images and the processes of representation to persuade us how things are, how they ought to be and that the place provided for us is the place we ought to have.³⁴ For Althusser ideology is associated with Ideological State Apparatuses. For him, 'The Ideological State Apparatuses (ISA) function massively and predominantly *by ideology*, but they also function secondarily by repression, even if ultimately, but only ultimately, this is very attenuated and concealed, even symbolic.'³⁵ Bill argues, 'the dominant ideology, representing the ideas of the dominant class to perpetuate its dominance through the psychic and material investments we are led to make as signs of acquiescence, has the upper hand.'³⁶ Most 'Ideological theories stress that all communication and all meanings have a socio-political dimension and that they cannot be understood outside their social context. This ideological work always favours the status quo, for the classes with power dominate the production and distribution not only of goods but also of ideas and meanings'.³⁷ In a sense Hindi Cinema industry is in a vortex of the Class and Caste nexus, the meaning and ideas produced largely from dominant caste/class perspectives with ideological domination. The economic system is organized in their interest, and the ideological system derives from it and works to promote, naturalize, and disguise it. Whatever their differences, all ideological theories agree that ideology works to maintain class domination³⁸. One can see in the Indian context how ideology maintains class and caste domination. For instance, the production of specific ideological cinema is making the individual a passive recipient, what Herbert Marcuse argues about one-dimensional thought which eliminates alternative ideas, may be encouraging

exploitative practices. Herbert Marcuse also argues that 'the products indoctrinate and manipulate; they promote a false consciousness which is immune against its falsehood'.³⁹ Marcuse states that idea 'emerges a pattern of one-dimensional thought and behaviour'.⁴⁰ One can also see how the logic of caste, capital and cinema is associated with cinematic content and image. Many a time Hindi Cinema is producing one-dimensional content. In fact, hegemonic, hierarchical relations operates in a deep unconscious level, where the cinematic message and meaning play the lead role. It furtherance 'repressive structuring', which Marcuse called 'surplus repression', because of asymmetric relations of power through the exploitative process.⁴¹ Cinema can be seen as a force of cultural domination; from Marcuse's point of view, in the age of mass consumerism and popular culture, a new social order has emerged that sharply curtails individuality, dissent and opposition.⁴²

As Jean-Louis Baudry puts it,

[cinema] constitutes the subject by the illusory delimitation of a central location—whether this be that of a God or of any other substitute. It is an apparatus destined to obtain a precise ideological effect, necessary to the dominant ideology: creating a *fantasmaticization* of the subject, it collaborates with a marked efficacy in the maintenance of idealism.⁴³

Movies/Cinema can appeal to the imagination and engage in emotions; the viewer may not only watch the unfolding screenplay but also participate in it. S/he will often identify with one of the characters, and the result of the experience may be that the viewer may learn something about what he/she feels like to stand in the shoes of a person of a different time, nationality, ethnic group, or other situation vastly dissimilar to his or her own (such as a lower-class ghetto).⁴⁴ Cinema factory also exercise power over individuals through various genres, and individuals internalize structures and reproduce them the same way. The power structure is caste- and class-specific and governs the industry and its relationships. Cinema can be seen as the 'product of social conditioning'.⁴⁵ It is embedded with a hegemonic group of capitalist cine players. Additionally, the audience has varying degrees of freedom to construct relationships with the individual texts of the medium or with the medium as a

whole. Individuals can deeply move (for better or worse) by what they see and hear on the screen.⁴⁶ Social order is thus augmented by the ideological domination of a ruling class that effectively controls and, in many cases, owns the mass media.⁴⁷

Most of the Hindi movies portrayed kinds of stereotyped ideals and images of Marginals particularly Scheduled Caste. Historically, Marginals, particularly Scheduled Caste/Dalit, are composed of mostly exploited, discriminated and subjugated people in India. For a very long time, this group was systematically excluded from the cinematic production process as well as from larger cultural production processes, including those in the cultural sphere. It is perceived that Hindi movies reproduce hegemonic dominant cultural traits that contradict Marginal life. Caste discrimination, subjugation and exploitation, as well as normalization of violence, can be observed in contemporary Hindi cinematic images; for instance, *Aakrosh* (2010) and *Chauranga* (2014) to *Article 15* (2019). The construction of the stereotype Marginal/Dalit identity is nurtured and cultivated continuously on the Hindi Cinematic screen. Caste/Class feudal and hegemonic domination is visible in the cinematic production of content. The ideology used in cinema is primarily concerned with specific kinds of dominant ideas and values; specifically, the image of the oppressor has been internalized and homogenized through cinematic content. Paulo Freire rightly argued that the oppressed, having internalized the image of the oppressor and adopting his guidelines, are fearful of freedom.⁴⁸ Paulo Freire further argues that cultural invasion is, on the one hand, an *instrument* of domination and, on the other hand, the *result* of domination; furthermore, cultural invasion serves the ends of conquest and the preservation of oppression.⁴⁹ One can see how contemporary hegemonic Hindi cinema has invaded the entire cultural sphere of marginals. Hindi Cinema combines domination, self, identity and the significance of one's emotional life. It much more reverberates with fictitious ecstasy, false pleasure and repression. Therefore, the content of the cinema needs to be analysed and understood through the ideology and political economy of the Hindi Cinema industry. The following questions arise: who is the producer and controller of the medium, message and meaning, and how is it emotionally significant? One

cannot negate the psychological impact of content and image. From the psychoanalytic perspective of the unconscious, selfhood socialization is linked with cinematic production, which is also a critical question for Hindi Cinema. Frankfurt school theorist Adorno and others have argued that psychoanalysis and identity formation can be contextualized in the context of cinema. From Jacques Lacan's point of view, the realm of ideology through traumatic film encounters the real. The issue of power is central to this text, as is the imbricated issue of powerlessness or *jouissance*.⁵⁰ How the script writer or cinematic product creates content that reflects the internal landscape of identity formation impacts cultural and social relations. Cinema also plays a central ideological role in practice and products and is also a source of conformation of inequality in society. The caste inequality is reproduced and translated in movie messages and media practices. As earlier argued Hindi Cinema is associated with a larger logic of caste and capital structure, and the content of Hindi Cinema serves a specific caste/class interest. Many a time, Hindi movies produce one-dimensional cinema and hesitate to challenge the dominant ideology. Few movies have attempted to challenge domination but have faced numerous impediments.

For instance, Sanjiv Jaiswal, maker of *Shudra: The Rising* and *Quota: The Reservation*, back in 2012, narrates his experience as an alternative movie maker.

When we made the film *Shudra: The Rising*, we faced innumerable challenges and obstacles. After its release, the audience appreciated it, and we even got global acclaim. Our recent film *Quota: The Reservation*, which was based on Dalit discrimination faced in elite institutions, surpassed expectations and went on to win global awards. However, we did not get screens to give it a theatrical release, owing to the hesitancy still present. Finally, we had to release it on OTT and received much-deserved reach.⁵¹

This is a critical issue, as not receiving enough screens, particularly from the distributor side, will create a situation of control and command. Controlling the space is itself as good as controlling public culture as well as messaging and meaning, including the lives of individuals and communities. Many a time message and meaning do not emerge from democratic or social consensus but rather from the

dominant class/caste perspective. The prescribed values and ideas are seen as the weapon used by the dominant group over the marginals. For instance, reinforcing stereotypes, enforcing exploitative practices, normalizing violence and suppressing marginals. Caste and class hierarchical ordering of social structure is rooted in Hindi cinematic culture. The world of everyday cinema is embedded with a 'matrix of domination',⁵² particularly a matrix of caste and class domination. Hindi cinematic narratives are an undetached aspect of Indian socio-cultural life. Cinema also carries symbolic code and meaning through images and content to denigrate Marginals particularly scheduled castes/Dalits. There is also a 'language' for visual representation, sets of codes and conventions used by the audience to make sense of what they see. Many Hindi movies constantly use derogatory language for Dalit's such as *Neech*, (Wretched) *Neech Jati*, for instance, *Chauranga* (2014), and *Article 15* (2019). For instance, Priyadarshan directed *Aakrosh's* (2010) storyline, in which the content and image of the movie portray the idea of caste dominance and honour killing. The plot revolves around intercaste marriage, control of women's bodies, patriarchy and caste discrimination and violence against Dalits. Depiction of the caste killing and hegemony of upper caste/class in India, consciously and unconsciously influence the audience. Priyadarshan's characterization of dominant caste image particularly the idea of the upper caste hero as the saviour has been normalized in Hindi Cinema. The main protagonist is the upper caste Sidharth Chaturvedi, a Dalit, Major Pratap Kumar a supporting actor, who also suffered through the caste system. Even after having a meritorious career, he could not marry the daughter of the upper caste teacher because of the fear of caste atrocities and subjugation (his father refused due to fear of caste punishment). This movie stereotyped a particular ideological form and identity formation; the images depicted in the movies about Dalits are from *Neech*, and they are not supposed to drink water from *Dudh Kuan* (Milk Well); they must take water from *Kala Kuan* (Dirty/Black Well). *Kala Kuan* is produced by a specific symbolic system. The binary of *Kala Kuan* and *Dudh Kuan* is the depiction of what Louis Dumont called purity and pollution.

Sanjiv Jaiswal's directorial movie *Sudra: The Rising* (2012) is a

different genre depicting the image of Dalit exploitation and untouchability. This is a historical periodic film and historical analysis of Sudra exploitation. The narration and framing of stories are interesting in many ways. Such as violence and exploitation of Dalit women. This Hindi language film is based on the storyline of the caste system. Exploitation, subjugation and sexual assault of Dalit women. Depiction of agony, pain and suffering. Images and narrations of movies reinforce the unconscious aspects of caste systems. Disturbing images, landless Dalits, and use of work, the film *Neech Jati* depicts the reality of the caste system in India. Water and sacred wells are important components of movies.

Chauranga (2014), by Bikas Rajan Mishra, depicted the relationships among caste exploitation, women's bodies and violence against lower caste. It has been observed that many a time, the movie maker stereotyped the scheduled caste with animal considered dirty. They reinforce the lower caste marginal identity with foul and filthy substance. Symbolic representations of Dalits are impure stereotypes in cinemas. This movie depicts the story of reinforcement of subjugation, killing a Dalit boy for writing a love letter to an upper caste girl. Caste profiling and the production of particular caste stereotypes in cinema further reinforce caste discrimination and inequality; for instance, *Chauranga* (2014) described the image of pig *suars* and the relationships of pigs with Dalits. Most of the Hindi movies stereotyped specific images about Dalits and constant use and abuse of the words *Neech Jati* and lower caste, etc., had very strong impact on individuals and the community. It is essential to understand how the upper echelon operates in Indian society through the production of a symbolic cultural system and the formation of identity

Dhadak (2018): This movie was adopted and based on *Sairat* blockbuster Marathi movie. The story is based on an inter caste love story where a marginal boy falls in love with an upper caste girl whose father is a dominant politician. Finally, the story goes with a fight and struggle for love and life. Ultimately, the father killed the marginal boy and his son. It is depressing and shows a particular way to hegemonies the upper caste ideas. The difference between the two Marathi movies is depicted realistically. It's story about marginal men and upper-caste women. *Dhadak's* end is truly chilling and disturbing

the killing of both man and his son; this image itself is disturbing; on the one hand, it depicts the story of the justification of honour killing and on the other killing by Dalits as a normalization phenomenon.

Article 15 (2019): Non Dalit is the protagonist; specifically, the upper caste hero is the saviour. The film is a stereotypical imagination of an upper caste filmmaker, and the imagination lacks the lived reality of Dalits. It is a simplification of the generalized narrative and does not cover the full scope of Dalit emancipation. The frame of the image is completely stereotyped, justifying the dominant ideas that, *Sab Barabar Honge to Raja Koun Banega* (if everyone is equal who will be the king); for *Santulan* (balance), the stratification is justifiable.

All these movie narratives are centred around negation, exploitation and subjugation as well as the reproduction of domination. Hindi movies are more or less a one-dimensional cinema that is associated with caste and capital and has been producing a repressive ideology of subjugation rather than emancipation. Nichols rightly argues that 'Imaginary here does not mean unreal, existing only in the imagination, but rather pertains to views, images, fictions, or representations that contribute to our sense of who we are and to our everyday engagement with the world around us.'⁵³

Contemporary Hindi cinema construct particular kinds of identities. The symbolic code and symbolic system facilitate a particular kind of identity. From Lacan's point of view, identity is the result of a complex and dialectical relationship between the real conditions of the individual body and the environment, the social-symbolic system that it is situated within, and the individual's own dynamic history at the juncture of the two. The social-symbolic system thus plays an enormous role in the construction and maintenance of identity.⁵⁴ The problem of the current cinema consciously and unconsciously negates the emancipation of marginal precisely Dalits. The Dalit has never been a dominant subject; rarely, one finds a Dalit protagonist in the Hindi Cinema. However, to some extent, southern cinema does quite well. Recently, most of the blockbuster Hindi cinema has centred around upper caste/class dominant majoritarian identity. Contemporary blockbuster commercial successful movies produced by various production houses include upper class/caste charters and stories; for instance, *Dabangg*

(2010), *Tanu Weds Manu* (2011), *Dum Laga Ke Haisha* (2015), *Jolly LLB 2* (2017), *Bajrangi Bhaijaan* (2015), *Badhai Ho* (2018), *Dream Girl* (2019), *Article 15* (2019), and *Pati Patni Aur Who* (2019) mostly represent upper caste/class identity. *Dabang* (2010) to *Article 15* (2019), most of the protagonists carry upper-caste cultural values. In the Lacanian sense, it is reinforcing upper caste/class cultural values in totality. This symbolizes how Indian popular culture is embedded with upper caste/class norms and values. In a certain sense, it reinforces existing caste identities. This also indicates that the upper caste/class identity is the most saleable commodity in the Hindi movie market what Stuart Hall argues about the 'dominant hegemonic position.'⁵⁵ This is the normalization of particular cultural identities on the Hindi cinematic screen, essentially by producing, packaging and marketing upper caste/class essence and minimizing marginals. In a sense, Indian cinema reinforces class/caste-centric ideological stereotypes among the national audience, which is antithetical to the life and reality of the marginal. The conditions of marginality in relation to the production of meaning in the cultural sphere is an important question for marginal. Although marginal has had its own cultural text, that text was systematically marginalized through historical exploitation. The lack of substantial representation of Dalits in Hindi Cinema questions cultural rights in public culture. Cultural exclusion of Dalits is a historical question, and the structure has been shaped such that it exploits and excludes Dalits. Even today, visible exploitative practices have a strong historical link with caste structure and functions.

Cinema ideologically constructs the stereotypes of caste hegemony. In the case of Hindi Cinema, the caste/class and capital merged, and the upper caste and class controlled everything; they controlled the medium, message and meaning. In a sense, they are part of the production of messages and meaning. One-dimensional cinema produces a particular ideology bent of mind that negates the alternative.

CONCLUSION

Hindi cinema, is a symbolic system and an institution in India essentially associated with medium, message and meaning. The

control of the medium, power of messaging and meaning is a crucial factor in the cinema industry in India. It has been observed that Hindi Cinema storylines are centred around upper class/caste narratives. It reproduces a specific class and caste ideology. In Althusser's sense it is ideological state apparatus. The political economy of the Hindi film industry encompasses and represents the upper echelon of the Indian social structure. The Hindi cinema storytellers and production houses are always glorifying upper class/caste ideas. The cinematic medium represents the essence and appearance of the upper strata of society. It has been observed that for a long, most of the blockbusters (maximum viewership) have essentially propagated upper class/caste normative order.

Hindi movies do not dare to break ideological domination. Repression, subjugation and violence against Dalits is routinely normalized in cinematic reels. The representation of violence and subjugation reinforce similar kinds of stereotypes in different locations. Moreover, contemporary content writers do not dare to break stereotypes but rather reinforce them. However, there are exceptions in the case of cinema in southern India, which try to break dominant ideological barriers, for instance, Pa. Ranjith's *Kaala* (2018).

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Realities of the Marginal Worker as Reflected in the Medium of Cinema

M.M. REHMAN AND KANTA REHMAN

INTRODUCTION

Cinema has become a very powerful medium to study, examine and reflect our realities of existence. Ever since its appearance in India, the medium has been used to entertain, educate and disseminate information in a dramatic form and in a most effective manner. Dadasaheb Phalke who learned the craft in England, made the first film in 1913, titled *Raja Harishchandra*. And since then, the medium has been endlessly essaying in dramatic form many aspects of society in the country. In India, the social realities are very complex. The complexity has become very complicated over the centuries/millennia. The apparent social structure could be examined from two terms of reference among others, rather simplistically. The terms are 'the advantaged' and 'the disadvantaged groups'. Here in this essay, an attempt has been made to study and examine how the literature of cinema has taken the issues regarding the disadvantaged sections of the society in India. Here, the disadvantaged sections of Indian society are termed as marginals, to examine realities as reflected in some motion pictures produced over the decades.

Initially, cinema was a medium of entertainment. But gradually it became a powerful analytical tool for examining and reflecting the conditions of the marginal of the society. The marginal are identified

as the 'Dalits', the sex workers, the disadvantaged workers like the agricultural labourers, the distressed marginal farmers, the slum dwellers, the street vendors, small artists and many others. The Indian cinematic literature has been studying and examining the conditions of these sections over the decades and the medium is trying to also send messages that the emerging society looks forward to. In this chapter, an attempt is made to see this aspect.

This chapter provides an overview of the cinema industry and examines how some films reflect and narrate the realities of the existence of some marginalized groups in Indian society.

HISTORICAL PERSPECTIVE

It was 132 years ago, i.e., on 7 July 1892, the first film show was arranged by the agents of two French brothers, Louis and Auguste Lumière, at Watson Hotel in Bombay.¹ The show was hailed as the marvel of the century. Another landmark was the construction of the first cinema hall in India in Calcutta in 1907. The hall was known as Elphinstone Picture Palace built by J.F. Madan. Cinema was born abroad i.e., in England. The technique of film production was not known to the Indians initially. It was Dadasaheb Phalke who was the first foreign returned cine-technician. Dadasaheb learned the craft of filmmaking from Cecil Hepworth who was the prominent producer at Walton in England, in 1912. However, the turning event took place in 1912. It was in this year that the first film titled *Raja Harishchandra* was produced by Dadasaheb Phalke. This 3,700 feet length film was released on 3 May 1913, at the coronation cinematography in Bombay (now Mumbai). From then on, Bombay (henceforth Mumbai) nurtured and maintained by a veteran and pioneer like Dadasaheb Phalke, has occupied an important place in the industry. It is the first city where the film was produced and has remained as the dreamland of show business.

Beginning with a handful of people, today the 'industry' employs several lakh people. The industry is now spread over several states such as Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, West Bengal, Karnataka, Gujarat, Odisha, Kerala, Assam, Manipur, etc.

EARLIER MILIEU

Filmmaking began in India when the country was under the colonial regime. It was also a period when the freedom movement was beginning to peak. The country was witnessing an upsurge of expectations for freedom from the British Empire. The situation was, therefore, quite volatile. The empire was very cautious about allowing people to express their thoughts either through print or audiovisual mediums. Censorship was quite strict. The situation was aptly described by V. Shantaram. He writes:

In the old days, the Censors were more concerned with politics than morality. In 1930, I had to change the title of a film from *Swarajya* to *Uday Kal* to satisfy the foreign censors. With the advent of freedom, there was a natural shift towards puritanism. In their zeal to preserve our ancient traditions and culture, the censors became increasingly puritanical and moralistic in their outlook. However, one expected that, with time, the zeal would die away, just as the prejudices against the British have died away' (Shantaram: 1963).

Shantaram, however, expressed his dismay, that even after the independence, the situation had not improved. He said,

But censors have not been able to keep pace with the changing social conditions and manners. I, for one, would not plead for a license to show anything obscene or vulgar: but, at the same time, I would call upon the censors to be more rational and uniform in judging films (ibid., p. 110).

This indicates that there were and still are obstacles to filming subjects that may not be palatable to the existing power structure, and the reasons may be many. Therefore, subjects to be picturized have to adapt to the rules of the rulers. This is because ideas never die. In a segregated and differentiated socio-economic and political system, the call for justice and equality might be disconcerting to the advantaged groups and their power instrument. This is one side of the medium cinema and its expression from the supply angle. There is another side, i.e., the demand side. On the demand side is the audience. The audience decides which film should be viewed and which one not. And the members of the audience are free in their

choice. No one has any control over them. It is their money that helps the film industry to survive. As a result, filmmaking is a risky business; and investment in filmmaking is very huge even for a small film. Hence, the producers and the directors have to keep the choices of the audience in view. This way the suppliers are constrained. They will have to create a situation: you win, I win. However, it is not an easy choice. Mehboob Khan says very clearly while raising many problems of the industry:

Public taste influences the quality of films in as much as the producers, while making a film, is guided by the thought of making a commercially successful film—a film which will appeal to the majority of picturegoers. Most of the patrons of Indian films consist of lower-middle-class people and the labour masses who want song and dance and glamour and thrills and laughter and tears and melodrama, all in one film. And this line of entertainment is an ancient tradition with Indian masses... (Mehboob, 1963).

These are the pulls and pressures from both supply and demand sides that determine the type of stories to be turned into cinemas, because filmmaking is both a risky and costly business. Scores of people, like artists, technicians, directors, and a host of others like dress designers, and hairdressers are involved in making a film. Thus, the failure of a film means a heavy loss to the producers. There also have been moral concerns, i.e., cinema's influence on the ethos and ethics of society. Cinema has a powerful influence on people. Hence, the topics and storylines are expected, to a great extent, to have 'special approval'. This has been very clearly expressed by one of India's former Presidents, Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan. He says:

It is essential for all those connected with film production, whether they are directors, producers or actors and actresses, that they should resolve that they will not use their knowledge, their skill, their imaginative power, their artistic ability for any ends other than justice, freedom, peace and dignity; and they will not merely cater to the ruthless intent of certain individuals, who, in their anxiety to make profits, tend to corrupt human nature, degrade human beings and lower their tastes. That is a danger that we should like to avoid (Radhakrishnan: 1963).

All this has influenced filmmaking—the risks, profits, social situations, political structure and finally people's expectations. This is

brilliantly illustrated by Ingmar Bergman: 'The creator of the film involved as a means of expression which concerns not only himself but also millions of other people, and more than not he feels the same desire as other artists: 'I want to succeed today. I want to be a celebrity now. I want to please, to "delight, to move people immediately"'.

Midway between this desire and its realization is found the public, who demands but one thing of the film: 'I've paid, I want to be distracted, swept off my feet, involved; I want to forget my troubles, my family, my work, I want to get away from myself. Here I am, seated in the darkness, and like a woman about to give birth, I want deliverance.'

The filmmaker who is aware of these demands and who lives on the money of the public is placed in a situation which is difficult, and which creates obligations for him (1998) (quoted in Chanana: 1998).

The limitations of expressing through cinema are much more complex than any other medium. The writer of books, articles or stories need not invest so much money in the process of expressing her/his ideas. But cinema producers cannot take unlimited liberty because of money, profit and social and political 'permission' both 'covert and overt'.

Films are a form of literature. It is audiovisual literature that depicts any phenomenon in the most visually accurate manner. It can depict and describe any subject—physical and emotional. As we have noted in the beginning, in India the major focus of filmmaking was stories and ideas available in our written literature. And it was initiated with *Raja Harishchandra*, by Dadasaheb Phalke, the father of Indian Cinema.

However, after a long time, since the beginning of filmmaking in India, the issues and problems of workers, their workplace relations, organization and struggle began to get attention from some filmmakers both in the mainstream Hindi Cinema and in regional cinemas.

STUDY OF SELECTED HINDI CINEMA

Here an attempt has been made to examine some films produced in the medium of Hindi. The purpose is to see, to what extent, the films

narrated the existing conditions and what message they attempted to deliver by the directors and producers and to the audience.

Damul

One of the most exploited segments of workers in India is constituted by the bonded labourers. They existed in the far and long past; they still exist in thousands and they will continue to exist in future as well. In 1968, an act was passed to abolish the bonded labour system. But it has been so pernicious and resilient, that incidences of their exploitation is quite common. To highlight their plight, filmmaker Prakash Jha made the film. It was released in 1985. Helmed by talented actors like Deepti Naval, Annu Kapoor, Manohar Singh and others, the film narrated precarious and exploitative situations in which the bonded system is perpetuated. The important points which emerge from the narrative are that a sectarian social system, skewed distribution of land and uneven participation as owner and owner are responsible for the existence of the system of bonded labour. The bonded labourers, being the most marginalized, do not have much access to any institution for the redressal of their problems. They are unorganized and unregulated. The film narrates the plight and suffering of the bonded labourers in a very touching manner along with unravelling the complexity of socio-economic system. However, the film does not provide any way to escape the system. Intervention by some worker's organizations would have indicated that an attempt could be made to change the situation. The film describes a situation as it is along with many issues that contribute to the existence of bonded labour in India today.

Paar

The film *Paar* (Crossing) was made by Gautam Ghosh which depicted the cruel existence of a migrant couple in Calcutta (Kolkata). Helmed by Shabana Azmi and Nasiruddin Shah, the film narrates the difficulties faced by migrant workers who belong to the socio-economically disadvantaged groups in society. And being highly disadvantaged, often, they accept the most difficult, dirty and

dangerous/works/jobs (Shabana: 2012). This is amply illustrated in the film. Once again, the film does not show us any sign of redemption. A flicker of hope should have a great idea to be thrown into the narrative.

Coolie

One of the most unprotective groups of workers is constituted by the coolies (porter). They are engaged in carrying luggage of travelers. More often they are treated very badly by people who use their services. The film coolie depicts the realities of the lives of coolies who could be found in many large railway stations in India. The director narrates the living and working conditions of coolies and shows their struggles and achievements. The film finally tries to bring the socio-cultural milieu into perspective. The film starred Amitabh Bachchan, Kader Khan and others. It was directed by Manmohan Desai.

Kaala Patthar

This film was produced and directed by Yash Chopra and released in 1979. The film story is based on the tragic incident of an accident that took place in Chasnala in Dhanbad. Yash Chopra has tried to highlight the sufferings of the workers, engaged in coal mines and makes a point about how management is indifferent to workers' sufferings. This film starred Amitabh Bachchan and Rakhee.

Naxal

The film was directed and produced by K. Abbas and starred Mithun Chakraborty, Smita Patil and others. Abbas has tried to depict the problems and issues that led to the birth of the Naxalite movement. He highlighted the dynamics of a socio-economic system that was exploitative which led to rebellion. However, the film does not provide us with any trajectory which can help to change the socio-economic system.

Mirch Masala

The film was helmed by Naseeruddin Shah, Smita Patil and others. It was directed by Ketan Mehta. The film picturizes the oppression of poor women and their efforts to organize themselves to protect their honour and dignity. This film gives an idea of women's organizations and the technique for thwarting harassment by privileged people.

Importance of the medium, films unlike books could be read by anybody, literate and illiterate alike. It is a powerful means to disseminate information, either for simple knowledge or for entertainment and education which includes skills and ideas. Its impacts are immediate, and get internalized by many. It may encourage, may disappoint, may incite, negatively and positively. Thus, a filmmaker is constrained by factors like who are producing a film, either for profit only or for sending a social message. The power of films has been aptly noted by India's first President Dr Rajendra Prasad: 'As a medium of education, films have come to be looked upon as a vital factor the world over. In the more advanced countries of the West, films were being used for spreading education. I am sure we too, in India will be making the fullest use of films in educating our people' (Adarsh: 1963).

During the last several decades, we have witnessed several controversies and conflicts around several films, mostly related to films with historical backgrounds or films with a religious perspective. The controversy around the film *Padmavat* and earlier around the *Naxalite* are an example of constraints that the filmmakers have to take into consideration. People's choices and dignity as social and economic groups have to be respectfully protected.

Workers, especially the marginal segments, are exploited, oppressed and unorganized and sometimes disorganized. To articulate and express their situations through film narrative scientifically, one requires proper terms of reference and contexts. However, this is not an easy task. The most powerful organization in human society is the government/state. It perpetuates more often the dominant power and to maintain its power, it perpetuates the exploitative socio-economic and political systems. This conflict is inherent and unavoidable in the explanation and presentation of an exploitative

situation. The state power and its beneficiaries more often than not do like the truth of inequality and injustice to be narrated in films because films may tilt their boats.

Because of these constraints, not many feature films are produced in the country depicting the process of exploitation. Nevertheless, many attempts have been made by documentary filmmakers to narrate the plights and problems of marginal workers in the world in general and India in particular. As we have noted, cinema is powerful literature. Human and environmental situations are continuously narrated in a more visually realistic manner which influences human minds very effectively.

CONCLUSION

From the beginning of the making of films, the subjects of marginal workers were not in focus of the film literature. The initial filmmaking in India revolved around history and mythology. In the second wave, the filmmaking was more focused on social and personal relations and their complexities. Of course, the plot, often, highlighted the romantic nature of human lives and also narrated socio-economic conflicts in a socio-political situation. For example, the film *Naya Daur* illustrated the conflict between the use of automation and non-automated sources of livelihood. Many mainstream Hindi films also depicted the realities of farmers, agricultural labourers, migrant workers, vendors and others. However, little attempt has been made to picture the process of struggles of the marginal workers, the development of their organization and eventually and their salvation from their poverty. The films dealing with marginal workers portrayed them, i.e., the marginal workers as the victims, victimized by others. But the extent of victimization by their ignorance and efforts of their potential have not been adequately narrated in our films. Maybe this is an area in which films can make their foray.

NOTE

1. The dramatic turn in filmmaking took place in India with an exhibition of some films by two French brothers: Louis Lumière and Auguste

Lumière. One of the films which they exhibited was titled: Workers Leaving the Lumière Factory (La Sortie des ouvriers de Lusine). 'On 28 December 1895, the Lumières open the first movie theatre in history, showing several short films to a paying audience' (Kupsc: 1989).

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CHAPTER 4

Disability in Cinema

A Case Study of Selected Hindi Films

KURUKHETRA DIP

INTRODUCTION

Cinema is considered one of the most acceptable forms of art in the contemporary era. In cinema or through cinema, we can see what is happening in society and aspire for society through cinematic imagination. The study of films provides opportunities to connect history and technology vis-à-vis social changes and ideological impetus. Over time, cinema production has also gone through several changes due to changes in technological advancement. The relevance of watching traditional theatre is also changing due to the availability of DVDs/CDs and other online streaming mediums for watching movies. In other words, films or cinema is more accessible to general contours than ever before. With time, the study of films and film studies has also changed. Now many traditional disciplines like philosophy, political science, sociology, etc., are studying film/cinema from their disciplinary point of view.

Different disciplinary perspective gives a slightly different reading of a film. For example, 'Anthropology of Film' might integrate ethnography into films and read it as 'seeing culture' of a particular period or point in time. At the same time, from the 'sociological lens', the reading of the same movie might look upon the sociological aspects, i.e., gender, race, community, etc., interpreted in that. For instance, in the film *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* an anthropological argument would be how the Indian diaspora can inculcate their

cultural values, whereas from the sociological point of view, how 'patriarchy and power' work in modern/advanced society. In the history department, films can be viewed in their historical context. In the mass media and cultural studies departments, perhaps the cousins of *sociology* in terms of film analysis, the reader is asked to consider social and cultural powers in making a film and the film industry. Further, sociologists can engage in decoding a film and explain how films elicit structure and facilitate the expression of different emotions to which human are subjects to. Reading films with a sociological eye makes us conscious of ourselves as we watch movies. As we are being entertained, we are also introduced to the worldviews and social theories embedded in the films.

Sociological reading of films asks us to look beyond common sense thinking and long-held interpretations. If we take film/cinema as text or literature, it speaks a lot about social issues and turbulences that society experiences. In this context, cinema as literature is appreciable not because of its capacity to tell us a good story but rather how 'the scriptwriter' reflects and approaches the social context, social/psychological struggles, etc. One can understand a social class to which we generally do not belong and do not associate our feelings with it, through the vantage point provided in cinematic narratives. Like, a novel's interpretation lies on the readers; a movie's readings also depend on its audience. It depends on how the audience decodes it and how it imagines itself with the '*galaxy of images*' presented in a movie. Further, it also depends on how the audience thinks of movies as comprising visual languages, verbal systems, dialogue, characterization, narrative, and story (Slid: 2001, 3).

In artistic and expressive mediums, i.e., cinema and television¹ they use narratives with little tweaks that are already popular in larger imagination. The appearance of disabilities in these imaginations is quite different from physical disability and cognitive disorders. Physical disability appears to be a challenge and tragedy whereas, in the case of cognitive disorder, it appeals in a somewhat different role. Audiences are typically asked to respond in a restricted number of ways, ranging from sympathy or pity to some sort of charitable granting of limited personality to such characters. They avoid complicated characters and adopt a simple loving protagonist that

can be understandable, so the show will succeed in masses. Furthermore, these narratives ease the audiences about their idea of 'normalcy'. In many cases, if the movie's lead character is a 'cognitive disorder' or 'madness', i.e., depression, schizophrenia, etc., the protagonist becomes a tragic stand-in for its audiences. In this regard, Davis (32) argued that the line between tragedy and redemption, as well as between tragedy and comedy, seems to be blurred by obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD). In one scenario, the person with OCD is transformed into a cute little nut and called a disability 'mascot' (ibid.), and this mascotization of disability produces a loveable and cuddly representation of disability.

Similarly, if a side character has a disability and the movie is not about disability, then the viewers may be inattentive because of the disability narrative. In an ableist culture, they would question why the 'normalcy' of the movie is being altered. In this view, a disability is an allegory because it must represent something else, i.e., weakness, insecurity, bitterness, fragility, evil, innocence, etc., and be the setting for the moral lesson that people are good and can overcome obstacles, and that we shouldn't be prejudiced or dejected.

THEORETICAL CONUNDRUM

One can say that the semiotic code of cinema is the semiotic code of reality. The echoes of a similar argument can be found in canonical film theory as well as in the 'cognitive code' of reality given by Pasolini (1968). Representation in cinema is about allegorical interpretation rather than just being confined to the interpretative meaning of images. Cinema can be seen as a vehicle of abstraction, given that the symbolic meaning of the filmic image derives from the symbolic value of cinema. However, such inference is always in strain with the film's signifier and signified, which ensures that such a moment is not abstract but embodied. It is in this context,

One might suggest that the question posed by van Dormael's film is precisely how far the socially mediated concept of disability is perceived through the ontological assertion of bodies captured in cinematic representation intertwines with other concepts such as community nation and humanness (Fraser: 2016).

One has to acknowledge that, the thinking process influences our apprehension and our vision has an impact on knowledge. Through films, audiences may get an idea of how disability is deep-seated in a given social setting along with their encounter about how disability is socially mediated in other cultures. Whether perceived as negative, positive, or neutral, the individual and social forces that create and shape the appearance of a disability in cinema motivate those forces to act in the way they do. As Fraser (2016) also argued, the appearance of disability in movies and its portrayal in media always seem important but it never appealed to the global context.

No matter what the textures of cinematic representation discussed, and no matter where they unfold across the globe, it is in analysing, evaluating, and comprehending the ideas behind the creation and viewing of movies, it is via the interrogation of social formations of visual knowledge that viewers may move towards other ways of seeing. In this way, the worldwide cinema serves as the beginning of a discussion about representation, a process that naturally also takes place outside of the context of artistic debate in our day-to-day interactions with one another (Fraser: 2016) as Siebers' once said 'representation is the difference that makes a difference' (2008, 17).

Social representations necessarily mediate the cognitive codes we use to construct realities, and as such, they are also potentially impacted, shaped, grounded and re-calibrated by artistic representations. 'How do we accept peoples' belief systems, the attitudes, ideas, and conceptualization of people with disabilities?' The staging of disability for global audiences and readerships thus begins a meaningful conversation on attitudinal change. If 'disability enlarges our vision of human variation and difference' (Siebers: 2010, 3), then consideration of disability across world cinema contexts will have enlarged our world a great deal more indeed. In a global context, there are certain assertions in movies like *Oasis* (Lee Chang-dong, 2002) and disability discourse in New Wave Korean movies, that the fiction film spans 'two gendered modalities, simultaneously spotlighting a male crisis while anticipating a more expansive take on female subjectivity' (Fraser: 2016).

DISABILITY IN CINEMA

The understanding of Disability is quite tragic compared to other concepts used in social and political theory. In the time of enlightenment, and later philosophers/social theorists were quite in a corner to study disability from the preview of their theory or philosophy for that matter. Studying disability in concrete contexts of able-nationalism, Snyder and Mitchell's issue offered an opportunity for scholars to pursue a new paradigm for theorizing disability among other cross-cultural experiences of bodies identified as deviant (2010a, 119). They further argued that the problem with disability studies is that they transport theories and methodology from the Western academy to the other parts and give local disability structures and understandings barely passing consideration (2010, 219). Disability, as Siebers (2010, 4-5) wrote,

was present even if 'rarely recognized as such throughout the history of modern art, where the presence of disability of "strangeness" and the "convulsive"; of "misshapen and twisted bodies" allowed the beauty of artwork to endure over time'.

As a visual medium, cinema-like painting, and sculpture, for example, have not focused on the representation of bodies: bodies in specific locations, accurate and imagined.

DISABILITY NARRATIVES IN HINDI CINEMA

The majority of people in India misunderstand disability because of a lack of awareness and as a consequence, people with disability live in constant marginalization. Looking into this lack of awareness one can take the help of a representational medium that can provide a powerful platform for the dissemination of knowledge and reach out to the masses in a short period. In this context looking to the outreach of Bollywood or Hindi film industry, one can use it as an effective tool to connect people and sensitize about disability and its related stereotypes. Indian cinema in general and Hindi cinema in particular, in their earlier narratives, adopted a normative approach to 'fixing' disability, in which a disabled person is introduced to an able-bodied

person who teaches them how to put aside their impairment and leads happy lives. The following paragraphs offer some examples of such.

In early narratives, disability can be seen as a punishment (*Jeevan Naiya*, 1936; *Kashish*, 1980; *Dhaiwan*, 1981). But in *Netrikakan* (1981) the message was both punishment as well as desexualization of persons with disabilities. Another narrative is that being disabled is a worse punishment than death (*Sholay*, 1975). Apart from these narrations, disability can also be seen as stigma, mockery and restoration of normalcy (*Guzaarish*, 2010; *Koi... Mil Gaya*, 2003; *Pyare Mohan*, 2006; *Tom, Dick, and Harry*, 2006).

Until the 2000s, the representation of disability in Hindi films was very offensive, and caricatural in nature. Things have changed with the new wave of cinema, the representative narration changed, now it has become sensible and directly engaged with the subject. Even in the new wave cinema, certain films continue the old fashion. The primary objective is to use the platform to increase public sensitivity and awareness of the issue. Additionally, it appears that the way a director views disability has shifted from being something to exploit to being seen from the perspective of the disabled person. This change in the line of thinking can be dated back to 2005 when the nation's first international film festival for people with disabilities was held by the Chennai-based NGO Ability Foundation. The festival's goal was to dispel misconceptions about people with disabilities and raise awareness of disability issues through an extraordinary showcase of international films (*Indiaglitz*). Since then, this festival has been held annually and has attracted several notable producers and directors.

Along with increased sensitivity, mainstream movies about a variety of ailments have recently come out, including Progeria, Alzheimer's, Dyslexia, Asperger syndrome and Cerebral Palsy. It is encouraging to see that many of these movies are edging closer to presenting disability as an integral part of society. Although some of these films have been criticized for stereotyping, it is still important to appreciate them because the ideas they explore have never even been depicted on film.

AS LANGUAGE

Like silences, discourses are not subservient to or opposed to authority. Discourse communicates and creates power, it maintains it, but sometimes it undermines and exposes it, weakens it, and allows it to be thwarted. Similarly, silence and secrecy provide a haven for authority, cementing its prohibitions, but they also relax its grip and allow for relatively hidden pockets of tolerance. Dialogue is linguistic usage, in whatever form and via whatever means, concerning social, political, and cultural formations; it reflects social order, but it is also language producing social order and defining social life negotiation. Studies from racism² language in usage can impact people's lives in both 'good' and 'bad' ways.

Regularized and ritualized 'negative' change has the same power to harm, oppress, and exclude racial and ethnic groups on both personal and institutionalized levels as the practical hurdles to inclusion that people with disabilities encounter in their daily lives. Nowhere is this more evident than in the lives of those who are denied access to the use of language or whose access is limited to the 'basic', 'ordinary', and 'daily' due to discriminatory educational and societal practices.

However, this narrow focus for linguistic oppression analysis may be a red herring in the context of resistance politics given that the production of meaning, cultural value, and patterns of access to discourse are inextricably linked with social relations of domination and subordination. Nevertheless, many sociolinguists concur that persuasive language is necessary to bring about significant social change in the face of oppressive structures of any kind. It needs to interact with the dominant discourses defining the key spheres of its social reproduction to compete in mainstream society. In last, Marx may have missed the fact that 'to interpret it persuasively is to change it' when he launched his famous war cry against conventional philosophy (the goal is not 'to interpret the world differently but to change it', as repeated by Oliver and Barnes).

DISABILITY AND SOCIAL ATTITUDE

When the elevator of her college stops working one day, Laila is hoisted up the steps in her wheelchair. This act calls into question the ableist culture's perception of staircases as 'beautiful architectural elements [...] that raise key state buildings'. They are shown in the film as tyrannical and bigoted toward Laila, who has a physical impairment. Stairs signify a 'commonplace cultural assumption' in our society, 'an embedded aspect of the interpretive frameworks sanctioned by culture' that supports a specific view of the human body and its powers. This understanding of ableism as a practice working at the level of everyday discourse also offers options for us looking for alternatives that contradict ableist normativity, such as the presence of an elevator as an alternative.

Furthermore, scenes featuring Khanum and Laila playing miniature golf and swimming in New York and cricket in Delhi illustrate the film's ableist discourse, which frequently dictates the underlying social structures of sport. There is no denying that certain sports favour and reward specific abilities or physical capacities. In this regard, Cherney's (2011) views can help us understand the more nuanced of how societal attitudes help to create more hurdles for persons with disabilities. According to him,

The system of sports shapes expectations of physical capacity by designing games with rules that create spaces where individual performances and abilities appear salient, and it labels those whose bodies prevent them from participating as 'disabled' or 'incapacitated'. (p. 6).

It might be claimed that comprehending the nature of such a system's activities opens up opportunities for alternate methods of practicing existing sports and new ones. Furthermore, at Laila's college's rock band competition, the woman handing out the top award to her college team states that it was granted to them because a girl with a handicap wrote the songs. In the film, the woman presenting the award tells Laila,

This competition is a milestone. When I was informed that a disabled musician had written the song's lyrics, we had to give the award to her college. Your journey must have been different from other normal children. Would you like to share anything with us? (Bose: 2014).

To accommodate the different aspects of 'persons with disability', the role of other people's attitudes towards them contributes a lot. Some of the films take such a stance where some of the other characters play that role to accommodate the difference. One such film is *Taare Zameen Par* where the story revolves around an eight-year-old Ishaan. He slowly lost his interest in study but was unaware of his dyslexia. Later, when his parents enrolled him in a boarding school, he could not cope with the new challenges thrown at him. However, his life changed when he met a temporary teacher Ram Nikumbh (Amir), a temporary relief teacher for 'special needs students'. Ishaan can rediscover his self-confidence and overcome an impairment that his parents were unaware of with Nikumbh's aid and advice. Aamir Khan's directorial debut film shows Ishaan's dyslexia sensitively and gives an emotional look at life as a youngster humiliated by an ignorant world. In his family, the dyslexia of Ishaan is unacceptable. When his father is not ready to accept that Ishaan has been suffering from dyslexia for a while, his mother accepts it and plays the sincere caregiver to her son. Later on, his father also accepts when Nikumbh confesses his suffering from dyslexia.

The film's brilliance rests in Khan's visual storytelling, which combines animation and live-action to provide viewers with insight into the mind of his young protagonist. His concentration on nuance prevents the picture from devolving into melodrama. He lets his gifted actors do the rest, particularly Safary, who gives an outstanding performance as the damaged but intelligent boy attempting to take his place in the world. Khan, a special-needs sibling, criticizes the Indian school system for producing geniuses while rejecting those it considers to be failures. In addition, the film critiques Indian society for failing these intelligent youngsters by ignoring their latent potential.

Another film, *Main Aisa Hi Hoon* (Baweja: 2005), shows multiple aspects of the problems faced by persons with disability. In this film, nobody is ready to understand or to say nobody is ready to accept Indraneel, an autistic single parent who is raising his seven-year-old daughter by all means. He works as a waiter in a coffee house, and his life revolves around his daughter and the coffee shop.

DISABILITY AND SEXUALITY

Quoting Merleau-Ponty (1963), Shildrick (2005) implies that sexuality is nothing more than a 'mode of existence'. Shildrick also refers to Foucault, implying that bodies are equally made and susceptible to perpetual modification rather than fixed (Shildrick, 2005: 116). Based on all of these ideas, every type of disability provides its own unique set of sexual options within specific time-space settings that may or may not restrict other parts of identity performance. Because most sexuality is fundamentally about the interdependence and transmission of bodies, wills, and intentions, as well as an inherent vulnerability in which the boundaries of the Self and the Other are unpredictable, the subject is never settled or limited but intricately interwoven with the other in a dynamic process of becoming. Suppose one looks at the history of cinema carefully. In that case, it shows that many films have been made on the issues about women with disabilities from time to time as one of the most powerful and influential representational mediums for a while. The cinema both underrepresented and often misrepresented the issues regarding women with disabilities. Further, this notion is substantiated by how women with disabilities have been portrayed in the movie *Barfi!* (Basu: 2012) and *Margarita with a Straw* (Bose: 2015).

In these movies, the everyday language, attitudes, and actions depicted in films generate and reinforce sexist, ableist norms, resulting in various forms of discrimination and exploitation across specific locations and generations. In *Barfi!*, when Jhilmil realizes she has affection for Barfi, she attempts to mimic Shruti. She, like Shruti, strives to suck down a whole *panipuri*.³ Moreover, she tries to drape a sari but cannot do so independently. When the camera concentrates on scrutinizing her waist in the mirror to impress Barfi, her sexual impulses are accentuated. In *Barfi!*, a scenario in which the potential for sexual exploitation of disabled women in public places is highlighted by Barfi and Jhilmil as they are lying in a car while the man sitting next to them ogles Jhilmil's bare calves in a voyeuristic manner. Although Barfi's mocking reaction of baring his legs and pointing the man to leer at them challenges the ableist patriarchal order of society's 'primordial desire for the pleasurable looking' and

sexual objectification of women, given his role as Jhilmil's bodyguard, it fails to bring about any significant shifts in the ableist patriarchal order of society (Mulvey: 1975, 9).

Margarita with a Straw dares to deal with the disregarded and demonized component of sexual pleasure in Laila's life. When she tries to tell her mother about her bisexuality, she displays a frequent hesitation to use the term 'bisexual' within ableist language. 'Aai, I have become a "bi".'⁴ She informs her mother after much deliberation and effort. Underlining an interesting wordplay, Laila's mother misinterprets 'bi' as the Hindi term 'bai' for 'servant' and mockingly says, 'Even I am a bai'. No matter how well-educated these Hindustani men are, they all refer to their spouses as bai (Bose: 2014). This demonstrates her mother's ignorance and the danger to heterosexual ableist standards. Under the ableist umbrella of the film, it also carefully ties together LGBT and class problems. Furthermore, this scene is shot in a house courtyard, a woman's place and an in-between area that, while open, is not a public space.

When Laila tries to confess her bisexuality for the second time, she does it in the confines of a bathtub while trying to bathe her ill mother. The bathroom, where the body is king and where secrecy, privacy, sexuality, and cleanliness are most openly practiced, is expertly employed as a venue that discloses one's innermost impulses and secret kinds of pleasures. On the other hand, her mother fails to notice and instead repeats the earlier 'bai' joke, claiming that Laila has unquestionably become her 'bai' now that she has to care for and bathe her cancer-stricken mother. Furthermore, Laila's slurred voice in the scene appears to show underlying inhibitions about using specific labels to describe sexuality. 'Not the servant, bai?' Her mother inquires. 'What are you on about, bai?' 'What exactly does that imply?' (Bose: 2014). Laila eventually tells her mother who Khanum is and her girlfriend. Her mother's initial response is revulsion, exclaiming, '*Chiee*, this is not natural!' 'This is what the world said about me as I grew up, and you fought with them,' Laila says, reacting to contempt. This is hypocrisy since you are now behaving as if you were one of them' (Bose: 2014).

As a result, if a person's image is experienced and represented as a complex and ever-changing combination of physical, mental, and

social mechanisms, a more nuanced understanding and tracing of both ableist constructs and mechanisms that question them is required. Both Jhilmil and Laila require an assistant or caretaker to assist them with dressing correctly, negotiating bathroom facilities, requiring physical provisioning and assistance in achieving comfortable sexual positions, and fulfilling other bodily demands. They participate more explicitly in such networks, which might be described as a type of tangential desire or desiring production for transformational possibilities of being and being in the Deleuzian sense (Deleuze & Guattari: 1987).

DISABILITY AND CHALLENGE TO ABLEIST IDEOLOGY

Although they are scarce, it is vital to call attention to the tangential instances in the films covered here that poke and challenge the ableist discourse's predominance. For instance, in *Barfi!*, when Jhilmil repeatedly sings her favourite song in a way that her class disapproves of during a birthday celebration, some of her snobbish society members make fun of her, Jhilmil responds by calling them out. Furthermore, the theme of glass surfaces, mirrors, automobile headlights, and a glass paperweight, which Jhilmil receives from her grandpa, gives imperfect views of objects and unsettles the film's ableist discourse by altering the audience's order world view. Jhilmil is frequently shown playing with a glass paperweight that serves as a prism or lens, allowing her to perceive objects or surfaces that do not exist or cannot be seen explicitly.

In *Margarita with a Straw* as well, the focus on Khanum's use of wearable accessories and applying makeup, as well as Laila's use of a swivel spoon and her augmentative alternative communication device, draws attention to the challenges that people with disabilities face when participating in various daily and leisure activities like playing musical instruments, choosing clothing, and using particular types of make-up products, utensils, and cutlery. Both the films (*Barfi!* and *Margarita with a Straw*), in some cases, create significant concerns: What is a 'routine' day-to-day activity? What activities may be classified as 'day-to-day'? Who makes the decision? How? Is there

a time and space limit for this kind of activity? Both attorneys and victims of handicap prejudice in India are frequently confronted with these complex concerns. When films address it using particular cinematic tactics and fictional tales, they bring these issues to the forefront and into public debate.

In the movie *Main Aisa Hi Hoon*, Indraneel fights to control his daughter. Because of the inherent apathetic attitude and stigma, Indraneel is about to lose the case, not because he is less capable of caring for his daughter. Instead, the role of the state and those in the various state apparatus and their no-ableist notion of thinking. Though here and there, the movie challenges the ableist notion of society, the end of it somehow establishes the hegemony of the ableist idea. The court granted custody to Indraneel after his advocate Niti married him and produced the marriage certificate in court. One way or the other way, the victory of Indraneel to take custody of his daughter is nothing but the victory of the ableist ideology of society, especially the way the case turns up at the end of the movie.

Nevertheless, there are other two films, i.e., *Iqbal* (Kukunoor, 2005) and *Black* (Bhansali, 2005), that challenge the ablest idea of society and bring a new perspective. In the movie *Iqbal*, Iqbal, a 'deaf and mute boy who inspired to be a cricket player, faces an acute challenge from both his father and society at large. In his initial phase, the only solace for him is that his mother and sister are die-hard supporters of his cause or dream. He lived up to his dream and finally got selected for the Indian cricket team after defeating every hurdle thrown at him by society. He champions because of the environment created by his sister and coach Mohit, a drunkard but formerly a state champion. Putting the whole concept of the movie into a sentence; if a conducive environment is given to a 'persons with disability', s/he can defy the inherent ableist notion of society and can achieve their goal and set an example to society. Another movie, *Black*, has many facets to it. It is a highly complex movie giving interpretations like child abuse, to mould to live a 'normal', and many other facets. However, the movie's undertone also has the same lines as *Iqbal*, *Taare Zameen Par* and *Apna Aasmaan*. The storyline of *Black* revolves around Michelle McNally, a deaf and blind girl. Though Hellen Keller inspired the story, the movie itself

revealed so many facets of what a 'person with disability' goes through in their everyday life.

To conclude this chapter, cinema is one of the essential representational mediums and plays a very crucial role in presenting various social realities on the screen. As cinema in general, and Hindi film in particular has a large audience and a significant global reach, it is essential to examine the nuances of its operation and appreciate its ideological implications and the hegemonic discourse of ableism within which it exists. Responding to cinematic images of specific problems that arise in specific times and locations that influence the way experiences of disability are theorized, experienced, and lived may be more beneficial.

NOTES

1. Though there is not much difference between cinema and television regarding technology and production, there are still some minor differences. A film is more shoot days than a similar number of television pages. In a film stage, 'two people talking' is shot with motion and dynamics cameras, whereas a couple of static cameras handle/capture it on television. Further, television creates an innovative story and production, but films depend on or develop their retelling of stories,
2. For more details, see Matsuda et al., 1993; van Dijk, 1993, 1996; Whillock & Slayden, 1995; Riggins, 1997; Butler, 1998.
3. In Indian cuisine, fried puff-pastry balls filled with spiced mashed potato or chickpeas curry, spiced water, and tamarind juice.
4. 'Aai' refers to an informal way of addressing one's mother in Hindi and Marathi languages. The abbreviated form of bisexual 'bi' seems to have been used to highlight an exciting wordplay and correlate with 'bai' (pronounced as *bi*), meaning servant in Hindi and Marathi.

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CHAPTER 5

Epistemic *Ashrāfiya*-Morality and Urdu Theatre Public Sphere in Nineteenth-Century Bihar Muslim *Internal-Decoloniality**

NESHAT QUAISER

...throw this enemy-of-morality-civility-and-faith woman immediately out of this theatre Company (*Al-Punch*, 1891, 7/15).

Lots of lowly people, very few highborn [in theatre hall] (*Al-Punch*, 1898, 14/39).

INTRODUCTION

This chapter attempts to provide a Muslim *internal* decolonial critique of the hegemonic *ashrāfiya*¹ knowledge-oligarchies. Epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality is produced by these oligarchies as a mechanism to

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colonise the shudra²-dalit³-disenfranchised Muslim mind *internally*. Through the prism of the Western style Urdu theatre in the last quarter of the nineteenth century in the Indian province of Bihar, this essay examines the epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality-based responses to the popularity of the Western-style theatre and its ‘corrupting influences’; participation of the ‘lowly’ women and men in theatre that posed a threat to *ashrāfiya*-moral order; a possible subaltern counter-intuitive subjectivity; women as objects of marketized desire and other related issues. Although the essay deals with the colonial period, it has theoretical implications for comprehending the convincing continuity of epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality in the postcolonial Indian subcontinent.

The essay, divided into four sections, draws primarily on Urdu weekly *Al-Punch*.⁴ Section I outlines the concepts of epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality; Muslim internal-decoloniality; *ashrāf*; and *ashrāfiya*-morality. Section II provides a brief overview of Urdu theatre in the late nineteenth century Bihar. Section III, with three sub-sections, deals with the questions of popularity; contending moralities; responses to the ‘morally corrupting’ theatre; subaltern counter-intuitive subjectivity; ‘lowly’ subalterns in theatre posing a threat to *ashrāfiya* moral order; maghribat⁵ (Westernism) and *ashrāfiya*’s responses to colonialism; spatial-cultural, urban-suburban and *ashrāfiya*-subaltern tensions; and the ‘lowly’-*bāzārī*⁷ women as objects of disdain and desire. Section IV, the conclusion, outlines the Urdu theatre public sphere; the historicity of the epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality; and *ashrāfiya*’s *umma*⁷-making endeavours and colonising the mind internally.

Section I: Epistemic Ashrāfiya-Morality and Muslim Internal-Decoloniality

Morality denotes a normative framework determining human transactions in different forms in all the fields of social life (for general concepts of morality, see Carson: 1984; Harmen: 1977). However, morality is inscribed in ideologies of caste, class, race, religion, and culture; thereby, we find contending conceptions of morality (for contending moralities in our context see, Section III).

But when morality is epistemically foregrounded as a religious-universal moral prescription, it becomes a 'choreographically occultating' ideology. Thus, epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality is that which claims non-*ashraf* morality and ethics cannot be authentic. It works from the logic that authentic morality that guides all-encompassing conduct in society derives from superior caste-class, and race/tribe and family lineages and it alone can produce true knowledge. Epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality, therefore, excludes shudra-dalit Muslims from knowledge production. This supremacist moral framework produces relations of domination. Thus, epistemically privileged *ashrāfiya*-morality was/is presented as an authentic Islamic general moral framework that aimed to colonize the non-*ashraf* Muslim mind. Epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality is produced by the internal hegemonic *ashrāfiya* knowledge-oligarchies. This calls for decolonizing the Muslim mind internally.

In the context of colonialism, decolonizing refers to deconstructing the social, cultural, and political thoughts and values radiating from the colonial/western/white centres of power (for the concept of decolonization/decoloniality (see Thiong'o: 1986; Fanon: 2001; Mignolo & Walsh: 2018). Muslim decoloniality primarily focused on Western colonial technologies of domination to reshape and mould Islam and Muslim societies by privileging the Western/'modern'/orientalist constructions of religion and Islam, where secularism, democracy, and modernity emerged as the defining concepts. This engendered different Muslim counter-perspectives. Muslim decolonial thinking, however, as a part of a widely desired counter-strategy, pre-dominantly deployed arguments such as Islam is, by its very nature, modern, democratic and a harbinger of peace, etc.; and that Muslims are Ummat-e-Wasaṭ, meaning that Muslims are just, away from extremism, undogmatic, and 'moderate'. However, concepts such as *Al-zarūrāt tobīh al-mahzūrāt* (necessities permit impermissible things), *iṣtirārī* (despairing) conditions, and *istishhād* (desired death of a martyr) have also come into play. Muslim decolonial thinking also meant critiquing epistemological and ontological foundations of European Enlightenment, reason, secularism, and modernity, to develop a Muslim/Islamic intellectual counter-strategy (for Muslim

decoloniality, see among others (Wali Allah: 1995; Al-Attas: 1993; Asad: 1993; Sayyid: 2014).

The overriding theoretical thrust of the grand Muslim decoloniality has been to consider Islam as an internally cohesive and universal religion, in which ‘political’ compulsions also played a significant role, and considering Muslims as textually-driven non-hierarchized essentialist category, with the notion of *umma* as the underlying structuring principle. This may be called the *ashrāfiya* oligarchic Muslim decoloniality, as the external-colonial-factors-driven Muslim decoloniality has expediently not paid the required critical attention to the following crucial issues from the *internal-decoloniality* perspective: Islamic ‘canonical tensions and contradictions’; the manipulative *maslakī*⁸-jurisprudential hegemony; caste-race-lineage-class-based theories and practices of discrimination among the Muslims; and the *ashrāfiya* internal ‘epistemic’ and corporal violence. A critical examination of these issues alone will be able to unpack the colonizing the mind projects of the hegemonic *ashrāfiya* knowledge-oligarchies within Islamic/Muslim states, societies, religion and politics. Therefore, *Muslim internal-decoloniality* denotes shifting ontologically the focus from external to internal, within the wider historical and intellectual contexts, without necessarily neglecting the epistemic foundations of external colonial experiences. Muslim internal-decoloniality assumes greater significance as the continuation of epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality has acquired newer implications not only in the Indian subcontinent but also for other Muslim societies as well.

Ashrāf and Ashrāfiya-Morality

Ashrāf (plural of *sharīf*—of noble birth) are considered to be those Muslims who claimed to be of foreign origin with highborn lineages such as Sayyid (supposed to be descendants of the Prophet), shaiikh (supposed to be descendants of Prophet’s companions), and Mughal and Pathan. We have learned to take this *ashrāf*-propelled self-representation for an unquestionable truth.⁹ Such claims remain unsubstantiated in the case of most members of these categories in the Indian subcontinent. However, the early *ashrāf*—since very long

disconnected from their foreign locales of origin—along with the later incorporated members of local origin constituted a hegemonic *ashrāfiya*-oligarchy. They derived their distinctiveness akin to savarna (high-caste Hindus) from their claims to be of noble birth. The only expedient model available to them was the Hindu ascriptive caste hierarchical model, which could enable them to maintain their high social status due to their claims to be of noble birth of foreign origin, which would distinguish them from the shudra-dalit Indian Muslims. *Ashrāf's* claims of high status, as preordained, corresponded to the Hindu ideology of ascriptive status for justifying social segregation between savarna and shudra-dalit. Marriages with shudra-dalit Muslim castes are disdained, as it 'polluted' the 'purity'.

Thus, the caste system among Muslims in the Indian subcontinent contains the Hindu caste constitutive features like endogamy, mandatory segregation based on ascriptive occupational affiliation, status hierarchy, and also ritual purity and pollution with varying regional differences, but only in overt expression as these have expediently been equated with Islamic notions of '*pāk*' (clean) and '*nāpāk*' (unclean) (for caste among the Muslims, see Ansari: 1960; Momin: 1977; Sachar Committee Report, 2006; Ranganath Misra Commission Report, 2007; P. S. Krishnan Report, 2007; Deshpande, 2008). However, some scholars have argued that the caste system among Muslims differs from the Hindu model (Ahmad: 1973; Dumont: 1980). However empirical evidence suggest that the causal relationship between a Muslim's caste location and her/his related social disabilities are in no way different from the Hindu caste practices, which are continually reproduced (Quaiser: 2011, 49-68; Anwar: 2005; Rā'in: 2013; Trivedi et al., 2016, 32-6; Lee: 2018, 1-27).

Charles Lindholm (1995, 449-67) has insightfully discussed various approaches on caste among Muslims in India such as structural-functionalist adaptive, normative, essentialist, reflective symbolic, interpretative/constructionist, comparative, diffusionist, and indigenous monistic. The discussion shows a great deal of confusion, chaos, and conflicting oscillation in comprehending caste among Muslims in the Indian subcontinent. These approaches predominantly consider the *ashrāf-ajlāf-arzāl* divisions in terms of

‘adaptive’ practices, not in terms of palpable ‘caste’ divisions among Muslims as concretized in India defying even Islamic textual equality and justice. *Ashrāf* adopted an adaptive-essentialist strategy and portrayed the adaptive elements from the Hindu caste system as Islamic-essentialist in their exclusionary relations with shudra-dalit Muslims, in which *ashrāfiya* ‘ulama (scholars of Islam) crucially contributed. This lived reality has produced hegemonic casteist *ashrāfiya* subjectivity.

Epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality, as a mechanism to colonize the mind, emanated from the *ashrāf*-propelled self-representation and the Hindu caste structures. There were/are four principal constitutive elements of this moral order: firstly, expediently reinterpreted¹⁰ sub-continental *maslaki*-jurisprudential notions of Islamic moral values¹¹ to the advantage of *ashrāfiya*; secondly, pride in original Arab, Iranian and Central-Asian lineages and entrenchment in the Hindu caste system that enabled *ashrāfiya* to assume a superior ascriptive position akin to savarna; thirdly, pride in the subcontinental conquistador lineages; and fourthly, *ashrāfiya*’s collaboration with colonialism and other structures of oppression to safeguard their privileges after the final fall of *ashrāfiya* political power in 1857. The processes of the formation of this epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality had begun with newer dimensions since the second half of the eighteenth century. This propelled them to engage vigorously in *umma*-making endeavours in the given contexts (see Section IV below). Equipped with these mechanisms of colonizing the mind, *ashrāfiya* foregrounded the epistemic morality almost as divine predestination to reproduce conforming shudra-dalit Muslim subjects.

It was against this backdrop that the *ashrāfiya*’s morality-related anxieties and dilemmas in the wake of colonialism produced Urdu *akhlāq* literature (morality-related literature) in South Asia since the late nineteenth century, which ranged from philosophical debate to issues of everyday life. *Akhlāq* literature ultimately represented not only *ashrāfiya*’s moral dilemmas but also their quest for a ‘modern’ Muslim identity in colonial India with a new ‘liberal’ Islamic identity, which ultimately set the tone for a new *akhlāqiyāt* (moral code). This ultimately produced a reconciled ‘mixture’ of expediently *ashrāfiya*-reinterpreted Islamic moral values and western-colonial

moral norms, revealing the two-facedness of the epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality (for Urdu *akhlāq* and adab literature representing dominant *ashrāfiya*-morality, see Alam: 2004; Pernau: 2017, 21-42; Metcalf: 1984; Hasan: 2007).

Section II: Urdu Theatre in Bihar: A Brief Overview

This section presents a brief account of Urdu theatre in nineteenth-century Bihar. We find that the theatre that the *ashrāfiya* opposed for its ‘corrupting influences’ was simultaneously patronized by them. Thus, *ashrāfiya*’s reconciliation was stronger than the ambiguities.

The introduction of Western-style stage theatre in nineteenth century India emerged not only as a site to legitimise colonial rule but also to contest it. However, beyond this binary, the theatre also became a site to contest local caste-class-race-religion-based ideologies of domination, particularly in terms of subalterns’ participation. The new theatre had come into existence in Calcutta in 1831, but it began in a big way after 1857. Theatre emerged as a potent site where the colonial rule, western/colonial modernity, existing institutions and moralities, and different responses to these came to be debated that created a theatre public sphere (for theatre in colonial India, see Bhatia, 2008; Singh, 2010).

The history of ‘modern’ Urdu theatre began with the *Indar Sabha* of Amānat Lakhnavi which was staged in Lucknow in the early 1850s. However, it was after 1857 that professional theatrical companies were established on commercial lines mostly by Pārsīs (Zoroastrians). After the initial success in staging Gujrāti plays, Pārsīs took to commercially most promising Urdu plays, and a new phase of competitive theatre began (for Urdu theatre, see Nāmi: 1962; Rahmāni: 1987; Hansen: 2003, 381-405; Hansen, 2016, 1-30). Professional actors, singers, musicians, playwrights, costume designers, and importantly female actors were introduced. They expanded their activities beyond Bombay and staged Urdu plays in several Indian cities and towns, attaining popularity.

In Bihar, two Urdu plays—*Sajjād wa Sumbul* and *Shamshād wa*

Sausan were written in 1874 (Hasan: 1959, 33-8) by K.R. Bhatt¹² which were seemingly influenced by some Bangla plays. However, it was in the year 1884 that a theatre company called Imperial Theatrical Troupe staged several plays in Patna which became popular (ʿAbdulwadūd: 1952). Soon after, Bihar Theatrical Troupe was established in Patna (Hasan: 1959, 8-13). In 1891, the arrival of Jubilee Theatrical Company in Patna was reported, but was explicitly unwelcome:

In the month of February, this Company came to our city and staged several plays. With God's blessings...now it is planning to move towards the west. (*Al-Punch*, 1891, 7/15).

In 1892, Damṛī Mukhtār Ka Theatre (Damṛī Mukhtār's Theatre) was founded. This theatre company staged plays in and outside Patna and gained popularity. This was a professional company in which not only male but also female actors worked, and they were paid a proper salary. This company's well-known male and female actors were Mahbūb, Jawāhar, Khurshīd, Nasīr, and Nādir, of which Mahbūb and Jawāhar were very famous. Mahbūb excelled in his *zenāna* roles, and theatre halls were always full to watch him act (Hasan: 1959, 11-14). Nasīr too performed *zenāna* roles, and in the play *Zahr-e Ishq*,¹³ he played the role of Māhjabīn (*Al-Punch*, 1892, 8/14).¹⁴ Damṛī Mukhtār Theatre usually staged Urdu plays which were already popular such as *Zahr-e Ishq*, *Indar Sabha*, *Harish Chandar* and *Gul Bakauli*. In addition to Patna, it staged plays in several other cities and towns, such as Gaya (ibid.) and Muzaffarpūr (Hasan: 1959, 11-14) and every year in the famous Sonepūr fair (Hasan: 1959, 8-13). When Damṛī Mukhtār's Theatre became popular and attracted particularly students in large numbers, it was more vigorously opposed. It finally packed up, and its exit was celebrated:

Boys have stopped going to theatre, and public has developed hatred...due to lack of patronage from schoolboys, Damṛī Theatre's sources of income have shrunk (*Al-Punch*, 1892, 8/2).

After a gap of about five years, Damṛī Theatre was reorganized in 1898 as Bihar Theatrical Company in Patna City, with a stage in Bānkīpūr¹⁵ as well. Mahbūb of Damṛī Theatre fame joined

this company and became its star actor. The company's actress Bismillah attracted young people in large numbers. 'Students again came back to the theatre and once again, a theatre ripple was created' (Hasan: 1959, 8-13). Opposition to the theatre resumed, but the Company continued to stage plays (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/18). Bihar Theatrical Company staged several popular plays, such as *Ashiq-e Jānbāz*, *Zahr-e Ishq*, *Indar Sabha*, *Katora-Bhar Khūn*, *Dorangi Dunya*, *Dhūp Chāon*, *Asīr-e Hawas*, *Khūbsūrat Balā*, etc. As a result of its success, several professional and amateur theatre companies were formed in early twentieth century that continued for some time (Hasan: 1959, 11-14). Most of these plays were based on traditional *masnavi* (long narrative poem), *dāstān* (oral storytelling), *qissa* (tales), etc., or were an adaptation of English plays. The central themes of these plays mostly related to love stories and heroic deeds. They reinforced mostly the epistemic *ashrāfiya*-moral values.

Section III: Popularity, 'Corrupting Influences', 'Lowly' Women and Men, Spatial-Cultural Tensions, Contending Moralities and Counter-Intuitive Subjectivity

This section, in addition to an introduction, is divided into three subsections: (a) The popularity of the theatre and its 'corrupting influences'; (b) The Bānkīpūr argument: modernist response, spatial-cultural, urban-suburban and subaltern-*ashrāfiya*, tensions; and (c) 'lowly'-*bāzārī* women: disdain and marketized desire.

Urdu theatre performances, spectators, stage, actors, theatre companies, *ashrāfiya*, literate public, 'lowly' women and men, and students, with multiple familiar and unfamiliar issues and questions, created an Urdu theatre public sphere¹⁶ (see Section IV) in which 'epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality and subalterns'¹⁷ participation were the key organizing principles.

Since the 1870s theatre in Bihar attracted not only the *ashrāfiya*, emerging educated and professional middle classes, but also the 'lowly' women and men. Theatre *ka tamāsha dekhna* (to watch theatre performance) was emerging as a critical supplementary source to form new identities in the colonial contexts. However, the active

participation of the subalterns deeply disturbed the *ashrāfiya* moral-cultural order. Thus, the expedient *ashrāfiya* opposition to the popularity of theatre among the masses (*‘awām*-commoners, *bāzārī* women, shudras, students) was an attempt to pre-empt a possible subaltern ideological challenge.

The participation, responses, and the role of *‘awām*, shudra Muslims, *‘bāzārī* women about theatre were neither ‘written’ by themselves nor were adequately recorded in the newspapers or elsewhere in their voice. Evidence of critical subaltern participation is to be extracted even from the disdainful *ashrāfiya* narratives. Thus, ironically, they registered their presence through antagonistic and disdainful representations in *ashrāfiya* narratives, thus, the absence was turned into presence, subverting the very logic of that narrative, as is evident from what follows.

However, how would subalterns possibly gain counter-intuitive subjectivity from the plays, which did not at all relate to subalterns’ life conditions, and which reinforced *ashrāfiya* moral values? In most of the plays, the subalterns patronized so eagerly in different ways, were based on traditional tales or an adaptation from English plays with highborn as central characters, and which were deeply entrenched in epistemic *ashrāfiya* moral values. Yes, but the very fact that the subalterns came out of their socially assigned places of exclusion and entered the hitherto exclusive *ashrāfiya* spaces publicly was of critical importance. While doing so, subalterns defied the charted process of expected subject formation¹⁸ and refused to be constituted expectedly by the *ashrāfiya* moral authority. The active participation of ‘lowly’ women and men in theatre signified the formation of a counter-intuitive subjectivity, no matter in what embryonic form it may have been. The acts of being spectators and actors formed a critical constitutive element of a new subject formation, as the subalterns were excluded from the domain of knowledge in print. The very fact that the *ashrāfiya* launched a tirade against subalterns’ participation in theatre provided internal evidence of their critical presence and a possible counter-intuitive subject formation. This counter-intuitive subject formation was not premeditated, and yet not unintended (see concluding remarks in this section). Besides this, theatre, despite having colonial connotations, facilitated subalterns’

public visibility in exclusive *ashrāfiya* social spaces (for how subalterns gained from British presence, see Guru: 2005).

Thus, there emerged three sets of contending moralities: firstly, two-faced epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality; secondly, subaltern morality, which was constituted by the very act of subalterns' participation in theatre that had a promise of a counter-intuitive subjectivity, even if the contents of the plays were not subaltern-centric. This, in essence, was an act in defiance of the *ashrāfiya* prescribed moral codes of quiescence, passivity, and submission. The act of viewing theatre was a critical constitutive element for a new subaltern moral imagination, as knowledge in print was not their prerogative; thirdly, a colonial moral regime in a sense supported *ashrāfiya*-morality, yet theatre created an atmosphere for recognizable social visibility of subaltern 'bāzārī' women and 'lowly' men, ironically though.

(a) Popularity of the theatre and 'corrupting influences'

The popularity of theatre and concerns for its 'corrupting influences' assumed specific ideological connotations. Popularity simultaneously entails inclusionary and exclusionary connotations. In the given context, however, 'popular' tended to emerge as the early *colonial populism* for appealing to the colonized of all categories including ordinary people to legitimize colonial ideological apparatuses. This was different from 'authoritarian populism' where 'the people' are pitted against the elite as Stuart Hall had enunciated in the late 1970s;¹⁹ but beneath-the-surface logic common to both is to produce homogeneousness through explicit or implicit pressure. These characteristics were at play in the debate on theatre, under discussion, in different forms. *Ashrāfiya's* responses were exclusionary as they targeted mainly 'lowly' people to make theatre popular, engendering defiance. Students of *ashrāfiya* stock were deplored as they not only defied paternal authority, for visiting theatre meant knowing and imbibing new ideas, but also for they would ruin their chances of a bright future in the colonial administration by wasting their time in theatre.

We shall now briefly illustrate *ashrāfiya* responses to the popularity of theatre and its 'corrupting influence'.

A newspaper in early 1885 reported that a theatre company staged several plays last year and gained immense popularity. It commented:

Inhabitants of proper Patna are fully aware of the Imperial Theatrical Troupe... its plays had captivated not only the rich, nobles, different occupational categories, public in general but also the students... last year, the Imperial Theatrical Troupe's plays ruthlessly impacted the education and good conduct of our able and innocent students ('Abdulwadūd: 1952; Hasan: 1959, 8-13).

Theatre's popularity had captivated also the educated *middle-ashrāfiya* professionals such as lawyers that disturbed the *high-ashrāfiya*. Lamenting the extent of theatre's adverse impact on lawyers and students, a report much later observed:

Now listen to the kind of impact theatre had on rich and powerful, lawyers and students. Keeping aside their valuable legal works, and slate and books... they reached the theatre hall as the clock struck seven o'clock (evening) (*Al-Punch*, 1892, 8/14).

One Nasserul-zurafa' in a letter to the editor sarcastically suggested making use of theatre to tackle the cholera epidemic:

Theatre is next to college... ask Mahbūb to sing in his characteristic style, and you will see Haiza (cholera) Khan would run away. (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/33).

The suggestion conveyed the message that theatre is so lethal that even cholera would run away on seeing it. The reference to Haiza 'Khan' has a subcontinental Muslim conquistador connotation that even great Pathan and Mughal warriors would run away in the face of the morally corrupting armoury of theatre. And yet one cannot miss in it the elements of appreciation of theatre.

In the face of upsetting tensions produced by the popularity of the theatre, some *ashrāfiya* thought of using theatre to reform the *qaum* (community/Muslim community) and society. One Sayyed Mohammad Nawāb Mohammad wrote a play *Jawan-Bakht wa Shamsunnahār* (Mohammad: 1884) for reforming the *qaum*, because plays staged by theatre companies were not morally fit for the cultured and educated society. A similar concern was expressed in the face of

‘moral degradation’ caused by ‘lowly’ women in the theatre in which the references to *qaum* and ‘our Muslim brothers’ assumed significant connotations:

Jubilee Theatrical Company has publicized itself with magnified honourable claims as sympathiser of the country and *qaum*, and educator of morality. But these claims are misplaced. It has presented a wanton-eyed woman on the stage. Some people sympathise with this Company, for it is established by ... our Muslim brothers. My suggestion is: throw this ... woman immediately out of the Company (*Al-Punch*, 1891, 7/15).

Therefore, ‘reform’ within the *qaum* was essentially an *ashrāfiya* concern for self-preservation.

Corrupting influence of theatre on students and young was opposed by both ‘modernist’ and ‘traditionalist’ *ashrāfiya*. The traditionalist response was more concerned with the growing erosion of traditional Islamic moral values, expressed in the language of anti-maghribyat. A very prominent *ashrāfiya* Urdu writer and poet, Maulana Fazl-e Haq Āzād ‘Azīmābādī²⁰ wrote:

If possible, approach the Lieutenant Governor that he should try to remove prostitutes and theatre from India. These are corrupting the morals of people. And also, the influx of European novels in India should be prohibited because in them such materials are that the poetry of Jān Sāheb²¹ would appear like a dry leaf... (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/5).

Although Āzād expressed his concerns strongly for the preservation of Islamic values and protecting Indians from European culture, novels, prostitutes, and the corrupting influences of theatre, he merely appealed to the Governor rather politely. This is for, despite his strong opposition to the theatre, Āzād was very much in favour of Muslims and others acquiring Western knowledge and considered British rule as a boon for India. He was perhaps making a distinction between Western culture and Western scientific inventions and colonial administration.

This concern found expression in different forms, including English education for Indian girls. In a letter to the editor, one M. M. Sokhtadil wrote:

How the girls of respectable people would on a khatolī (a small bedstead) go to school and learn the lesson of a, b, c. This much one can tolerate. But

after this, our simpleton girls of Bihar would shake hands with memsahib, which means after completing education they will fight with their husbands for freedom. So, our Bihar is going the London way (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/10).

Sokhtadil, though hesitant about English education for respectable *ashrāfiya* girls outside the home, is ready to tolerate 'up to this', revealing a gradual acceptance of English education even for girls. But he expressed a grave concern relating to the control over women's bodies, sexuality, and expectations for strict adherence to the assigned religious-cultural roles of a wife.²² Coming in contact with *memsahib* would morally contaminate the girls, as it would encourage them to deviate from the well-defined normative roles of an obedient wife.

Modernist response to the popularity of the theatre and its corrupting influences is discussed in the following subsection, as it is entangled with other emerging complex issues whereby epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality was acquiring newer characteristics.

(b) The Bānkīpūr Argument: Modernist Response, Spatial-Cultural, Urban-Suburban and Subaltern-*Ashrāfiya* Tensions

Modernist response to the theatre was entangled with more compelling and complex emerging issues. Most *ashrāfiya* tended to be 'modernist' and were aligned with the colonial power adding new dimensions to epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality. Theatre, subalterns' recognizable social visibility, colonial modernity, English education, colonial administration, etc. produced tensions of all kinds within the emerging modernist *ashrāfiya*. These tensions were reflected through theatre in different forms, such as the tensions between the 'modern' and the old-fashioned residential localities; between the *ashrāfiya* and subalterns; and between the urban (*shahri*) and suburban (*qasbāti*) *ashrāfiya*. These tensions reflected conflicting economic, social, and political interests of urban and suburban *ashrāfiya* and the subalterns. The following report reveals the theatre-related tensions and the reference to *qaum* in it denoted *ashrāfiya*:

When theatre comes to Bānkīpūr, school children come under the control of some jinn. We heard it with great sorrow that a student of T.K. Ghosh

Academy...with some boys of Patna Collegiate has taken contract of theatre, which has saddened us most. Surprisingly, why did our kind and noble Headmaster of Patna Collegiate, Moulvi Amjad Ali Saheb not take corrective measures? If he takes little interest...these boys can be reformed... and *qaum* would thank him (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/33).

One Kammo, in a letter, expressed similar concern for *qaum's* welfare regarding the hostility between modern and traditional localities that theatre had produced, threatening even physical violence:

...you keep unravelling political knots, how would you know the evil doings of theatre. You could not even ask why, leaving the whole of Patna,²³ has it come to Bānkīpūr? And why does it choose a place...just opposite Patna College? If you have even an iota of interest in *qaum's* welfare, you should stop them.... They should at least leave Bānkīpūr and perform their jugglery and rope-dancing in Patna and make money. If you cannot do it yourself, order your followers to tear them into pieces. Otherwise, I am ready to take on them (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/18).

The above report and the letter reveal an emerging conflict between the westernizing Bānkīpūr and the old medieval Patna City. Bānkīpūr is a neighbourhood and residential area in Patna. Until the early twentieth century, Bānkīpūr was the administrative centre of the Patna Division of Bihar, which came under the rule of the British East India Company following the battle of Buxar in 1764. Bānkīpūr, since the 1860s, signified a 'modern' locality inhabited by modern-oriented people. It was in Bānkīpūr where English medium educational institutions, new architecture, modern markets, Western dress, Bānkīpūr Club, Bihar Young Men's Institute, Jahangir's Theatre and Cinema Hall, Rammohun Roy Seminary (an English Medium High School), Patna Collegiate, etc. existed. These were the markers of modernity. English medium education, colonial power, and new job opportunities attracted the traditional urban-suburban high-*ashrāfiya* and other emerging English educated middle-*ashrāfiya* and other middle classes.

The argument in Kammo's above-mentioned letter that theatre should leave Bānkīpūr and perform in Patna City signified tensions within the new *ashrāfiya*, emanating from two main concerns: firstly,

to sustain the hold of epistemic *ashrāfiya* moral codes over the 'lowly' people by keeping them away from Bānkīpūr. Patna City was predominantly inhabited by subalterns, labouring poor, artisans, shudra-dalit Muslims and Hindus—the non-*ashrāf* population. The underlying argument was that there was no problem if theatre was performed in the old City as people in that locality were outdated, incapable of upward social mobility and it was preordained that they were born poor and low in the caste hierarchy. If they come to Bānkīpūr to watch theatre, a culture of subaltern defiance will grow here as well. Secondly, the concern that theatre was distracting their progenies from being studious and competitive, a necessity for acquiring 'respectable' jobs in the colonial administration, which would bring additional enviable social esteem. Thus, Bānkīpūr emerged as a site for new social, educational and economic opportunities from which *ashrāfiya* alone were to benefit. *Ashrāfiya*, thus, actively collaborated with the colonial administration in all possible ways. For example, despite their claim to be 'modern', *ashrāfiya* were critical of the 'corrupting influence' of the theatre for reasons of political expediency as well. It enabled them to emerge as the sole representative of 'Muslim'/Islamic/Indian/Eastern moral values and culture in the eyes of colonial administration. They became the representative of 'the community's (all Muslims)' interest'. This became evident when *ashrāfiya* hugely benefitted from the separate electorate (Vohra: 2001, 113-15). In the process, *ashrāfiya* acquired jobs and positions of power in the colonial administration, educational institutions, and judiciary, and benefitted from the newly emerging political process.

Bānkīpūr and theatre also signified tensions between the urban and suburban *ashrāfiya*, in which conflicting cultural, economic, and political interests were palpable. After 1857, both the urban (*shahri*) and suburban (*qashbāti*) *ashrāfiya* began to move to Bānkīpūr. But the conflict between the two was expressed through culture, language and literature. City-bred urbane high *ashrāfiya* of Patna City were high-caste traditionally landed, affluent, and pedigreed nobles, having urban-traditional education. The suburban *ashrāfiya* were high-caste landed gentry of respectable families with suburban-traditional education and constituted the suburban aristocracy. But

the Patna City-based urbane *ashrāfiya* considered themselves of high culture and refined manners, and a repository of high linguistic and literary traditions. They considered the suburban *ashrāfiya* rustic in their manners and substandard in matters of language, accent and literature. Their suburban location of origin rendered them culturally inferior in the eyes of the city-bred *ashrāfiya*. This produced a bitter tiff between the two. They launched a diatribe against each other to prove their cultural and literary superiority, and the theatre did not remain unaffected by this, and for which *Al-Punch* provided space liberally.

Nonetheless, even such acrimonious argumentativeness contributed significantly to the emergence of a culture of critical public debate enriching comprehension not only of language and literature but also of politics, colonial rule, English education, and other issues. However, suburban *ashrāfiya* such as Fazl-e-Haq Āzād too had been well-informed of theatre and had strongly opposed it, and was considered to be the intellectual resource person behind *Al-Punch*. The editor and owner of *Al-Punch* too was a suburban *ashrāfiya*. They, too, could not resist the temptation of being part of the new centre of culture and economy and began to move to Bānkīpūr, with the view to getting their share in the land of new opportunities. And soon they did make their presence felt in Bānkīpūr in a big way. For example, the Imam family from the suburban Neora became perhaps the most prominent family of Bānkīpūr. Thus, Bānkīpūr emerged as a site for the making of a post-1857 *ashrāfiya* intellectual ethos.

By the end of the nineteenth century, ambiguities gave way to reconciliation and *ashrāfiya* began to accept the 'morally corrupting' theatre expediently. They took to the theatre to seek pleasure, with women emerging as objects of desire, as is evident from the following letter:

...brother, tell me, have you ever watched this theatre even in disguise...it is all pleasure and enjoyment... (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/18).

More forthright appreciation followed:

Bihar Theatrical Company staged its play *Āshiq-e Jānībāz* very nicely, with spectators in large numbers. Mast Nāz's style of acting...was wonderful...

and why not...this role was performed by the old master Mahbūb (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/24).

However, 'lowly' men and women continued to be condemned by casteist disdain and blamed for the popularity of theatre, and 'modern' *ashrāfiya* had no difficulty in collaborating with the colonial apparatuses. For example, theatre brought 'lowly' people in close physical proximity to high and middle *ashrāfiya*, which amounted to breaking the boundaries of casteist segregation, despite seating segregation according to the price of tickets and social status. This produced an alarmist reaction. Thus, a weaver was disdainfully reminded of his ascriptive status:

Leaving his loom, he goes to the theatre. For no reason, he will be harmed. If this eagerness to visit the theatre continues, even his loom will be sold out (*Al-Punch*, 1906, 22/46).

The above reminder communicated the casteist social status of a shudra Muslim in the language of the patron-client relationship. A stern message was conveyed that stick to your ascribed occupation; do not aspire for any vertical mobility by changing your occupation or emulating *ashrāfiya* cultural practices; to watch theatre neglecting loom was not your job. Despite repeated admission that the theatre was patronized even by nobles, *ashrāfiya* educated people, lawyers and students, yet subalterns were blamed for the popularity of the morally corrupting theatre by lamenting that: 'a lot of lowly people, very few highborn' [in the theatre hall] (*Al-Punch*, 1898, 14/39).

(c) 'Lowly'—'Bāzārī' Women: Disdain and Marketized Desire

Gender and sexuality are inscribed in caste class, religion, ethnicity, and nationality (with theatre, see Bhattacharya: 1998; Hansen: 1999, 127-47; Singh: 2010). Accordingly, a clear division existed between the subaltern and the upper-caste women about theatre under study. Theatre created an atmosphere for women to undertake a journey from home-shanty-*kothā* (*kothā*—broadly, a whorehouse) to public stage contesting differently the *ashrāfiya* notions of women's moral virtues. For 'decent' women, the home was a well-guarded place where they could be kept under control. Their participation in

theatre was largely a sign of relative freedom encouraged by *ashrāfiya* men, who were too eager to be a part of the colonial power structures. Caste-based hierarchized predispositions were clear, as sympathetic concerns were expressed in the case of respectable women. For example, a bit sarcastically but not disdainfully, it was expressed that now even women (here, decent ones) are attracted to the theatre:

Fair sex too now... have leanings for theatre
Listening to praises, they are restless with eagerness
Making tinkling sound of anklets, they come (*Al-Punch*, 1892, 8/1).

On the other hand, it is evident from the available sources that low-caste women, branded as ‘*bāzārī*’, entered the theatre as performers primarily to earn a livelihood.²⁴ ‘Lowly-*bāzārī*’ theatre women were targeted for causing moral degradation; *ashrāfiya* believed that they could easily be consumed and owned as objects of desire. In a report, describing the caste-class composition of spectators in a theatre hall, a clear distinction was made between respectable chaste and ‘lowly’-*bāzārī* women and it was contemptuously stated that only with *bāzārī* women, one can act lasciviously. One Fakhrul-Zurafa Māel Dharampūrī Darbhāngavi wrote:

They were respectable, chaste and pious wives and daughters of Bengali *bābūs*²⁵...*bāzārī* women had not gone there, so there was no chance for you to act lasciviously (*Al-Punch*, 1898, 14/39).

Thus, the subaltern women were portrayed as of lax morals, and *ashrāfiya* demanded that the Theatre Company divest them of their means of livelihood. While doing so, upholders of the *ashrāfiya*-morality two-facedly described the same women lasciviously:²⁶

It has presented a wanton-eyed, unceremonious woman on the stage... throw this affliction-without-remedy, enemy-of-morality-civility-and-faith woman immediately out of this Company (*Al-Punch*, 1891, 7/15).

In a long poem, on the decline of Damrī Theatre after its star actress Jawāhar eloped with Bādshāh Nawāb, the bodily beauty of the actress and sorrow of the spectators are expressed, significantly, with a blend of ‘morality’ and lascivious desire:

If old men get to see such a complete body, their old age will be taken care of,
 And the condition of young men is worse than that of old men, Ah Theatre!
 When you could not satisfy your innate desire, you got the idea
 And you subdued schoolboys, Ah Theatre!²⁷

In yet another report, representing casteist segregation, it was lamented that no seating plans were made to segregate *bāzārī* women from the respectable members of the audience:

No separate seating plan was made for *bāzārī* women. Generally, they sat next to any person as per their desire (*Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/24).

The violence of representation of the subaltern women was brazening. And yet the disdainful lamentation that ‘they sat next to any person as per their desire’ signified self-respect that the ‘lowly’ women were gaining—even if it was at a nascent stage.

A report blamed ‘common people’ for the growing number of women performers in theatre, as they increasingly desired to see women nearby:

In the eyes of common people, women’s appearance on stage as actors is certainly considered praiseworthy, and for that very reason they rush in hordes. But the gentry consider it vulgar and do not look at such theatre with respect (*Al-Punch*, 1891, 7/15).

Participation in theatre was gradually transforming subaltern women into objects of marketized desire. Marketization generally denotes the privatization of public services within the welfare state (Kumlin: 2007). Marketization, however, herein denotes a capitalist marketization of social relations, which produces the petrification of true meanings of immanent human qualities. It commodifies, for example, women as objects of desire to be bought at a price affected by the market. Market manufactures commodified desire and presents it as innate to one’s being (for desire as an object, see Quaiser: 2018, 22-38).

Within the sphere of theatre, *ashrāfiya* casteist disdain and transformation of women into objects of desire to be consumed and owned go together. Thus, by the end of the nineteenth century, the expediently reluctant *ashrāfiya* were attracted to female theatre

performers to seek lascivious pleasure from the object-desired-the easily accessible immoral women. A reporter L.H. Hamsar Bhāgalpuri wrote:

Why did you go to Calcutta? It is because the Harmistone Circus' fearless, lustful...ladies' riding intoxicated horses.... This generated lustful desire in spectators and clapping with great dejection. Pārsi Elphinstone Theatre's taut-bodied girls' and fairy-like boys' dance with expressive action and gesture on stage, and on every step trampling upon the hearts of out-of-control spectators under the feet of coquetry. Such alluring and confounding plays were in Calcutta that you would forego thousands of conferences for each expression of those women....²⁸

The power of masculine *ashrāfiya* social location to acquire the object desired was displayed quite brazenly in a letter to the editor, indicating a greater possibility of gaining easy access to and even 'running away' with the 'women of lax morals'. It was lamentingly asserted:

Alas, I was not there, otherwise, right from the stage, clutching in my lap, I would have run away with at least one (of the actresses)²⁹

Marketization with the underlying logic of the ownership of the desired object led to competitiveness among *ashrāfiya*. Jawāhar of Damfī Mukhtār's Theatre was very beautiful, and many big wigs competed to possess her, but ultimately Bādshāh Nawāb was successful. In a poem, this event was commented upon, lamentingly and longingly for the body of the object desired:

I am faint-hearted; with grief, I am dispirited—Ah! Jawāhar
With you went away the splendour of stage—Ah! Jawāhar
What to say, what was that swelled-up breasts—that was stairway of beauty
It was here that the travellers of intimacy boarded the train—Ah! Jawāhar
Movement of lips was stimulant for eagerness—speech was magic
In your sight was hidden Africa's magician—Ah! Jawāhar
Tell me, who sold you at Guzri³⁰—O golden bird³¹

With the progress of time, almost all theatre companies preferred to have women actors. For a fruitful survival of theatre, it must be economically viable, and for that to happen, female actors were much needed.

As is evident, a new subaltern subjectivity was in the making through the very act of subalterns' participation in theatre as spectators and performers that constituted an act in defiance of colonizing the mind project through epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality. The act of viewing³² assumed critical importance, as knowledge in print was the preserve of *ashrāfiya* and other literate castes. Subalterns did not have a neatly worked out schema for class struggle when they actively participated in theatre; instead, it was an expression of an impulsive, dormant, undeclared desire to say no to the undesirable state of existence marked by apparent silence, quiescence, servitude, meekness, passivity, submission to the *ashrāfiya*-morality as preordained. The desire to say no finds expression in many undeclared transferences (Quaiser: 2019a, 98-9). In the process, they learned mechanisms to act outside the given boundaries of epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality. 'Lowly *bāzārī*' women, shudra Muslims and other labouring poor were driven by their existence in everyday life and its counter-intuitive comprehension; they learned imaginative manoeuvrings convivially.

Subaltern participation in theatre, however, was contradiction-ridden as well; for if theatre facilitated subalterns' social visibility with emancipatory promise, the logic of colonialism at the same time was to subjugate them, and in times to come they would oppose the colonial power.

Section IV: Conclusion: Urdu Theatre Public Sphere, the Historicity of the Epistemic Ashrāfiya-Morality, Umma and Colonizing the Mind Internally

Urdu theatre in Bihar in the period of our study created an Urdu theatre public sphere. It became a critical source for comprehending not only the changing *ashrāfiya* moral, cultural and social landscapes but also of the making of a cultural history of subalterns. Thus, new discourses on gender, sexuality and *ashrāfiya*-morality; *ashrāfiya* perception of 'corrupting influences' of theatre; theatre enabling shudra Muslims and 'lowly women' to contest epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality amounting to decolonize internally through their participation in theatre; a challenge to the 'Muslim'/*ashrāfiya*

'Islamic' cultural identity and concerns to reform and preserve it; *ashrāfiya* collaboration with the colonial rule; colonial authority, English education, modernity, western moral values; and *ashrāfiya* and lowly castes' responses to these issues constituted an Urdu theatre public sphere in Bihar. Within this sphere, unfamiliar issues, ideas, institutions, and a new language affected a new outlook, and the tensions that these produced engendered a sense of amazement, despair, lamentation, and attraction. Familiarity with the unfamiliar produced different routes for the *ashrāfiya* and subalterns. The *ashrāfiya* took the route of recognition of and negotiation with the colonial rule and continued with their epistemic morality. For subalterns, their convivial participation in theatre, questioned the *ashrāfiya* moral order, amounting to decolonize the mind internally.

The processes of colonizing the mind through epistemic *ashrāfiya*-morality that began with newer dimensions in the second half of the eighteenth century assumes critical significance. Assertion, contestation, recognition, negotiation, placation, and acceptance were the key *ashrāfiya* responses at different stages. The defining event of 1857 radically altered the social life of all segments of *ashrāfiya*, who portrayed the event as a big blow to *mashriqyat*³³ and further ascendancy of *maghribyat*, causing attrition of distinct 'Muslim' identity.

However, *mashriqyat* has been a euphemism for *ashrāfiya*-morality and political power. Compelled against this turn of history, *ashrāfiya* began the construction of a subcontinental Muslim *umma*. *Umma* ideally denotes a united community of Muslims bound to Islam, independent of national boundaries. However, territorial conditions, local *ashrāfiya*'s interests, and 'restorational politics' (Quaiser: 2011, 49-68) ultimately shaped the conception of an *umma*. It meant, how to ultimately restore the lost 'Muslim'/Islamic (read *ashrāfiya*) political power, but since such a possibility did not even remotely exist, the only option left was to recover and sustain whatever could be recovered and sustained. This post-1857 concern and its postcolonial implications are best captured when much after 1947, Imārat-e-Shari'a Bihar and Orissa, a prominent *ashrāfiya* institution established in 1921, introducing its *raison d'être* argued:

After the revolution of 1857 and the downfall of Mughal Empire in India, the ‘ulama of the day...were compelled to find out a suitable platform for the Muslims in India through which their social, cultural, religious lives and activities could be managed, controlled and guided in the light of Shari‘at laws...in non-Islamic countries. An organization based on Shari‘at laws under one Ameer (chief of the faithful) is essentially required to educate, inspire and guide the Muslim ummah to enable them to lead a collective life under Islamic order (Quaiser: 2019b, 173).

In lāmrat’s conception of the *umma*, Islamic identity and the loss of Muslim political power assume critical significance. Certain other factors, such as the activities of Shuddhi Sangathan of Arya Samaj³⁴ and the rise of Hindutva forces in the pre- and-post-colonial period also supplemented the *umma*-making efforts. Thus, the notion of *umma* became a powerful tool to colonize the shudra-dalit Muslim mind. In this conception of the *umma*, the *ashrāfiya*-perpetuated caste-based vertical division among the Muslims was strategically never even mentioned. The need to expediently construct a Muslim *umma* was/is for the preservation of *ashrāfiya* politico-religious oligarchic hegemony.

NOTES

1. Of *ashrāf* (of noble birth). *Ashrāfiya* herein denotes a hegemonic-highborn-casteist-racist-knowledge-oligarchy constituted by Muslim nobles of foreign origin and high caste middle-class Indian subcontinental Muslims. See the discussion in Section I.
2. Shudra is the lowest-ranked category in the Hindu caste system, under the subordination of Hindu upper castes. They are producer peasants, artisans and labourers, engaged in necessary material production and reproduction. Shudra castes constitute the majority of the Muslim population in the Indian subcontinent, retaining their ascriptive caste social status. Caste affiliations constitute their primary identity and are accordingly disdained by *ashrāfiya*.
3. Dalit means trampled upon, oppressed. The term Dalit was first used by Jyotirao Phule (1827-90) for the untouchable lowest castes in the Hindu caste system. Muslims too have their share of converted Dalits.
4. Urdu weekly *Al-Punch* was started in 1885 from Patna, the capital city of the north-eastern Indian province of Bihar. The weekly was read

even outside Bihar. *Al-Punch* widely covered Urdu theatre activities in Bihar in the period of our study. *Al-Punch* covered national, provincial, local, suburban and international social, political, administrative, and cultural events and news. It supported the British Raj, as various post-1857 *ashrāfiya*-run Urdu newspapers did. Although, it was critical of the government's various policies and practices with wit, satire, and humour but in a rather friendly manner. *Al-Punch* represented the post-1857 *ashrāfiya* intellectual ethos in Bihar through the emerging Urdu print culture. This essay is part of the author's ongoing work on *Al-Punch*.

5. *Maghribiyat*—Westernism: Western normative structure, moral values and philosophy of life and society, which in the given context included also the colonial state's economic, political and cultural machinations.
6. *Bāzārī* (woman) herein means a woman portrayed as of lax moral, easily accessible for sexual gratification due to her low caste location.
7. *Umma* ideally denotes an integrated brotherhood of Muslims bound by tenets of Islam, devoid of caste-class-race hierarchies and independent of national boundaries. See Section IV for discussion (for a general concept of *umma* see: Shafi: 1997 and Esposito: 2004).
8. The term *mazhab* denotes a school of Islamic jurisprudence. The term *maslak* in the Indian subcontinent refers to multiple denominations within a particular *mazhab*, with conflicting interpretations of the Quran, *hadīs*, and *Sunna*. They are in antagonistic relations with each other as they also significantly represent non-faith caste-race-class interests.
9. Scholars studying *ashrāf* and their place in South Asian history (such as Margrit Pernau: 2013 & 2016) too have taken this *ashrāf* propelled representation as gospel. These categorizations are highly misleading, and they are only descriptive (which is also inadequate), and cannot be employed as an analytical category for comprehending *ashrāf* as a 'caste' social category. This is crucial, as this original theory has laid the *ashrāfiya* epistemic foundation on which subcontinental hegemonic casteist *ashrāfiya* subjectivity is constituted, which reproduces casteist hegemony to keep reproducing conforming non-*ashrāf* subjects. Most scholars studying *ashrāf* and their defining role in the 'making of South Asian Muslim society and politics' do not question the *ashrāfiya* epistemic foundations, and in doing so they endorse *ashrāfiya* hegemonic social locations. They can be called 'docile' authors as drawing on Foucault's schematization of 'the author' Wael Hallaq has explained (Hallaq: 2018, 134-5).

10. Role of Islamic 'canonical tensions and contradictions' in expedient reinterpretations is a matter of another debate.
11. In Islam, *akhhlāq* (morality/ethics) and *ādāb* (good manners) are traditionally rooted in Qur'an, sunnah, and *hadīs*. However, *akhhlāq* has also been philosophically interpreted by Islamic scholars since the ninth century AD (See Fakhri: 1991; Hourani: 1985).
12. It has forcefully been claimed that the real author was Moulvi Hasan Ali (see Hasan: 1959, *Eshara*, 33-8; 31-6 and Hasan: 1962, 5-8).
13. Based on classical Urdu *Masnavi* (long, narrative, poem) *Zahr-e-Ishq* (1862) by Mirza Shauq Lakhnavi.
14. For males representing females on stage, see Hansen: 1998, 2291-300.
15. Bānkīpūr (or Bānkīpore or Bānkī Bazaar; also known as Bāqīpūr) is a neighbourhood residential area four kilometres west from the medieval Patna City or 'Azīmābād, which came under the East India Company in 1764. Since the late nineteenth century, it signified a 'modern' locality.
16. Habermas identified a public sphere in eighteenth-century Europe where public issues were debated and the government's activities were criticized by the 'public'- the bourgeoisie (Habermas: 1989, 13 & 27). However, increasingly public sphere became status-quest to legitimise the capitalist state and society (Thompson and Held: 1982, 4-5; see also Calhoun: 1992). In the case of India, 'as the historical context of public spheres in colonies was different from that of the western bourgeois society, the nature of the public sphere also differed. In India, public spheres existed much before the eighteenth century representing ideologically conflicting critical and conformist orientations outside the state. In India, it was concerned not only with the state and the political but also, with other indigenous structures of domination', see Quaiser: 2012, 122. See also: Joshi, 2001, 23-58.
17. Gramsci employed the term subaltern for those who are excluded from political representation, thus hegemonically denied having their voice (Gramsci: 1971, 52-5). Moving away from the Subaltern Studies Group's understanding (Ludden: 2003) or any mechanical class perspective, the subaltern is employed herein not strictly through and against the colonizer and colonized; instead to include also the non-colonial local caste-class forces of domination and forms of knowledge: the disenfranchized people of low castes; or at times even youth and student who felt suffocated under parental authority.

18. For subject formation and subjectivity, see Althusser: 1971, 123; Quaiser: 2019b, 180.
19. For popular, populism and authoritarian populism, see Hall: 1980, 157-85; Hall: 1981. For Frankfurt School's views, see Jay: 1973.
20. Fazl-e Haq Āzād (1854-1942) was a landed *ashrāfiya* of Sayyed caste from the village Shāho Bigha in the Jahānābād district, Bihar, but later he settled in Bankipur in the 1880s.
21. Jān Sāheb (1817-96) is known for his Urdu poetry that detailed women's sexual desires and activities.
22. These concerns were articulated more forcefully by various prominent *ashrāfiya* scholars.
23. Patna here refers to medieval Patna City.
24. Samik Bandyopadhyay has noted in a general sense that, 'For the actresses, several of them single mothers or with dependents, the options were more constricted, and acting remained the only means of living' (see Bandyopadhyay: 1994, 65-6).
25. Respectable educated men—plural of *bābū*.
26. For *ashrāfiya* lascivious description, see footnotes 28, 29, 30 & 32.
27. *Al-Punch*, 1892, 8/4: Passim.
28. *Al-Punch*, 1900, 16/24
29. *Al-Punch*, 1899, 15/18
30. Guzri—a residential and market locality in Patna City, where Badshah Nawab resided.
31. *Al-Punch*, 1892, 8/45.
32. Augusto Boal (2008) has underscored the possibility that the spectators could modify the representation according to their contextual experiences.
33. *Mashriqiyat*: Easternism: Eastern normative structure and philosophy of life, which in the given context meant Islamic, 'Muslim'/*ashrāfiya*-morality, Indo-Islamic, composite culture, indicating conflicting ideological predilections.
34. Arya Samāj was formed in 1875 for the revival of Vedic values and practices. It gained notoriety for its shuddhī activities for conversion to Hinduism creating communal tensions.

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Mediations and the Body-Politic The Problem of Representation Revisited

RATHEESH KUMAR

While introducing the concept of ‘ideological state apparatus’ towards building his thesis that ‘Ideology interpellates subjects’, Althusser (1971) writes:

Behind the scenes of its political-ideological state apparatus, which occupies the front of the stage, what the bourgeoisie has installed as its number-one, that is as its dominant Ideological State Apparatus, is the educational apparatus, which has replaced in its functions the previously dominant Ideological State Apparatus, the Church. One might then add: the school-family couple has replaced the church-family couple (145-6).

Here, Althusser presents an account of a replacement of institutional dominance in perpetuating the ideology of the bourgeoisie through the periods of the medieval to the modern. The Church-family couple gets replaced by the emergence of the modern education system as he attributes it as the school-family couple. If Althusser could rewrite this thesis in the twenty-first century, he would be considering the media-family couple replacing the school-family couple specifically when the schooling space itself is absorbed into the sphere of the media in the context of pandemic-enforced online pedagogy. Insofar as the mediascape expanded drastically with the emergence of the new media in its various guises, versions and platforms, the question of media representation and the subsequent social practices stem from and through its complex networks demand critical scrutiny. Taking media socialization to its centre, this chapter will focus on the questions of representation, gender and body politic

in particular, towards a methodological concern beyond the domain of textuality.

The question of representation has always been central to the analyses of media texts, especially in the context of studying images of the body. Subjecting textual configurations towards unravelling body-politic in the context of analysing the 'marginalized' social groups remained to be a common track of approaching the problem of representation in contemporary media studies. This chapter takes a slight turn in its approach to the problem of representation and body politic by attempting a methodological realignment to underline the practices and effects that stem from text and its surroundings. This methodological shift in focus calls for a move from 'what the text has' to 'what the text *does*'. As it is significant to track the containment of texts as the starting point to mapping the politics of representation, the question of underscoring signifying practices that stem from such textual representation is equally important to capture the problem in its totality (Hall: 1997). By selecting certain key sites of gendered and racialized bodies that represent marginality in particular domains of social hierarchy, the chapter traces the effects and practices those textual representations engender through their features and functions.

INTERFACING MEDIA, MARGINALITY AND THE BODY-POLITIC

'We live in a world that is media-saturated', is one of the most frequently used phrases in today's media discourses. In other words, no one can escape the effects that contemporary media, both old and new, have on our daily lives. In our social and personal interactions, the media wields tremendous power and influence. Individuals are exposed to a variety of media forms and contents. The exposure to media is significantly increasing in contemporary times as most individuals often get involved in watching videos, films either on the internet or television, reading blogs, newspapers, magazines, and listening to music, spending time on social media platforms, and all these activities are carried out, in most cases, through a single device, the smartphone. In the time of unprecedented mediation swept by

the smart phone era, the frequent flash of notifications makes everyday life a constant site of distraction from routine tasks. As a result, as Virginia Woolf once aptly remarked that it is impossible to live outside the machine more perhaps than half an hour. A series of distracted and thus modified activities of the everyday create a social life that has yet to be explored to understand along with its mediating structures and agencies.

Now that we are aware of a variety of landscapes, regions and cultures, as well as the lives and experiences of individuals and communities who inhabit these constantly mediated landscapes (Knightley: 1975), Appadurai (1990) have translated the trajectories of such movements into the flow of mediascapes in the era of global cultural processes. Our world's 'culture epicentre' has become the mass media, especially visual new media and television (Castells: 1996). The following section will examine the various elements of such mediations as they relate to mass communication, production and consumption of media contents in various forms and the critical connections that media offer between the concepts of body-politic and gendered and racist representations.

The power of media texts to represent 'socially acceptable' ways of being or relating to others becomes substantial, and their capacity to negotiate and produce public recognition, honour, and status for different sections of people is enormous. Cynthia Carter and Linda Steiner provide an account of the feminists fighting for egalitarian conceptions of womanhood in the 1860s in the United Kingdom and the United States. It demonstrates that newspapers and journals of the period derided or ignored women's lived experiences to a great extent. Systematic research on media images of women flourished during the 'second wave' of the women's movement in the 1960s. Feminist academics and activists began looking at how the objective of those critical reflections was to problematize the media enculturation through anti-women and sexist content that made hierarchical and binary sex-role stereotypes into 'natural' and 'normal'.

In the 1970s, feminist studies took a critical turn by looking at how media portrayals bolstered the interests of the twin systems of patriarchy and capitalism. Gramsci's (1971) concept of hegemony

was a crucial and fertile concept underpinning this attempt to foreground the question of body politic in the whole affair of representation and participation in the media discourse. When the hegemonic and ideological modes of being, characteristic of the powerful groups are naturalized and made to appear 'normal', they are handed down to everyone as if there are no other answers, leading to a broader 'common sense'. 'The media play a critical role in gaining public consent', Carter and Steiner accurately note. Instead of just reflecting or mirroring 'reality', media texts construct hegemonic beliefs about what constitutes 'reality' (Carter and Steiner: 2004). Representations in the media seem to be 'real' and commonsensical and therefore most often remain the taken-for-granted truths about social reality. As a result, media representations reflect the desires of powerful social groupings. Critical feminist studies argued that women fail, in most instances, to distinguish how patriarchal principles are culturally translated to look as 'non-ideological', 'objective', 'natural', and 'non-gendered'. Although sex and gender are not identical, they are connected, *chevaliers*. Traditionally, the terms 'sex' and 'gender' have been used to refer to biological differences (male and female) and socio-cultural acquisitions of roles and behaviours (feminine and masculine) respectively. However, emergent debates on sexuality and identity have redefined gender and sex as a continuum rather than a fixed binary such as male/female or masculine/feminine (Butler: 1990).

The ideas about gender and sex are reconfigured constantly along the lines of socio-political, and historical contexts, and accordingly, those images in the media texts are subject to reception, which can, in effect, reproduce or counter-produce those modes of representation. Gender norms and relations are articulated in the media in significant ways. Both print and visual media, particularly television, are used to build fixed gender concepts through stereotyping. Though masculinity and femininity have diverse meanings in different cultures, media portrayals of these ideas tend to unify and standardize them in their representative patterns and meanings. Margaret Mead (1928) has long since written that what is seen as masculinity and femininity differs among cultures, based on her ethnographic investigations in Samoa and New Guinea. In other

words, not only do various societies label certain traits as feminine and others as masculine, but these traits also differ among cultures and regions. As a result, feminists have objectively proved that there is no basic relationship between men's and women's biology and the qualities and behaviours that are considered masculine and feminine, respectively. In fact, the process of socialization has a significant bearing on molding children to comprehend such gender-specific forms of behaviour, attitude, mannerisms, clothing and so on. Socialization is frequently subtle, veiled, and functions at the ideological level. A variety of institutions socialize children, which designs the effects of bravery, aggression, and confidence as 'masculine' and modesty, sensitivity, and shyness as 'feminine', as equivalent to the value that society assigns to them, and the media play a key role in socializing girls and boys in distinct ways in terms of those norms and values.

One of the key subjects of concern is women's position in the media sector and their level of participation. Several studies have discovered that women are assigned inferior positions and low-ranking employment in the media business around the world. Ann Ross Muir (1988) contends that if women are restricted to lower-paid and lower-status roles in the media sector, they will have fewer opportunities to influence content and representation and to combat gender stereotypes. She goes on to say that most television shows have a masculine perspective because men dominate and control the industry (Muir: 1988). Stott and Steiner note that, while working conditions for women journalists have improved significantly in recent decades, women have long been aware that many of their male colleagues doubted their capacity to produce 'serious' journalism simply because they were women. Some even claimed that every successful female journalist owed her success to her sexual availability (Carter and Steiner: 2004). Many journalists, editors, and producers across the world hold this skewed perspective.

When it comes to women in the television industry, most of the television industries around the world are dominated by men (UNESCO: 1987). It could reflect gender dynamics in other areas of life, when women are primarily confined to their homes. The gender configuration in the television industry was heavily influenced by

this dominating cultural pattern, which was dominated by men. There were only a few women in prestigious positions of higher authority and power in the early days of television. In the last several decades, there have been certain improvements in the media sectors that have raised awareness about gender equality. Women now have a variety of options thanks to television. However, the generation of gender-sensitive material in media texts remains a critical subject. Is there a significant movement in gender stereotyping in television programming? It may be premature to see gender equality in the media because of the rise in female engagement in the field. In terms of describing gender equality, the relationship between patterns of employment within television organizations and television representations is situated differently. Then we must ask a critical question: what goes wrong if the presence of a greater number of women does not correlate to any major transformation in the organization of the programme's content? According to statistics, women are unable to hold important decision-making roles in the majority of mass media businesses around the world. In the production of media content, van Zoonen's work on feminism and journalism (1989) demonstrates a strong misalignment between institutional rules and individual objectives. Although feminist ethics were incorporated into their training, women journalists who advocated for them found it difficult to put their beliefs into practice in an institutional setting. Women tend to regard these tendencies as 'normal' and hence take them for granted because of 'organizational socialization'.

STEREOTYPING BEYOND THE TEXT

In the study of media and culture, the concept of representation is one of the central concerns. 'Representation' or 'to represent' is a phrase used frequently in media studies to describe various methods of describing or presenting something for an audience to read or consume. Re-presentation allows mediation to reach the audience with diverse representations of the world, as an unmediated 'actual world' is not accessible. As a result, what we see on television, hear on the radio, or read in the newspaper will be a construction, involving

decisions about content selection, camera positioning, editing, and so on.

Another approach to consider the issue of representation is how media images help us make sense of cultural symbols. This can lead to a better knowledge of how various social groups are frequently depicted in media texts, as well as how stereotyping of certain cultural groups and people occurs. As a result, media depictions can be viewed as a reflection of reality or as a distortion of something 'real' or 'true'. This implies that we're interested in determining how true media images are to reality, or how far the media misrepresents reality to maintain certain ideas. Media texts frequently fall into a regular kind of construction in their varied ways of representing the 'actual', which causes some social groups to become fixated; this is what we call the stereotyping process. Women, for example, are frequently shown or viewed in a narrow variety of roles, such as housewives, girlfriends, or secretaries, and in the case of some ethnic minorities, terrorists, criminals, or servants are frequently depicted (in the case of Muslims and Black people). Scholars contend that reversing stereotypes in a dramatic and immediate manner as part of media ethics will not achieve the desired result. This is due to the nuanced nature of the representation-reality interaction. What is genuine and what is representation are difficult to distinguish. So, to answer the question 'Who represents whom?' we must examine many examples of the production and dissemination of stereotypes.

In this context, Richard Dyer discusses the significance of examining the concept of 'pleasure' (Dyer: 1985). Who is getting pleasure out of experiencing a media text? Or what kind of pleasure a media text can offer by ways of representation and who is the target audience to those representations? Do audience members all get pleasure from media content in the same way? Given the social disparities in terms of colour, class, gender, ethnicity, and sexual orientation, it's unlikely that all viewers, readers, and listeners will be equally comfortable with the styles of depiction. In the context of power and ideology, representations are created and transmitted in a social environment of meanings. This common sense of meaning is managed by authority, which elevates some meanings while demonizing others.

Stuart Hall poses a challenge that goes beyond the conventional view that representations are reflections or distortions of something real and instead asks whether occurrences in the universe have a single and essential fixed meaning that can be tested against distortion (Hall: 1997). In other words, reality does not have a fixed meaning until it is represented, and representations and their meanings fluctuate over time and location. What we call 'reality', according to Hall, does not exist outside of the process of representation; and the signs are always located in a dynamic relation to the production of meaning as they appear as 'floating signifiers' (Hall: 1997).

Correspondingly, the concept of sign was subject to a significant shift in the writings of postmodern and poststructuralist thinkers. Some of them were of the view that in the era of postmodernity, life is thrown into a sphere of mass-produced and massively disseminated media world, a storm of a set of complex signs. With the infinity of indicators in visual and new media texts that generate a 'hyper-reality', people struggle to distinguish reality from representation. The effects of stereotyping demand a revisit in the context of the emerging mediascape in the twenty-first century that includes the social media platforms in their constantly modified versions.

Stereotypes are a set of qualities that are assigned to individuals, groups, and civilizations fixedly. The word 'typos' comes from the Greek words 'stereos', which means 'solid', and 'typos', which means 'mark'. The term was conceptually developed by Walter Lippmann, an early twentieth-century American journalist, in his work *Public Opinion* (Lippmann: 1922). Lippmann finds two crucial aspects of stereotypes. Firstly, stereotypes tend to be resistant to change; second, they generally carry a pejorative and narrow range of meanings (O'Sullivan et al.: 1994). As they are theoretically acknowledged, stereotypes often display a set of imprecise, but simplistic generalizations about individuals or groups or communities and cultures. Stereotypes and stereotyping are processes and products that relate to power and ideologies in each social milieu. As Tessa Perkins (1979) argues, stereotypes certainly display a set of existing social relations that may be partial, but not necessarily false in a complete sense. Therefore, the association between stereotypes and social reality is a complex one to draw straight-line conclusions. For

example, portraying women in subordinate roles does not have to be read as a text that reproduces women's inferior standing in society, as some critics say. Many cultural analysts, on the other hand, have suggested that media texts generate and perpetuate stereotypes, and there is evidence to back up this claim. In short, the mode of representation in which images constitute stereotypes, would not often be tantamount to the exact translation of those images towards reproducing them in the domain of reception.

Who creates stereotypical images of whom? This leads to a debate on who should represent the other. Who exactly is the other? 'The other' is the representative entity that is placed outside of one's gender, race, class, religious, and ethnic identities. The building of the other, in most cases, turns out to be the construction of 'the inferior other' by society's dominant individuals and organizations. How is stereotyping used to produce othering in media texts? What is the connection between stereotypes and the media? In the continuation or demotion of stereotypes, the media's role in agenda-setting, gatekeeping, and ownership remains critical.

Grose examines the Sun Newspaper's evident sex culture, which pervades every element of the publication, including the parts dedicated only to women. 'The Sun termed its women's pages packed with sex', according to the paper's interpretation of its history. They were made for women by women. However, they were dubbed 'The pages for ladies that men can't get enough of', implying that there are lots of things that captivate both men and women, such as sex (Carter and Steiner: 2004). Grose's observation can be found in several magazines written by and for women. It demonstrates how women unwittingly participate in the creation of stereotypes. What messages are these publications attempting to convey to their readers? Women's periodicals are often divided into two categories: those focused on homemaking and childcare, and those concerned with other topics.

The second type is involved with giving crucial marketing advice to attract a mate. This distinction creates a problematic dichotomy in which the first type of woman reflects the qualities of being homely, humble, chaste, maternal, and modest. The second type of woman, on the other hand, represents amoral, bold, sexual, sinful, and dangerous characteristics. Most Indian films include two female

protagonists: a traditional 'Indian woman' who symbolizes the first group (and typically triumphs in the climax of the movie) and a modern/western woman who represents the second category, a sign of danger that threatens 'Indian Culture'.

In her study on computer games, Heather Gilmour claims that most computer software now being made for girls reinforces hierarchical gender differences rather than challenging power structures. 'Girls continue to be essentialized as emotional, highly social, modest, and soft-spoken while males are labelled as competitive and technologically inclined,' she notes in most computer games (Gilmour: 2004). Chaudhuri explains the relationship between male supremacy in the industry and masculine ways of representation by looking at male domination in involvement and ownership in the mass media industry.

Exploring reality shows such as *Who Wants to Be a Millionaire?* Chaudhuri claims that women are less likely to apply, are less likely to be picked, and are less likely to win substantial awards. This finding is supported by the fact that most of these applications are created, presented, and assembled by men. Most of the questions asked in such contests are probably geared toward men. Female contestants may be treated differently than male contenders. She claims that, despite a rise in women's employment and participation in the media industry, the sector's larger culture remained masculinist, which eventually influenced the mode of representation and shaped content that was primarily masculine in nature (Chaudhuri: 1999).

Such gender distinctions are not based on any fundamental differences between boys and girls, but rather on the 'ideologies and assumptions of researchers and developers'. Gilmour discovered that the disparities between male and girl gamers are mostly due to 'cultural gendering of leisure and play', rather than intrinsic biological variations, after surveying 180 students (90 boys and 90 girls) about their genre preferences. While game software makers treat females as a homogeneous, gendered group, girls' game preferences and usage remain heterogeneous. Gilmour encourages computer scientists to think beyond traditional views of femininity as a monolithic category that unavoidably limits female behaviour, enjoyment and self-definition (Gilmour: 2004).

There is a broad pattern of stereotyping the image of the female protagonist in Indian Cinema industries, ranging from Bollywood to all south Indian industries. In Indian cinema, there is a trend toward homogenizing the physical look and mental attitudes of female leads. Men were considered as writers of true authentic literature—objective, and in control of their aesthetic methods, while women were seen as readers of ‘inferior literature, subjective, emotional, and passive’. It creates a double-edged process of sexualization and marginalization when it comes to women of colour or Dalit women (Rowena: 2012). It will be worthwhile tracing the feminist scholarship in its distinct strands while tracing the question of the representation of women and the question of body politic in contemporary media.

FEMINISM AND MEDIA STUDIES

For the past three to four decades, feminism has been without a doubt one of the most significant theoretical turns in academics, particularly in debates on media and culture. Feminism dominated media studies, seeking social change and continuing to reject male-dominated involvement and representation in the business. Feminism has become a ‘dirty’ word to some extent (particularly in male receptions) as a political and scholarly movement that continuously threatens the status quo. This is largely due to media misinterpretation of feminist principles. Furthermore, feminism has become divided in recent years (due to its inability to portray the variations amongst women (in terms of caste, class, race, ethnicity and sexuality) and has found itself under new criticisms and some of them perceived as ‘from within’ (Casey et al.: 2004). Feminism emphasizes gender as a large and crucial aspect of our cultural identity as a political, social, and academic movement as well as a theoretical approach. Gender is seen as a significant factor that shapes our physical and social environments. Various streams of feminist thought evolved at different historical junctures, each with its distinct viewpoints, such as Marxist, Liberal, Radical, black, and Dalit feminisms. However, at various degrees, they all claimed that men as a social group have treated women in a variety of unflattering ways in economic, political, educational, and social institutions. It’s worth noting that feminism

has viewed patriarchy as more than just a case of men oppressing or discriminating against women. Patriarchy is established in our culture and social structures, according to feminism, and this could influence men's conduct and views toward women. In terms of stereotyping women's lives in the media texts and women's engagement in the business, media as a powerful institution in shaping and expressing gender relations has also come under feminist scrutiny.

While early feminist concerns were on women's lack of power in the media business, feminist interventions in the 1970s focused mostly on women's limited representation and unfavourable stereotyping of their images and lives. Scholars such as Laura Mulvey introduced a new method of thinking about the gaze in the mid-1970s, focusing on spectator posture to see a film or television via male eyes—the male gaze thesis (Mulvey: 1975). The approach is based on the idea that the male gaze sexualizes women and turns them into mere sexual objects to be looked at. Here looking is understood to involve desire, control or desire to control. The male gaze is tangled up with the questions of power. Because stereotyping is not a simple and obvious phenomenon, feminist scholarship has recently begun to examine it more critically. The construction and representation of masculinity and masculine sexuality were also examined. The relationship between the second aspect and its impact on content and representation becomes a topic of contention. Male camera operators, directors, and producers have objectified women's bodies and limited women's range of positions.

Even though gender encompasses both men's and women's issues, the majority of critical writings and debates have focused on women's experiences and portrayal until recently. Recent studies, on the other hand, have attempted to broaden the scope of gender and media studies by focusing on issues such as masculine sexualities, discourse, and representation of men. Men, in most media texts, inhabit a wider range of roles, that too in the public domains of occupation in the form of professionals, employers and labourers. They can be found in a wide range of ages, as well as different body types and vocal tones. Many studies of commercials and television shows imply that women are portrayed as domestic beings (as

housewives or mothers) or as sexual objects or accessories to males in advertisements and television shows (bodies to sell products or assistants to powerful men).

The portrayal of older women is frequently associated with themes of cruelty and unkindness (as in the case of mother-in-law in Indian soap operas) or amusement. Women from ethnic minorities, particularly Dalit and dark-skinned women, are frequently presented as the 'other' and as 'evil' and 'undesirable' characters. In contrast, 'typical' femininity is overwhelmingly depicted as young, thin, tall, fair-skinned, and heterosexually domestic. On the other hand, 'normal' masculinity is often seen as less restricted and more often associated with action, power, authority and control. Matlin explains how the medium shapes reality, and how stereotyped depictions impact women's perceptions of what they should look like. Girls and women frequently forget this and become overly sensitive to marketing (Carter and Steiner: 2004). We must analyse the contemporaneous and convergent meanings that advertising and their surrounding materials build and distribute about gender constitution as a whole.

TAKING ISSUES WITH THE 'HOT' CONTENT

Some scholars claim that internet spaces such as social networking sites like Facebook and Twitter, Instagram, personal blogs, and video-sharing sites like YouTube provide emancipatory potentials for excluded populations. The essential premise of this argument is that everyone could generate content that can challenge and oppose dominant and hegemonic images. However, most of the fields in these virtual places continue to contain anti-women, anti-Dalit, and racist rhetoric. For instance, if one types any (celebrity) woman's name in the search box (of Google or YouTube), the topmost leading suggestions/options would be 'hot', 'hot videos', and 'sexy' after those women's names. But this rarely happens in the case of their male counterparts. Social networking services like Facebook and Twitter have been a revelation in interacting with people, from the Arab Spring to the Anna Hazare campaign. Recently, a group of young

people known as 'change.org', a social change portal, initiated an online campaign to remove sexually violent content from social networking sites such as Facebook. The study discovered that there is a lot of sexually aggressive information circulating in these virtual forums that makes women the mere objects of misogynic appropriation ((Young: 2000; Tejaswi: 2012). In the era of social media representations, overwhelming toxic content in the form of images and comments on the YouTube, Instagram and Facebook have become commonplace. In certain occasions, the intrusions in the form of stalking and bullying get extended to the real-life situations of violence, making a continuity to the idea of 'following' with a literal meaning of the term without the consent of the offended.

Robert Jenson investigates how the sexual charge is linked to the concept of male dominance and female submission which is important in contemporary commercial pornography by looking at visual spaces regarding sexual content and the making of pornography (Jenson: 2004).

He claims that whether a pornographer feels guilty or proud of his actions, the end consequence is the same: pornography continues to sexualize and objectify women, reducing them to simply sexual bodies for male enjoyment. As Jenson claims, pornography creates or reinforces desires for specific acts, most of which are focused on male pleasure and can cause female pain. Rather than unlocking sexual creativity, pornography shapes and constrains a person's sexual imagination with its standardized scripts. Jenson also adds that race plays an important aspect in scripting pornography, which reinforces the view of women of colour as the 'exotic primitive'.

For Jenson, the notion of authentic sexual desire is problematic; there is no pure, natural sexuality that is not mediated by culture. Here he simply contends that pornography is a force that can shape desire and that we should be concerned with how men may be conditioned to desire sexual acts that are humiliating, degrading and sometimes painful for women (Jenson: 2004). His observations on the interconnections of gender and race in the manifestation of body-politics in visual media necessitate a conceptual foundation, which can then shed light on the concept of pleasure in watching images of women of colour.

GAZE AND THE IDEA OF PLEASURE

In relation to studies on the domains of visual cultures, film, and television in particular, the male gaze has been a prominent topic of feminist intervention. Laura Mulvey's psychoanalytical approach to the idea of the male gaze and pleasure in mainstream Hollywood movies opened new theoretical options in this argument (Mulvey: 1975). The works of Kaja Silverman, Teresa de Lauretis, Barbara Creed, bell hooks, and Ann Kaplan, among others, have recently sparked a substantial theoretical wave in the subject of feminist film theory (hooks: 1992; Kaplan: 2004; Mulvey et al.: 2006). Feminist interventions in the domain of television also gathered momentum in the works of Lila Abu-Lughod, Tania Modleski, Laura Stempel Mumford, Ien Ang, Deborah Jermyn and so on (Abu-Lughod: 1988; Akass & McCabe: 2006). However, feminist media criticism is never confined to the frame of simply focusing on the male gaze and the problem of representation.

bell hooks' writings provided a fresh reading of the visual field against the usual trope of understanding gaze and representation from the viewpoint of the white feminist scholars. Contextualizing the idea of an oppositional gaze, hooks writes: '...the politics of slavery, of racialized power relations, were such that the slaves were denied their right to gaze. The "gaze" has been and is a site of resistance for colonized black people globally. Subordinates in relations of power learn experientially that there is a critical gaze, one that "looks" to document; one that is oppositional' (hooks: 1992, 116). She goes on to say that stereotypically humiliating and dehumanizing depictions of blackness coexisted with a critical practice that restored presence where it had been lost. When the absence of black bodies in politically progressive film texts is replaced by their presence, stereotypes are often resurrected to fit into white viewers' aesthetics, where victimization becomes a source of pleasure. This proclivity for depicting black bodies creates a barrier between the viewer and the image. 'Black films were also subject to critical interrogation', according to hooks, 'as they came into being in part as a response to white-dominated cinema's failure to represent blackness in a way that did not reinforce white supremacy, they too were critiqued to see if images were seen as complicit with dominant cinematic practices'.

hooks goes on to say that black women's long silence as observers and critics was a reaction to absence, to cinematic denial (ibid.: 117-18).

The question of denial and absence that the cinematic space presents for coloured women, as expressed in the framework of hooks, may be applied to understanding how 'caste bodies' are represented in Indian mainstream cinema, particularly Bollywood. When it comes to the critical literature on body politics, however, the topic of women's presence and representation arises at the level of problematizing the sexualized bodies of upper caste/fair-bodied women. Concerns about what happens to the bodies of women of colour when their photographs are transmitted in a sphere of spectatorship that is largely influenced by the notions of caste and untouchability, as well as masculine gaze. Jenny Rowena's account of Silk Smitha's biopic *The Dirty Picture* (Dir. Milan Luthria 2011), tackles this tricky context of body-politic and the caste question imprinted in cinematic texts where the idea of sexuality and visual pleasure are subject to scrutiny through a different vantage point (Rowena: 2012). Rowena's critique enables us to broaden the frame of oppositional gaze within the context of caste, not prompting us to settle easily within the binaries of the victim or the perpetrator. Drawing from hooks (1992) and reading through Rowena (2012), I argue that the Black and therefore the Dalit-Bahujan female spectators, who refuse to identify with white/upper caste womanhood, who would not settle with the idea of phallocentric gaze of desire and possession, but attempt to craft a critical space where the binary opposition that Mulvey offers—'woman as image, man as bearer of the look'—gets continually deconstructed.

Recognizing the presence of black and Dalit female audiences would open a conceptual space for discussing pleasure politics in the context of the dissemination of pictures of coloured bodies. Relocating representational arguments from within the text to the practices that texts produce during their circulation would allow for a more critical analysis. According to hooks, mainstream feminism has made little attempt to investigate the idea that women can develop an opposing perspective through a better understanding and awareness of race and racist politics. 'Feminist film theory, rooted in an ahistorical

psychoanalytic framework that privileges sexual difference, actively suppresses recognition of race, reenacting and mirroring the erasure of black womanhood that occurs in films, silencing any discussion of racial difference—of racialized sexual difference.’ Her claims substantiate the fact that grotesque bodies carry different histories and biographies (hooks: 1992, 122). This necessitates a methodological shift toward documenting subaltern women’s spectatorial experiences to comprehend concerns of representation and body politics from a contrasting perspective to mainstream feminist concepts.

As against the survey model of reception studies, there is a growing demand towards micro-social histories to be constructed through the methods of critical ethnography and historical anthropology (Lughod: 2006). Instead of relying on the narrow idea of reception in a quantitatively naïve manner, it is imperative to have accounts of media experiences of individuals beyond the textual aspects of representation. How media generate new ways of organizing daily life for different groups of people especially in the time of new media platforms and gadgets invites critical attention from emerging scholars. Daniel Miller’s account on Facebook communities in Trinidad and Tobago would throw light on such a critical scholarly endeavour beyond the textual domain of media and enter the contours of practice through ethnographic explorations (Miller: 2010). To conclude, it is evident from the above discussions that representations of gender and gendered bodies are neither simple nor the audience readings of the text are rather complex and multi-dimensional, and critical scrutiny cannot limit its analytical scope within the text, but to engage with what kinds of practices that texts generate as social practices.

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CHAPTER 7

Consuming and Producing Feminism through Indian Media Analysis of Empowerment, Commodification in Culture Industry

BISWAJIT DAS AND RIDHI KAKKAR

INTRODUCTION

This chapter examines the theoretical grounds of the assumption that *empowerment* can potentially foster a better portrayal of women through media. During the late 1990s, when popular discourse shifted towards *girl power* rhetoric, media, and accompanying concepts were deliberately co-related with contemporary ideas on *How empowerment can be attained?* and, *national policies* were re-examined to identify perils and paradoxes to promote empowerment. Inspired by the events and the subsequent *National Policy for the Empowerment of Women*, this paper seeks to examine the notion of empowerment as it corresponds to feminist agency.

Drawing from theoretical viewpoints in both political economy and feminism, this chapter elucidates ‘girl power’ rhetoric as is articulated in popular and feminist discourses. While using the idea of commodification, this paper demonstrates that not all ‘girl power’ rhetoric extends the desired opportunity to women to transcend individual consumption, further, propose collective change in social relations. Even though several feminist literatures are available and offer critique of culture by pin-pointing the body as a site of ideological production; yet this paper demonstrates and emphasizes the need to re-look at the material production of culture. Further,

this paper lays together the concepts of agency, empowerment and commodification in subsequent sections. Lastly, this paper demonstrates the farce of the 'girl power' rhetoric. With the support of empirical examples, this paper depicts the extent to which the commodified 'girl power' rhetoric has distorted feminist notions.

Framing the Issue

A notion emerging out of academic debates and deliberations emphasizes the need of *third political liberations*, i.e., a liberation from unrepresentative and partisan role of women in India. Formerly, from welfare to development and now from development to empowerment, as argued by scholars and policymakers unanimously, such a departure in the notion of liberation requires transformation from within itself in Indian society. The proceedings of the 'National Policy for the Empowerment of Women 2001' states the following:

Within the framework of a democratic polity, our laws, development policies, plans and programmes have aimed at women's advancement in different spheres ... there has been a marked shift in the approach to women's issues from welfare to development. In recent years, the empowerment of women has been recognized as the central issue in determining the status of women (p. 5).

The said quotation endorses the view of empowerment as central to western democratic theory and practices; in which empowerment is treated as gaining political ability over those who govern. However, in presence of multiple varied terms for '*development*'—it is somehow difficult to reach an agreement or unambiguous statements as of *what empowerment in effect entails or how it becomes apparent in an individual, a group or society at any level*. Even the academic interventions solely dedicated to scrutinizing the said dimension of development, do not provide comprehensive and uncontested definitions of empowerment. Therefore, we are forced to deduce the meaning of the term '*development or empowerment*' only from the context of its inclusion in existing literature. As of now, there are two polar views on the 'empowerment' of the people in connection with the state.

The first view, as endorsed by the World Bank, visualizes empowerment 'as a process by which ordinary people, and especially women... take greater responsibility for improving their lives'. Thus, unburdening the state and reducing its role by channelling responsibilities towards citizens. This interpretation reflects the economic point of view of the Bank, where people are expected to be the motor of society and adopt the role of entrepreneurs, rather than the state.

The second extreme view, based on 'dependency school', associated with the theories of Paulo Freire (1970), considers 'empowerment' as a process meant to enhance people's abilities to achieve rights, emancipate themselves from dependent economic relations and make endeavours for their just demands on state and its office-bearers.

The former position upholds the dominant modernization view of socio-economic headways. Under the modernization perspective, the economic and social premises of the capitalist market system are looked upon to prepare grounds for achieving equitable development. Advocates of this view promoted that the inequities are the result of flawed application of market principles at specific places or points in time. However, lately, it has been observed by multilateral proponents such as the World Bank and UNDP that specified set of political conditions are also crucial and required for the market to function in a manner, which leads to greater equity. Whereas the latter position puts more emphasis on bringing 'empowerment' through changes in social relations, i.e., by expanding the influence or control of the poor and downtrodden over political and bureaucratic systems. However, the pervasive economic order limits the scope of such an outcome to the improvement in the material position only. Therefore, policies revolve around assisting the poor to strengthen their material position within the exigencies of a prevailing market economy.

These varying concepts of 'empowerment' not only acknowledge, but also integrate the concept of 'democratic transformation' within them. It is through 'democratic transformation', that both structural economic reform and political change blend together to make the state more accountable to its citizens. In a nutshell, it suggests the need for attaining required long-term re-arrangements of political

and economic relations; thus, ensuring permanent benefits/solutions to the women, instead of mere temporary appropriations within the existing order of things. Before the issue is settled, the recent policy document *National Policy for Women: Articulating a Vision for Empowerment of Women* 2016, (Draft) highlights

women's empowerment has been envisaged as a socially inclusive right-based approach while reinforcing the rights and entitlements provided under the 'Constitution of India'. The policy will enable sustainable socio-economic, political empowerment of women to claim their rights and entitlements, control over resources and formulation of strategic choices in the realization of the principles of gender equality and justice (p. 1).

The shift from empowerment to gender justice is a progressive step ahead. Popular representations and discourses welcomed and popularized the 'girl power' across various fields and professions.

Some considered this shift in perspective a progressive step, whereas for others, it was nothing more than mere rhetoric. The results were starting to show up in various activities, be it in work front, education, sports especially, not in traditional girl sports alone but in masculine sports such as hockey, cricket, lawn tennis, and basketball and in popular culture such as in film, music, video and so on. These accomplishments in specific events and fields encouraged the infusion of girl power rhetoric and girls rule paraphernalia that later became part of popular discourse and culture in India.

Scholars in academia as well as among feminist groups, initiated discussions about the ongoing transitions in feminist consciousness and struggling with issues of difference and diversity. While this movement might have encouraged women to be powerful and empowered; the national policy on women promoted a very different type of empowerment of women, contrary from the one being popularized by media and articulated as 'girl power'. Interestingly, the document of *National Policy for Women: Articulating a Vision for Empowerment of Women* 2016, (Draft), moves one step ahead by incorporating empowerment within the context of women's rights. It assumes that the issue of rights would provide access to opportunities, resources, and choices with the freedom of decision-making both within and outside home. Empowerment would be achieved only

when advancement in the conditions of women is accompanied by their ability to influence the direction of social change gained through equal opportunities in economic, social, and political spheres of life (p. 1).

Agency and Empowerment

Feminist scholars have written extensively about the issue of 'agency', further, those who belong to the field of cultural studies have also made intriguing observations about the 'agency'. However, within feminist studies the concept of 'agency' has been pre-dominantly theorized with women's resistance, thus, taking no notice of various sorts of independent action at the level of an individual.

Scholars working on women's studies have incorporated as well as theorized the term 'empowerment', whereas the rhetoric of empowerment, in general, is quite common in India's policy discourse. This is to imply that agency and empowerment might appear coterminous, but for the feminist cultural analysis, the appropriation of empowerment into mainstream popular culture is highly problematic. One of the pressing concerns is that women 'at the level of individual' may feel empowered but the same cannot be said for women as a collective body. Thus, a reference from Chantal Mouffe (1979) is worth discussing where she remarked that hegemonic expansion is a by-product of the commodification of empowerment. Following the thought line of Mouffe (1979), this paper argues that the rhetoric of empowerment, instead of challenging power relations meaningfully, does nothing but contributes to rearticulating and recirculating the ever-existing patriarchal and capitalist values. Further, some scholars have also offered novel interpretations to existing understandings of the term 'empowerment'.

Scholars (Albrecht: 1988; Zimmeraman: 1995) highlight the ability to exert collective influence over the conditions of life or to control one's own life and destiny can also be deemed as 'empowerment'. Hence, it is not always that empowerment occurs on the individual level, it can occur at various levels such as interpersonal, professional, organizational, societal, etc. But it is always expected that empowerment at individual level must shape collective behaviour

and actions thus leading women to act on remaining levels to challenge and supersede oppressive power relations. Ristock and Pennell (1996) consider empowerment in their work as accessing the means to alter power relations. Empowerment also means creating and evolving new 'perceptions' by scholars (see Albrecht: 1988; Chiles and Zorn: 1995). For them, empowerment becomes a part of the reformatory approach, i.e., to build and create knowledge that eventually leads the change in the conditions of lives towards betterment, both at individual and collective levels. Jo Rowlands (1997) defines empowerment as a concept that must strive to reverse the top-down hierarchical approach by bringing theories and means of desired social change to praxis. For Rowlands, practical ways can only help people bring changes in the social milieu.

Rowlands (1997) states, that since empowerment can be experienced through the dimensions of personal, relational and collective, it is important to highlight and caution about the risks invoked by such collective actions. She added that as a demerit empowerment or any collective action tends to get carried away with its presupposed meanings, which may drive the people into the ideological trap of 'right to left'. Just because the term lacks precision in the meaning and is further perplexed by circulation and appropriation in popular discourses; barely there is any scope left for that 'rhetoric of empowerment' to inculcate a sense of individual enlightenment and pose a challenge to patriarchal structures. In this situation, chances are higher that the 'rhetoric of empowerment' unwittingly adds to individual pretensions rather than attaining some designated goals.

Feminists believe in collective agency, but at the same time, they leave space to exercise individual agency. Thus, they encourage agnostic responses while posing resistance to structural constraints. However, the notion of resistance can be problematic as witnessed by certain subcultural studies (Hebdige: 1979). Further, Schweickart (1995) added that the 'politics of resistance' may accentuate individual agency, but in this situation also engulfed in the same debacle as that in 'empowerment'. Thus, if people behave like individual actors and freely exercise their agency rather than being feminist agents social change may never occur. Moreover, if the notion of resistance

presupposes the definition of agency, then there is a possibility of overlooking the importance of material culture shaping social relations. Therefore, Louis McNay (2000) problematizes the ambiguity in definition of 'agency' and the conundrums of conceptualizing 'agency' solely as 'resistance'. Not to deny the efficacy of all forms of resistance, but it is to suggest that a more precise and varied account of agency is required to explain the differing motivations and ways in which individuals and groups struggle over, appropriate and transform cultural meanings and resources. This, in turn, indicates the necessity of contextualizing agency within power relations in order to understand how acts deemed as resistant may transcend their immediate sphere in order to transform collective behaviours and norms.

Schweickart (1995) stated that the idea of forming a woman collective and at the same time becoming subjected to the collective itself has bothered many feminists. Also, at the same time, a group/collective cannot be simply carved out and made to work harmoniously from self-interested individuals. Hence, it becomes apparent that if at all 'agency' has to be exercised then it certainly cannot be enacted solely at the level of individual or in partisan interests of individuals in particular. Henceforth, Schweickart (1995), asserted a need of a feminist arrangement that acknowledges heterogeneity and diversity of opinion (so as to maintain agency) as well as creates space for collective engagement without undermining or nullifying individual autonomy. This debate of empowerment and agency is inherently challenging and results in a displeasing compromise where women have to choose whether to 'act' or to 'resist'.

If at all empowerment stops at the level of individual, as hypothetically proposed by Ristock and Pennell (1996) and Rowlands (1997) and there is no consciousness beyond that of the individuals solely, then *'how one can expect transformation in social consciousness and confrontation to social practices that subjugate women?'* Furthermore, Ristock and Pennell (1996) and Rowlands (1997) observed a sudden upsurge in the use of 'the rhetoric of empowerment' in popular discourses as well as in women's self-help literature. Thereby they theorized that the commodification of the idea of 'empowerment' has confined the agency to the level of an individual only; thus,

restricting any contributions to structural transformations and narrowing the scope of the liberation of women living in patriarchal structures.

The policy document ('National Policy for the Empowerment of Women 2001') highlights of the question of media:

... will be used to portray images consistent with human dignity of girls and women. The policy will specifically strive to remove demeaning, degrading and negative conventional stereotypical images of women and violence against women. Private sector partners and media networks will be involved at all levels to ensure equal access for women particularly in the area of information and communication technologies. The Media would be encouraged to develop codes of conduct, professional guidelines and other self-regulatory mechanisms to remove gender stereotypes and promote balanced portrayals of women and men (p. 15).

A closer reading of this paragraph suggests that the policy document highlights:

1. the need for a better image of women through media,
2. participation and access of women in ICT, and finally,
3. to develop guidelines and regulatory mechanisms to remove sex role segregation between men and women.

Although one cannot undermine wishful thinking. *However, it does not clarify, how empowerment will be achieved. Or does the fulfilment of the above three objectives lead to empowerment?* One is back to square one to the same question of understanding empowerment. While the policy discourse assumes a different meaning of empowerment, the popular discourse reflects the contrary; especially, in entertainment and other popular forms of culture.

The experts have always thought of cultural production and consumption as a reason for the resurgence of the empowerment of women. This further posed a query whether the rise and upsurge of a feminist movement in India should merely be considered as a cultural phenomenon. The answer of this query may be affirmative only if the feminist movement remains within the periphery of philosophical discussion. But if the feminist movement is located within the 'relations of production' of burgeoning capitalist society, then feminist philosophy itself becomes political or at least as a

politics of representation. Moreover, it entails mass persuasion and publicity, demands for efficiency, productivity, resource allocation, power struggles, cooperations, etc. at the time of their concrete manifestation within the media. All these encompass the domain of the political economy of media. Considering the ever-advancing economy, it has become pertinent to enquire whether varying non-cultural aspects such as economic structures or market forces are hindering the development of feminist values. All this is happening in the face of the increasing prevalence of pluralism. Therefore, it brings the discussion to the question, of whether Indian women will develop their consciousness and form a strong movement; thus, by sweeping the market directions and interests. When the capitalist market is the core subject, even then it is given a pejorative meaning, whenever analysed with culture. While growing up in a tech-abundant age, many Indian women have started using electronic gadgets and the internet, besides other forms of mass media-produced consumer culture. Thus, 'commodification' offers a point of entry from where such social relations can be examined. 'Commodification', illustrates the differences between the portrayals in popular culture and the empowerment of women; and how these become conflated.

The process of commodification is important as well as two-folded in the field of communication. It enables media commodities to produce surplus value for the owners as well as frame and shape the consciousness of the audience's minds while circulating the ideological meaning. Considering the duality of cultural commodities, Meehan (1994) suggests 'one must rethink media commodities as both culture industry and industrial culture' (p. 564) as cultural commodities comprise both social relations and ideological meanings. Dallas Smythe (1978) too has written significantly about the process of commodification suggesting that the process turns the 'audience' to mere commodity of media. Smythe's argument brings into the picture the linkages between media content, advertisers and audience in turning the audience into a commodity. Further, Mosco (1996) terms 'a set of binding reciprocal relationships' whereby media companies construct audiences through programming and advertisers pay for access to audiences (p. 148). Hence, the audience as a commodity is manufactured and sold by media to corporations.

Symthe's contribution has widened the horizon of commodity production beyond the periphery of media, i.e., newspapers, magazines, television, films, etc.; thus, portraying how the rhetoric of empowerment is being used and drawing in the claim of the audience.

Girl Power and the Cultural Production

Cultural production of 'girl power' takes in the form of music, film, art, via the internet, club culture, etc. These messages are overtly political, and many girls with a girl power sensibility engage in activism via their cultural production. The women involved in these nebulous movements distrust conventional politics. They evade any media-given labels and publicly denounce attempts to gather their divergent work into the ambit one single category. Many of the women involved in the early stages of the movement are college-educated and well-versed to some extent in feminist theory. Which partly forms the basis for their feminist consciousness. Some common themes that emerge, centre on girls controlling their cultural production. Women become courageous to take action against constraining patriarchal capitalist institutions by getting inspired by the radical messages. Before computers became popular among the masses and became widely accessible to the Indian middle class, people used to make collages out of magazines, newspapers, etc. and arrange printed words and pictures into new contexts and new meanings. Even after the arrival of computers and sophisticated printing solutions that have made production and distribution easier, artists still admire the non-professional old rustic look. This aesthetic adds credibility to and promotes their critique of hegemonic structures and contributes to the emotion of a genuine rebellion against the status quo of professionalization. While the circulation of such materials helps expand this feminist network; further, the internet enables the fostering a dynamic movement. These materials, through the internet, are circulated, distributed, and connected across the globe and the websites are turning into e-zines with inspiring essays and engrossing trending discussions. The internet promoted 'girl power' and supported to building and maintaining a network community of girls. Several websites circulated information

about feminist gatherings such as time, date and locations for meetings and other events. Most of the websites also included some sort of 'mission statements' that propose and promote the feminist objectives in general as well as a person's interpretation of the subject. The understanding promoted by these websites of third-wave feminism sets the grounds for second-wave feminist's critique of overarching social structures, including ideas, power and subjectivity as envisioned in postmodern feminism.

Even though the discussion above celebrates 'girl power' cultural production; it is important to recognize that the material and art loaded with 'girl power' message are also commodified and structured by the constraints of exchange value, thereby feminist content on the women portals and internet are also organized within the constraints of capitalism. However, the semi-independent production and distribution network at least promotes a feminist message which is inherently different from the typical 'girl power' rhetoric being produced and circulated through popular culture. These motivated organizations as groups work as collectives, therefore, artists have more say and authority over operations. Their work, ideas, narratives, visions, political messages, etc. are not compromised, and their labour is not solely governed by profit motives. Amid the discussion above one cannot rule out the nature of exchange value and oppressive patterns of production and distribution following a capitalist model; even then one can suggest with conviction that this alternative process has somehow challenged the patriarchal and capitalist structures.

Commodifying Girl Power

Even though 'girl power' as a social movement refrained from any associations with commodification but idea of women's empowerment could not be able to elude itself from getting commodified. Cultural products such as music, videos, films, magazines, etc. have promoted and popularized the notion of 'girl power' and encouraged society members to value girls and prioritize their needs and issues. This follows the logic that if society starts to value girls, then, in return girls will also feel optimistic and empowered. The idea of 'girl power' is notable, but has been reified into tangible commodities bought

and sold by entertainment corporations in the form of music, soap opera, films, etc. These evident examples of popular culture portray how use value, the notion of empowering girls has eventually changed into exchange value. Thus, the commodities which are aimed for empowering girls in a process of transformation have lost their original meaning and essence. This diluted meaning of girl power has been rearticulated in a number of ways to appeal to the masses. Therefore, feminists criticize the ideologically contradictory meanings embedded in popular culture by revealing how contradictory textual meanings dominate the largest audiences for profit purposes. Most evident of them are women related soaps running on prime-time slots, advertisements, films, music videos, etc. These are the products of the most notorious mainstream projections of feminism, loaded with themes and misleading messages of woman empowerment.

As Ipshita Chanda (2000) rightly points out,

Television ads are seductively defining the persona of the modern woman, an entity that we, within the women's movement cannot ignore. And it is because of this seductive through ambiguous projection that we find, echoes of a familiar rhetoric popularized by the struggles of the women's movement, being appropriated in the service of systems and structures that these struggles were and are being waged against. The meanings of words like rights, equality, freedom or even empowerment seem to be sliding out of our control and even beyond our comprehension (p. 42).

In the television films advertisements or any other fiction, men play the role of the dominant protagonist, the whole fictional narrative revolves around them, they are treated as masters; while women are always given side roles as their supporters, admirers, caretakers and entertainers not more than a prop in a narrative (Behera: 1989).

Similarly, the women-oriented serials highlight anti-women images. The heroine miraculously overcomes her repression and mouths a few sentences about her power and independence (Choudhury: 1987). Most of these serials construct Masculine and Feminine genders as opposites. A few heroic women are shown but cast as redeemers of patriarchy. The trend to commercialization creates new contradictions (Krishnan and Dighe: 1990).

The films in India reflect diverse views of the empowerment of women. Although, occasionally, they posit a conflict between modern feminism and traditional values, however, in the last analysis they surrender to the age-old patriarchal values. Popular songs of the films pose women as intoxicating objects and serve as erotic objects. Invariably, the songs are showcased much before the release of films and work as an advert for the films. The constant repeat of these songs makes the viewers a nation of voyeurs. The song sequence does not serve only to present the female body as a spectacle. Indeed, song sequences are choreographed with movements which simulate sexual intercourse. Invariably, in these sexual postures, the image of the male being the dominant one and the woman as the receptacle who must be seen to be enjoying what is being done to her. Popular Hindi cinema as well as TV series, promotes unrealistic images of women through an archaic set of values. The celluloid place of women is always lower or lesser than the male hero. The male is projected as an active decision-maker of the house while the female as someone living at the mercy of the male heads of the family. This represents the depending on the image of women that has proven to be a hurdle for the feminist movement in India. But due to some serious and dedicated efforts of some committed individuals the image of women started evolving from being a mere social and domestic necessity. Thus, this turns Indian cinema into a battleground for gender wars, with women not ever standing up to supremacy.

Rao (1989) studied changing versions of femininity over 75-years in mainstream as well as so-called art films in India. She captures aptly in her study the images of women: a shift from goddesses to dream girls to the new woman. The female characters in the movies are used to portray the conventional structures of a patriarchal society. In defense the filmmakers of the industry stated that women in films are not degraded rather in a few instances they are stereotyped (Bagchi: 1996). Further, Bagchi comments that although there are exceptions such as films like *Mother India*, *Bandini*, *Sujata*, *Arth*, *Aradhana*, *Anupama*, *Mili*, *Aandhi* and *Ankur* invariably, most of the successful films of yester years show that female characters promote the legend that popular icons are women who have no ambitions or

interest beyond dressing up to the nines for their beloveds, or stepping out of their four walls once they've ensnared their spouses and who derive joy and pride from serving in-laws, looking after their precocious children and queening over the kitchen a la *Biwi No. 1* (Bagchi: 1996).

The new generation of filmmakers is no way exception to it except catering to the market by reinforcing the stereotypes. Bagchi analyses that a film like *Dushman*, a story based on women's empowerment ultimately takes recourse to male support to achieve desired results. Rarely, do women actresses have a voice to question their roles, although a few exceptions are there.

While the film portrays women in a conservative role, recent music videos have added a considerable amount of sensation to the Indian cultural scenario. Although there are opposition by the larger society to some extent but music-videos with their remix and dance sequences brought to the limelight another conception of women. This shift can be viewed from passive, exploited, oppressed to active, exploiting and oppressing the other. The woman is shown in skimpy dresses wearing full-on make-up, and a lot of body adornments, etc. to enhance the sexual appeal. The messages which are being conveyed through these 'item-songs or dance numbers' are highly distorted and suggest that the empowerment of women means vulgarity, overt sexuality, and temptation for the male gaze. Also, the lyrics of the song and nature of body gestures are created in a manner which portrays that girls can only achieve power and empowerment by using their sexuality and looks.

Since time immemorial, society has a perception that women gain access to power through their sexuality and appearance. Even their whims and fancies are considered an ornament of sexuality. Women's intelligence and skills are never given due recognition. Thus, women are considered whimsical and media representations are products as well as manifest evidence of this prejudice. These messages are not new, through out 1970s-80s second-wave feminists have countered them. In continuation of second-wave feminism, third-wave feminism depicts efforts towards degendering of the body. They redefined the notion of beauty and sexuality. But, if television 'soaps' turned towards a more conservative-impractical appearance/

outlook of women to adorn the male gaze; then the music videos in the name of subverting the patriarchal gaze, capitalized the women's bodies by the voluptuous portrayal of female beauty. Music videos were not celebrating all types of women's bodies such as fat, one-breasted, short, hippy, dark and so on rather, in due process they are reinscribing the socially acceptable benchmarks and institutionally set body types.

Even though media content celebrates make-up, beauty, clothes and other aspects of girl culture they don't question or rather hide that the girls are not free to choose, or they lack the agency to freely make choices. Females are socialized in a manner which doesn't give them direct access to economic or political power. Patriarchal society is structured in a manner that doesn't permit women to exercise agency without seeking male's approval. Therefore, media content primarily served as the indirect means of accessing the empowerment of women. If females being the active consumer of media content take charge of their beauty and sexuality, even then they become subservient to the male gaze. Thereby, women should be encouraged to develop means to acquire power by becoming independent and vocal about their needs rather than adhering to the material culture promoted by media content.

Many feminists believe that the media doesn't perceive patriarchal institutions as a real threat. Media instead of challenging the status quo, uses the status quo to generate favourable attention and profit. Media neither suggest any alternative for women's empowerment nor encourages them to seek political or economic power. While celebrating girl culture, media organizations mask patriarchal and capitalist structures and pave the way for oppressive behaviours. Therefore, when the media content highlights and standardizes female beauty and body types with accompanying messages of empowerment then they indeed trying to sell their pro-girl artefacts—commodified feminism.

Third-wave feminism is different from the brand of feminism posed by the music videos because it not only recognizes feminist body politics but also pays attention to structural forces such as patriarchy and capitalism that add on to the constraints on women. While third-wave feminist asserts their sexuality, it is not necessarily

for the male gaze shall change. Girls shall be treated as both subject and object of the male gaze. The third-wave of feminism redefined sexuality by encouraging girls to take pleasure in their bodies, like themselves no matter what size, shape, or colour. Also, it contributed hugely to debunking notions such as racism, sexism, homophobia, heterosexualism, fatism, ageism, etc. and accompanying injustices with it. Although third-wave feminism never intended to be commodified, certain aspects no matter what got transferred into commodities, such as the notion of girl power.

One of the drawbacks of girl power commodification is the symbolic exclusion of elderly or older age women as 'soap series' leads. Several TV producers accepted that to target the mainstream audience which has developed a liking for young women as well as most of the advertisers, they prefer to cast younger women in the roles. This not only depicts the change in demographics but also exposes the falseness of TV programmes messages about socially just society for women. Like any other industry, the media industry too follows the dictum of revenue.

The internet and its accessibility have grown greatly, it has become more interactive as well as much more commercial. It encouraged several young women with similar views and opinions to connect. While capitalizing on the girl power rhetoric, several advertiser-driven platforms and services on the internet have developed. These platforms are then sold to advertisers.

While closely examining the matter, one shall find that more emphasis is being laid on expanding the domain of duties and responsibilities of the females, rather than reclaiming the 'rights', to keep patriarchy and male domination intact (CAR: 2007, 187).

For instance, in the plot of the TV serial *Kahani Ghar Ghar Ki*, a blind girl is being raped by two male members of the family. Daughters-in-law, the protagonist of the show, who is depicted as very bold, independent, and mighty fights for justice for that girl (victim of rape), while going against the will of her husband and the family. The mother-in-law applauds her daughter-in-law for her intentions to seek justice for the rape victim, but at the same time reminds her about her duty to preserve the honour of the family.

Thus, *Maaji* (mother-in-law) proclaims that the daughters-in-law (female protagonist) must bring her husband back on the right path and try to arbitrate the issue within the domain of family itself, instead of taking the issue of domestic violence to court (CAR: 2007)

TV serials, thus assume that this process of re-affirming 'responsibilities' rather than 'rights' for women shall have a much better reception among women viewers. The popularity of these TV shows amongst a cross-section of viewers indicates, how much they cater to the emotional and psychological needs of woman viewers and alter the audience's perspective with twists and turns in the plot lines. Therefore, these shows promote manipulation of the idea of empowerment and are considered highly regressive by those working for women's empowerment.

The much popularity of these TV shows comes from the way the family is displayed. The family is shown at the conjecture of tradition and modernity, thereby striving to maintain its traditional values as well as legacies and at the same time facing the challenges of modernity. The only common thing is the 'state of flux' in every plot.

The TV drama series displays immense faith in the traditional values of the Indian family system and gives due preference to them in multiple renewing ways, i.e., through dress code to extravagant celebrations of festivals and rituals. Other than these overt performances, traditional values are re-asserted in subtle ways through dialogues and discourses in plots of conflicts and disagreements. These plots are gender biases against women, thus raising serious questions on the so-called claims of pro-women representation of these serials. All the claims of modernity and change are farce because the screenplay and the storyline of the show reassert that tradition is more suited to the persona and needs of Indian women and modernity adds to negative character of vulgarity and disgrace to overall women's personality. At last, it is stressed that 'right' kind of change can only come through the reinvention of the tradition.

This 'right' kind of change approach is highly problematic. The 'change' is packaged and presented in a way, that suggest that family set-up is deeply under threat in modern times, therefore women must not cross the limits set by traditional values. If women cross the

line of family, then her return shall be guided by process of *agnipariksha* (purity test to prove her chastity) and *vanavasa* (exile/separation to repent of the deeds) (based on Ramayana mythology). Therefore, women must not take extreme steps and strife for change within the domestic limits by solely bearing all pain and sacrifices.

Hence, it is important to unravel this 'process of packaging the change', which represents the mode of transition or change 'through re-establishing the traditional family with all its gender and power constructs'.

Further, the female characters in most of these TV shows manifest throughout the course of show how the husband's family and house should be maintained. Parvati the protagonist of *Kahani Ghar Ghar Ki*, is a perfect wife, daughter-in-law, mother, sister-in-law, etc. She is a care giver to extended family and thrives to restore the values of the family threatened by other family members or the antagonist character of the show.

TV serials proactively display superficial attitudes towards women. Female characters are portrayed as authoritative, kind, ferocious and sometimes conniving, but never overtly submissive. Despite all the assertions, female characters are shown promoting traditional trappings, from dressing to mannerisms, from observing rituals to following day-to-day protocols, etc., which are all part of the packaging strategy. Thus, one can observe the return to gender characterization along the lines of predominant stereotypes of males and females.

Most of the scenes are shot in sets of kitchens, bedrooms, living rooms, etc. spaces that are within the perimeter of the house only, reasserting the stereotypical geographical boundaries of women. Further, women are shown outside the home only when there is trouble with her spouse or family members. Thus, these shows insist on the depiction of almost every aspect of life mainly in terms of the family, thereby, preventing gender from being explored in the modern context.

There can be no engagement with viewers' response, and no critique of content shall prove useful unless we question the process of packaging content and unravel what viewers are expecting from

the producers of this content. Deconstruction of situational context is more needed than storyboard, to decode the contextual structure of these family shows and to use TV medium as the measure for raising issues on gender rights.

CONCLUSION

This paper argues for an examination of the rhetoric of feminist empowerment. We suggest that there are serious implications for the popularization of the term empowerment and this needs to be situated in a discussion of feminist agency. While individual empowerment in women can help foster collective agency, it more often has the effect of stunting women, encouraging them to work only for themselves in the immediate moment. This of course is far from women working collectively as individuals toward significant structural changes that will help improve the lives of others. Without a doubt, it is necessary for women to feel some sort of power, but as this article suggests, when it is commodified, empowerment can come at the expense of actual change.

We need a definition of feminism that clarifies and articulates our sense of feminism as a movement whose coherence hinges on the heterogeneity of its constituents, and whose stability and durability depend on its capacity for revision and development. Third-wave feminism allows for this, yet within its multiple articulations, women must distinguish between what is a feminist project originating from feminist roots and what is feminist rhetoric being packaged and sold by media industries and bought by many young women. A cultural analysis informed by political economy, in this case commodification, illustrates how cultural production can be a part of feminist projects for social change. If empowerment stops at an individual level, it does just that, serves the individual. If this is the case, women will be forever reproducing social relations that are rooted in patriarchal oppression and capitalist exploitation.

The conclusion drawn manifests that 'national policy' would be unlikely to hasten the process of empowerment until the political concept of empowerment is given a central prominence to the

activities. Therefore, government intervention must conspicuously include strategies informed by the political evolution of women's issues and the role of mass media in India.

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Media, Minority Consciousness, Memory Sikhs and 1984*

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Before the process of alienation was set in motion Sikhs never considered themselves a minority. They took for granted that they were equal citizens in a pluralistic society, with equal rights and equal responsibilities. The fact that they are a small numerical minority, only two per cent of the population, has, literally, been pushed down their throats. If the fact of being a numerical minority automatically carries the corollary of second-class citizenship, can any minority feel it has an equal stake in the country? And once the stake is in doubt, can the commitment to the nation be unconditional and complete? (Harji Malik: 1985, 61-2).

This excerpt represents and encapsulates the widespread Sikh sentiment in the aftermath of the anti-Sikh violence of 1984. On 4 June, the most sacred of all Sikh shrines, the Golden Temple or Darbar Sahib, was seized by the Indian army under state auspices, killing the controversial Sikh leader Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and his followers along with thousands of innocent Sikh pilgrims. This attack on the Darbar Sahib was followed by Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's assassination on 31 October by her two Sikh bodyguards. This became the pretext for ruthless massacre of Sikhs in the Indian capital city, New Delhi, and other parts of north India. This violence continued unabated and with state sanction until 4 November 1984 even though in popular imagination it is remembered as a sudden outbreak or 'riots'. Since then, '1984' has become a certain shorthand,

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symbolizing the tensions between the community and state as well as state-inflicted civilian atrocities and state abuse in Punjab.

In the excerpt above Harji Malik, a Sikh columnist conveys the collective angst of the community post-1984. Despite strains between the central government and Sikh leadership before the 1980s, the community at large had assumed their taken-for-granted status in India. After the events of 1984, however, and the distorted imagery and language manufactured and disseminated by the mass media all Sikhs became stigmatized as the 'other' and suspected 'terrorists'. The state and state-sponsored media not only created and facilitated conditions for a process of misrepresenting the Sikh community but also neglected the role of the central government in brewing tensions that would prove lethal for Sikhs. As Malik points out, there was no natural association between Sikhs' numerical minority status and minority consciousness before the events of 1984. After the events of 1984, however, the Sikh community was made to feel they occupied a precarious and unstable place in what had so far been perceived as a relatively secure context.

The consequence of these state-created representations is that Sikh memories of 1984 and the community's interpretations of 1984 events have not found much space in the Indian 'public sphere'¹ (Habermas: 1989; Calhoun: 1992). The Indian state and mass media either continue to reproduce and perpetuate impoverished and one-sided images of Sikhs that first came into circulation in the 1980s or suppress and neglect these memories. An emergence of minority consciousness (Gupta: 1985) that started unfolding in 1984 continues today, albeit veiled in 'normalcy' in popular imagination (see e.g. Kaur: 2013). Official memories of 1984 are deliberately frozen and static and these in turn inform popular memory. Dominant memory in India still considers 1984 as an aberration in which the Sikh community at large was responsible. The invasion of the Darbar Sahib in 1984 is justified as necessary and benevolent for upholding national interest and the systematic massacre of October-November are dismissed as 'riots' or spontaneous and 'serendipitous' (Ghassem-Fachandi: 2012, 9) outbursts. The complexity of the situation in Punjab and labels created by the state and media have not received critical attention with a few scholarly exceptions (see e.g., Major:

1987; Gupta: 1996). Militant counternarratives gained ground in the immediate aftermath of 1984. The state had vested interests in exaggerating these voices and representing them as purely destructive despite the necessity of understanding the complexity of the situation and motivations behind this movement (see Mahmood: 1996). While dominant memories of 1984 are constructed and monopolized by the Indian state, there is an emerging set of diasporic voices counteracting these hegemonic accounts. A section of diaspora Sikhs are documenting and recording experiences of marginalization that they encountered in 1984 and that continue to inform Sikh identity today. The segment of Sikhs engaged in an active process of recreating memories in public spaces informed by the present is doing 'memory work' (Haug: 1987; Kuhn: 1995; Sa'adi and Abu-Lughod: 2007). Diasporic memory work is intergenerational. In addition to first generation Sikh immigrants who are direct migrants from India, their children or second generation with 'postmemories' or 'delayed, indirect, secondary' (Hirsch: 1997, 13) memories of 1984 are actively engaged in representing and reinterpreting 1984 and Sikh identity. Sikhs are using both their diasporic locations as well as availability of digital media to practice memory work.

I will examine media representations of Sikhs in the 1980s and their impact on Sikh identity. I focus mostly on media depictions of events leading up to 1984 and specifically the attack on the Darbar Sahib and Sikh massacres following Indira Gandhi's assassination. There is a severe paucity of media accounts from this period, because of the large-scale media censorship that was in effect (Singh: 1984; Major: 1987). It is important to remember that state assaults and media manufactured distortions about civilian Sikhs carried beyond that year, even though an analysis of these texts lies outside the scope of this article (see Kumar: 2008 for an examination of media misreporting of human rights abuses in the aftermath of 1984). While mainstream or legacy media such as print, television and radio were strongly influenced by the state in their depiction of events and imagery about the community, there is a shift underway because of transformations in media of communication. As I noted above the Sikh diaspora is playing a key role in initiating these shifts and using digital media as a tool towards this end.

This chapter will address the following questions: What were some representations that Indian mass media constructed and popularized? How did these texts create a process of Sikh marginalization? Why are these representations being contested most emphatically in the diaspora and what are some components of new narratives that diasporic Sikhs are creating via digital technology? I draw on a combination of methods including content analysis of print media,² radio and television reports, commentaries from journalists and scholars, narrative analysis of 1984 websites as well as personal interviews with Sikhs in North America, United States and Canada. I am glossing over some minute details in this chapter to provide a critical appraisal of media imagery while highlighting the hitherto neglected Sikh point of view.

Legacy media institutionalized feelings of being a minority among Sikhs by producing hegemonic and unchanging representations and memories of 1984. As an antidote to these dominant texts and memories, digital media with its horizontal and diffuse structure is ushering in a shift in imagery. Even though all representations, memories and narratives are inherently selective and incomplete, digital media is making available tools and spaces to piece together imagery and texts that have been suppressed so far. Memory work in and through digital media is proving important in fracturing dominant memories and representations. Diasporic memory work is laying bare the process by which the Sikh community became subordinate by managing and presenting their own narratives, and consequently restoring 'symmetry of the communication process' (Goffman: 1959, 8). In the process of creating counter memories to dominant narratives of 1984, a section of diasporic Sikhs engaged in memory work are both drawing on community values and rejuvenating community identity.

MEDIA, REPRESENTATIONS AND MEMORY

Media is not merely a reflection of reality, but it also creates reality (Tuchman: 1978; Schudson: 2011). Despite the veneer of objectivity and value-neutrality, news reports are 'narratives' or 'stories' that are socially constructed and distilled through a 'process of selecting,

highlighting, framing, shading, and shaping' (Schudson: 2011, xiv). Mediated images must therefore be understood not as pristine and verbatim accounts of the social world but as 'representations'. Representation in turn means the process through which people assign meanings to 'objects, people, events, in the world' (Hall: 1997, 61). Representation as a process of meaning making is contingent on questions of power (Foucault: 1980). Who assigns meanings to certain groups and events? Why are only some meanings selected to the neglect of others? These questions are important to understand representations, popular texts and imagery. These questions are also critical to understand memory because 'journalism ... is also the first draft of memory' (Garde-Hansen: 2011, 5). McLuhan ([1964] 1994) advanced that media are extensions of memory. The need to remember and share is profound and keen but human faculties are limited. These limitations were the impetus to create various media forms and practices. However, memories must also be understood as narratives or partial and incomplete interpretations of past based on present time and place.

According to sociologist Maurice Halbwachs, collective memory is a project necessarily situated in the present. Our memories are a product of our belonging to social groups in certain spatial locations based on the present moment. These memories are in turn a significant component of our shared identity. In a similar vein, Hirsch and Smith define cultural memory as 'an act in the present by which individuals and groups constitute their identities by recalling a shared past on the basis of common, and therefore often contested norms, conventions, and practices' (2002, 5).

Media is an important vehicle for the production and dissemination of memory. Even within the broad canopy of media, there is a distinction between mainstream or legacy media and digital media. Legacy media produces news stories vertically by relying on 'journalistic authority' (Zelizer: 1992). Legacy media also follow certain routines and norms necessary for 'professional, legacy news making' (Ostertag and Ortiz: 2013, 5). On the other hand, digital media is free of reliance on journalistic authority. Digital communication and information generation is more horizontal and diffuse. This is because digital platforms such as online discussion

forums, columns and blogs are sites for both production as well as consumption of narratives and 'prosumption' (Recuber: 2012). The process by which memories are produced and shared are then qualitatively different in these different kinds of media. While legacy media often create memories top-down, digital media are bringing about a democratization of memory as increasing number of people gain access to media through which to communicate, share and store their memories publicly (Garde-Hansen et al.: 2009, 8-19). This is not to say that digital media is free of bias and immune to issues of surveillance and scrutiny,³ but in comparison to mainstream media, digital media are proving indispensable in doing memory work or a deliberate and public reconstruction of pasts based on present contexts.

1984: An Overview

The attack on the Darbar Sahib and the massacre of Sikhs following Indira Gandhi's assassination was the culmination of at least a decade of strained politics between the state and Sikhs. Until the partition of the Indian subcontinent in 1947 into Hindu-majority India and Muslim predominant Pakistan, despite some simmering discontentment among Sikhs, they formed an alliance with Hindus against Muslim Pakistan (Gupta: 1996). At the time of the partition, Punjab was split into Indian and Pakistani sides, but Sikhs who had continued to stay in India did not receive separate territories because of their small numbers.

Many of the problems that came to headway in 1984 started with peaceful protests led by the Sikh political party the Akali Dal and centred on the document known as the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. The principal demands in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution included: first, the demand for Chandigarh as the capital of Punjab alone rather than both Punjab and Haryana; second, the demand that the sharing of river water between the adjoining states of Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan be adjudicated by the Supreme Court; and finally, territorial disputes between Punjab and its adjoining province of Haryana be settled by an independent tribunal. These demands along with the lack of Congress (I) leadership in Punjab made the

state uncomfortable.⁴ This led to an increase of Congress (I) led state interference in the region's workings.

The lack of success of non-violent protests for regional autonomy yielded the rise of a charismatic Sikh leader, Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, of small farmer background and who had acquired great popularity as a preacher. His role in interpreting the document and wreaking violence in Punjab is disputed within the community as well as between Sikh scholars and commentators (see e.g., Nayar and Singh: 1984; Sandhu: n.d.). As tensions kept unfolding tensions between the state and Bhindranwale, the latter shifted to the Darbar Sahib complex in 1983. The state under the leadership of Indira Gandhi repressed Sikh voices carried in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution by declaring President's Rule in Punjab in the same year, dismissing the elected Punjab government and replacing it with her own staff.

On 4 June 1984, the Indian army occupied the Darbar Sahib under the pretext of 'flushing out terrorists' and 'recovering arms' under a code name, Operation Bluestar (White Paper on the Punjab Agitation 1984). The army occupation killed at least 493 innocent Sikh pilgrims and Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and his followers. This is only according to official accounts contained in the Indian state issued White Paper. Civil organizations like Movement against State Repression have estimated the number of dead to be over 10,000. The attack on the Darbar Sahib and other gurudwaras or Sikh temples was followed by targeted violence against Sikhs from the evening of 31 October through 4 November 1984. Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's two Sikh bodyguards assassinated her on 31 October 1984. In the immediate aftermath of Indira Gandhi's assassination, violence broke out against Sikhs killing more than 3,000 Sikhs in Delhi and several hundred outside Delhi. This was a systematic targeting of Sikhs and included organized 'slaughter and rape that accompanied looting, arson and burning' (Kishwar: 1984, 10). Voters' lists were used to mark Sikh houses and businesses. Poor Sikhs suffered more than middle- or upper-class Sikhs even though all Sikhs were made targets. The famous and controversial writer Khushwant Singh noted at the time that he felt like a Jew in Nazi Germany (1992, 93). He did get refuge in the Swedish embassy,

however, unthinkable for Sikhs who faced the brunt of violence. Public buses and trains were used to transfer paid mobs. Mobs were given money and liquor as remuneration to set Sikhs on fire. Sikh men were dragged out of their houses often by their hair or *kes*⁵ and burnt and women were raped (Who are the Guilty? [1984] 2003). In official accounts of the time and in memories continuing today, these events were/are dismissed as 'riots' or spontaneous and accidental emotional outbursts of Hindus against Sikhs.

*Representations, Minority Consciousness and 1984
Pre-1984*

Strains between the Indian state and Sikh community were portrayed and refracted selectively by the Indian mass media including national newspapers like *The Times of India*, *The Hindustan Times*, *Doordarshan* and *All India Radio*. Media was owned and controlled by the state (see e.g., Ohm: 1999) precluding even an attempt at an accurate depiction of events. Even before the invasion of the Darbar Sahib in June, and Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's assassination in October 1984, the state started manufacturing feelings of alienation among Sikhs at large.

The central government had started creating an antagonistic climate for Sikhs by using several tactics especially between the years 1980-4. These measures included: (a) denying the Sikh political party, the Akali Dal's demand for greater regional autonomy contained in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution; (b) portraying the Anandpur Sahib Resolution as a secessionist document; and (c) using the state-controlled mass media as a mouthpiece to circulate their one-sided representations that held Sikhs accountable for the events of 1984.

The Akali Dal and its negotiations with the central government were continually cast in a negative and disruptive light by the state and media. Media reports focused on the threat that Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale's violent measures posed but did not cover the manipulations of the Congress (I) and its political leadership (see e.g., Nayar and Singh: 1985). The Indian state used the document put forward by the Akali leadership, the Anandpur Sahib Resolution as a tool to further their political ambitions. The three main demands

contained in the document (the demand for Chandigarh; river water distribution and river water rights; and deciding territorial disputes by an independent tribunal) were 'straightforward regional and secular issues'. The very transparency of Akali Dal's demands and the religious composition of the Akali regional party gave the Congress (I) a reason to 'communalize' demands contained in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution and created fear of Sikh separatism among Hindus (Gupta: 1985, 218-9).

The 'non-reading of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution' (Gupta: 1985, 221) was deliberate and willfully manipulated for electoral gains. Mass media provided emphatic endorsement and became a carrier for a systematic, sustained and vociferous campaign of 'government misinformation and disinformation on Punjab' (Gupta: 1985, 221). Harji Malik points out that the overwhelming importance to the separate Sikh state of Khalistan was an invention of the media rather than being representative of majority Sikh sentiment (1985, 39). The anti-Sikh rhetoric contained the message that 'Sikhs had to be taught a lesson. That "they" had it coming!' (Malik: 1985, 50). For example, in an article appearing in *The Indian Express* before the events of 1984, Arun Shourie, who later wrote in support of the Sikh view of the October-November massacre targeted and portrayed the entire Sikh community as greedy, manipulative and anti-national:

A demand born out of whipped-up phobias as the panth⁶-in-danger, is inherently insatiable. The moment you satisfy a part of the demand, or even all of it, a new and more extreme one is put forth.... Do not lull yourself in the belief that Khalistan is just the brainwave of a Jagjit Singh Chauhan.⁷ It has an ancestry, and in the eyes of many a respectable one (*The Politics of Pandering*, 1982).

June 1984

The pattern of partial or non-communication continued during Operation Bluestar. There were huge gaps in the media's reports of this sinister episode. There was a media blackout during Operation Bluestar and two weeks after the army invasion of the Darbar Sahib, newspapers were not published or were unavailable (Singh: 1984, 1569). The state-controlled television channel, *Doordarshan*, used

language such as 'fortifications' inside the Golden Temple and 'caches of arms' seized by the army. These images were absorbed passively and unconditionally. Much of this information that media reports on the *All India Radio* and *Doordarshan* were conveying was false and exaggerated. Sikhs were successfully labelled destructive 'terrorists' while the Indian state and army were applauded for 'saving' the country (Malik: 1985, 44). As Pritam Singh writing on the media coverage of Operation Bluestar and what followed notes:

It was obvious that such news manipulation was bound to hurt Sikh sentiments. But consistent with the objectives of the media programmes, what mattered was not the Sikhs susceptibilities but the acceptance of such propaganda material by the wider Hindu population. Consequently, Hindu-Sikh relations were further embittered and communal polarization was sharpened (Singh: 1984, 1571).

Reporter Brahma Chellaney who reported the goings-on inside the Darbar Sahib was harassed and charged with sedition by the government (Ghazali: 1985).

After the invasion of the Darbar Sahib, *All India Radio* and *Doordarshan* were assertive in their reporting that 'no damage has been done to Harmandir Sahib'⁸ during the army action (Singh: 1984, 1571). This was another glaring omission. Sikhs who visited the complex after the army action and saw the damage firsthand, write of the Harmandir Sahib pockmarked and damaged by bullet marks (Nayar and Singh: 1984). Far from playing an objective role in its coverage of the army invasion, media representations of the events as they unfolded were either absent or heavily partial and one-sided. The media created a climate to fuel feelings of hostility and communalism. The Sikh perspective was left out of mass media reporting systematically and deliberately. A journalist writing in *Mainstream* magazine legitimized and approved of state actions with complete disregard to the effects of this discourse on the Sikh community:

Could the military action in the Golden Temple have been avoided? If what was happening before the military action had continued for another two or three months, there would have been a massive Hindu backlash. There would have been massacre of Sikhs outside Punjab. The possibility of some

sort of coup and the army marching into the Golden Temple...could also not have been ruled out (Kewal Varma, 'Genesis of Sikh Alienation', 1984).

Expressing his anger, Patwant Singh, a prominent Sikh writer noted, 'What to others is just a building is to the Sikhs the supreme symbol of their honor and inspiration' (1985, 21). State-backed mass media failed deplorably in capturing these community reactions. In an evaluation of media reporting during 1984 and the prolonged period of crisis in which Sikhs were embroiled, independent observers and scholars have noted that leading English national dailies like *The Times of India* and *The Hindustan Times*, far from diffusing tensions, caused damage and destruction by inciting communal hatred (Das: 2009).

October-November 1984

The same pattern of partial reporting and/or non-reporting continued in October and November when her Sikh bodyguards assassinated Prime Minister Indira Gandhi. The entire Sikh community was targeted and stigmatized and mass media became the main instrument for forming and communicating these images. The mass media neglected and made invisible the organized massacre of Sikhs and instead fixed attention on the death and funeral of Indira Gandhi (Mitta and Phoolka: 2007). As Assem Shrivastava a witness writes:

Such seemed to have been the depth of state endorsement of the violence. Not one image of the looting and arsoning, let alone of the killing, was ever shown on TV. It would have appeared that the city of 9 or 10 million people was in solemn sorrow and mourning at the death of the great departed leader ('The Winter in Delhi, 1984', 2005).

The media designed a narrative of communal 'rioting', that was a consequence of Hindus' inflamed sensibilities. State-controlled radio and television depicted the violence as spontaneous 'madness' carried out in 'grief and anger' (Who are the Guilty? [1984] 2003, 1). Organized massacre of Sikhs was underplayed as 'riots' by the media and this language continues to be used to frame the violence today. The term 'riots' evokes spontaneity and suddenness when the attacks on the community were intentional and well planned (Who are the

Guilty? [1984] 2003). *Doordarshan* broadcast images of crowds shouting 'khoon ka badla khoon say' (blood for blood). As novelist Jaspreet Singh writes it was later found out that this soundtrack had been created by cabinet ministers and members of parliament (Singh: 2012, 160). The only mention of the brutal mayhem that was unfolding on the streets of Delhi and other parts of North India was depicted in an inadequate and impoverished media summary: 'There have been some disturbances'. The state controlled *All India Radio* announced that leaving aside a few episodes 'the situation was under control'. While international media (Singh: 2012, 160) and therefore diaspora Sikhs were watching qualitatively different images of what was unfolding on the streets of Delhi, Indian viewers saw only Mrs. Gandhi's body lying in state (Malik: 1985, 50).

The slain Prime Minister's son, Rajiv Gandhi who succeeded her, justified the violence against Sikhs. Rajiv Gandhi issued a statement on 19 November in which he considered the mass massacre of Sikhs, an emotional reaction or a manifestation of people's '*krodh*' or anger and said, *jab bada pēd girta hai, to dharti hilti hai* (when a big tree falls, the earth shakes). The state clearly and neatly abdicated all responsibility.

State narratives made it seem like Sikhs had called on Operation Bluestar and now if a 'handful' of Sikhs were killed, it was nothing more than collateral damage. Even though Sikhs in Punjab continue to suffer in the aftermath of state atrocities and media narratives (see Kumar: 2008), mainstream media have been only too eager to integrate 'former terrorists...within the national imagination as harmless, cheerful tricksters in a slew of Bollywood blockbusters...' (Kaur: 2013).

COUNTER NARRATIVES

One of the first and few Indian initiated counter narratives to the state came from independent human rights organizations. Writing about the June attacks, the organization Citizens for Democracy included a critique of the official response to the demands in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. The report entitled 'Report to the

Nation: Oppression in Punjab' was banned by the Indian government. The report states,

Now in 1984 after the Operation Bluestar suddenly the Government clamped down on Punjab an undeclared emergency. Punjab was cut off from the rest of the country for days, censorship was declared, all Pressmen—both foreign and Indian—were expelled. There was total black-out of news except what was told by the Government-run *All Indian Radio* and *Doordarshan*, again bringing back the unpleasant memories of Emergency days... Without a scrap of evidence we were expected to believe that it was Pakistan which was responsible for the growth of terrorism in Punjab and there was a seizure of highly sophisticated weapons ('Report to the Nation: Oppression in Punjab': 1985, 5-6).

The active role of the state and state-backed media in starting and fuelling the systematic November massacre has been recorded by civil rights organizations, specifically the People's Union for Democratic Rights and People's Union for Civil Liberties (PUDL-PUCL), in their report entitled, 'Who are the Guilty? Report of a Joint Inquiry into the Causes and Impact of Riots in Delhi from 31 October to 10 November'. The report notes,

The attacks on members of the Sikh community...far from being a spontaneous expression of 'madness' and of popular 'grief and anger' at Mrs. Gandhi's assassination as made out to be by the authorities, were the outcome of a well-organized plan marked by acts of deliberate commissions and omissions by important politicians of the Congress (I) at the top and by authorities in the administration (Who are the Guilty? ([1984] 2003, 1).

However, these counter narratives have not led to any major shifts in how 1984 is remembered in the Indian context.

The ascendancy of Sikh militancy as resistance to state narratives and state action was the most important set of counter narratives that gained ground in the aftermath of 1984. Once again, as with the events of 1984, the state and media stigmatized and dismissed these voices instead of understanding the issues at stake. The militant movement must be contextualized and understood as more nuanced and complex than state and media portrayals (see Mahmood: 1996). At the same time, however, violent methods that militants subscribed

to as a form of resistance drowned voices of suffering and trauma instead of bringing them to the attention of mainstream Indian population. It has also been to the state's advantage to allow only these dissenting narratives to emerge. The Indian state used militant counter narratives as an instrument to paint Sikhs without qualification as 'secessionist' and 'fundamentalist' (see Major: 1987 for a discussion of subtle differences between labels).

DIASPORA, DIGITAL MEDIA AND COUNTER MEMORIES

In opposition to top-down memories created by the state and mass media, a section of diasporic Sikhs are doing memory work by using new digital media. Despite the selectivity of all narratives, these spaces are critical for the community to tell their own version of what they experienced during and since 1984. This memory work emphasizes the 'grievability' of all lives (Butler: 2010, 13), not just the lives of majority community members, economically advantaged, or political leaders like Indira Gandhi. 'Memory workers' (Stein: 2009) are also using digital media to bring attention to social and economic issues of drug abuse, farmer suicide and female feticide that are rampant in Punjab. Digital spaces are helping Sikh memory workers represent a more complex and differentiated portrait of events than in circulation at present. Some of the websites I analysed include: sikhchic.com (created 2006); ensaaf.org (created 2003), sikhgenocide.org (created 2004); sikhtoons.com (created 2009); sikhmuseum.com (created 2000).

DIGITAL CULTURAL MOMENT

Digital means of communication are new forms of writing, speaking and listening in the cultural moment at which we are located. Digital media is a far more horizontal and diffuse form of information creation and circulation than mainstream media. This horizontality of the digital is especially helpful for suppressed narratives, such as Sikhs' experiences of 1984. While the Indian mass media has been filtering and obliterating Sikh points of view, digital media with its

ease of recording, sharing information and making it public, is ushering in new and engaged ways of communicating with the media. The digital cultural moment is playing a key part in upsetting the dominant narratives on 1984 in circulation and coming up with alternative narratives composed of Sikh voices.

Sikhs are telling their own experiences of 1984 so they can assert acknowledgement and speak about 1984 over non-acknowledgement and silence within and outside the community. Digital technology makes it possible to converge many times, many places, many experiences, many ways of expression- writing, speaking, art, music all at once and this convergence is playing an important part in giving digital memory work on 1984 a distinctive edge. Websites in 1984 contained many kinds of audiovisual texts in addition to written accounts to viscerally evoke readers of texts.

Diaspora, Transnational Connections and Second Generation

Most memory workers are Sikh women and men⁹ in the diaspora with direct experiences of 1984 or children of survivors. 1984 is an important component of Sikh identity for this segment and they are taking the initiative to create their own texts of 1984 and share these with the community at large. In the face of physical distance from 'home' or Punjab, diasporic Sikhs maintain transnational connections with Punjab. This emotional connection is about nostalgia and a longing for the culture and heritage left behind. But it is also about the emotional connection with loss and suffering that becomes an unbreakable tie. In India speaking about 1984 continues to carry fear of being persecuted and being apprehended as 'terrorists' and 'separatists'. Also, the very shock of what they had witnessed directly or indirectly left the first generation speechless. Immigrant and online contexts are providing 'safe social spaces' (personal interview) for writing, talking, sharing and listening about 1984. Loss is both real, that is directly experienced and vicarious or imagined, empathetic suffering felt without direct hurt. Memory work is intergenerationally transmitted.

The second generation's role is especially important in

understanding vicarious or imagined suffering of 1984. They are playing an integral part in carrying out active and activist memory work in 1984 based on their postmemories or delayed and indirect imaginings. As a generation that are 'digital natives' (Prensky: 2011) that is they are born into rather than migrate to digital cultures, they are at the forefront in recreating and reconfiguring existing narratives. Further, this generation is simultaneously rooted in Sikhi or the Sikh religious and cultural heritage along with a distance from the Indian state and media memories. As one of my second-generation interviewees explained to me, he felt a deep sense of attachment and affinity with Sikh history and heritage including stories of the Gurus and values of *seva* or altruistic service and *shahidi* or martyrdom. Second generation Sikhs admit that they do not take their identity for granted and go about finding a 'sense of purpose' because they are questioned about their identity on an everyday basis. Because of this particular cultural and temporal location, second-generation narratives of 1984 are different from state and media accounts. In a personal interview, another of my respondents explained:

... there is very much a strong narrative that's been painted that is not favorable for Sikhs ... in North America, with the benefit of distance you've been able to put together a Sikh narrative which is supported by tools of Internet and technology.

Another important trigger for the second generation gravitating towards memory work are the events of 9/11 in the United States specifically. This led the second generation to reflect on their 'difference' from the mainstream population in ways they had not done before and go back to tracing their genealogies or start memory work.

Memory work is a two-way process. While diasporic Sikhs are motivated to do memory work because of their direct memories of 1984 or commitment to Sikh values, memory work also helps them strengthen their ties with the community. To this extent, memory work performs the role of rituals (see e.g., Connerton: 1989). Memory workers rejuvenate and revive their belongingness to their group identity by re-presenting their own experiences and imagery. This is especially relevant in diasporic contexts where immigrants

must continually reinvent and reconstruct 'home' and its memories (Hall: 1980). The struggle with top-imposed representations is a struggle to redefine the past as much as it is a struggle for diasporic Sikhs to keep their community identity dynamic and interactional rather than static and unchanging.

Given the distorted representations of 1984 where all Sikhs are painted as 'violent', 'terrorist' and responsible for creating 1984, an important theme on all websites is to educate by including testimonies of direct and indirect Sikh accounts. Testimonies are stories told by witnesses of violent and traumatic events to reveal aspects of tragedies that might begin to bring about social change (see for example Wolf: 2007). Testimonies of 1984 are often connected with other important events in Sikh history such as the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre of 1919 in which the British army officer General Dyer ordered the shooting on several innocent Sikhs who had come together for a peaceful protest.

COLONIAL RULE; THE PARTITION OF 1947 AND THE BUILDUP TO OPERATION BLUESTAR

Emotions of anger and disbelief and criticism of the Indian state are part of online accounts. Digital spaces are important platforms to talk back to the dominant memories of 1984. The following account is typical of the way events are traced. The significance of the day of attack is brought out as well as the language clearly expresses the Sikh perspective on Operation Bluestar:

On 4 June 1984, India's Prime Minister, Indira Gandhi, ordered the Indian Army to invade the Golden Temple Complex in Amritsar, the Sikhs' national institution. As it was the anniversary of the martyrdom of the Sikhs' 5th Guru Arjun Dev, it was full of thousands of pilgrims.... On the pretext of apprehending a 'handful of militants' lodged inside the Golden Temple, the Indian Army unleashed a terror unprecedented in post-independence India (PS, ensaaf.org).

In addition to creating an educational critique of what transpired during Operation Bluestar and the time that immediately followed, there are several accounts that evoke the sinister atmosphere of the

October–November genocide. An instance of evocative memories is feelings of humiliation at letting go of *kes* or hair and an assault on the Sikh Khalsa body. This is poignantly expressed in accounts such as these:

...Word had spread that Indira Gandhi had been shot dead by her Sikh bodyguards... My father had discarded his turban and worn a helmet to reach home, an act that left a deep wound in his psyche ... the next three days were about death... The streets of India's political capital were littered with burning vehicles, burning houses, burning gurudwaras, burning men. Death was in naked display; turbaned Sikhs easy prey. ... (HB, sikhchic.com)

Memory workers are using digital media to fill gaps in representation but also facilitate a movement where this reconfigured imagery can facilitate rehabilitation for survivors of 1984. They want to excavate pasts both to (1) understand Sikh identity in the light of this trauma that repeats itself because of the magnitude of damage; and (2) address present-day problems such as drug abuse and farmer suicides in Punjab that can be traced back to the 1980s and begin creating alternative futures.

Sikhs are also asserting their identity by expressing their alienation with the Indian state and its functionaries—the government, courts, police—and aligning themselves with their places of settlement, without using the language of state-media created labels of ‘extremism’ or ‘fundamentalism’. As one website contributor writes:

I had become a US citizen in the late ‘60s, but when I look back, in my heart I must have maintained a dual identity, and shared my loyalty with India. These strands were finally divided post-1984 ... Yet, I continue to acknowledge and treasure the rich culture that shaped me, and immensely value Sikhi that came from that land (IJS, sikhchic.com).

CONCLUSION

State-backed Indian media constructed impoverished and limiting representations of Sikhs in the 1980s, specifically 1984. These media representations are the source of dominant memories of the events. Sikhs’ numerical smallness did not automatically translate into a

minority consciousness. Rather, this minority consciousness was manufactured by state actions and mediated texts. Memories of this period continue to impinge on the Sikh identity today but without public space for sharing experiences in the Indian national context. A section of intergenerational diasporic Sikh memory workers are overcoming state-engendered and media circulated fear to create spaces for free and uninhibited discussion of experiences of the time. Digital media is proving indispensable in these efforts. Digital media's easy accessibility where information is horizontally produced and circulated rather than vertically consumed is a major impetus behind memory work to talk back to dominant memories of 1984. Memory work both builds on belongingness to the Sikh community but also acts as a ritual to rejuvenate community identity and representations.

Memory work around 1984 is emerging and fledgling. While a section of Sikhs in the diaspora are invested in excavating memories and making efforts at placing their narratives alongside official representations, not everyone in the community is an equal participant. The fear of retribution and the solidity of state and mass media accounts continue to haunt the community. The passage of time, however, and the shift toward public commemoration of 1984 in and through digital media is facilitating subtle changes within the community. How will this digital and diasporic memory work affect representations in the mass media and in the Indian national context? Can frozen and static official memories begin to start responding to this memory work? These are questions that time and future research will reveal. In the meantime, the relationship between media, memories and Sikh consciousness alerts us to the durable impact of media texts on producing marginalization.

NOTES

1. Simply put, public sphere can be defined in terms of open access, equal status of participants and rational analysis of alternatives (see also Bernal, 2006).
2. I confine myself to an analysis of English dailies even though print media in India includes regional language publications.
3. See e.g., Jill Lepore. Online: http://www.newyorker.com/reporting/2013/06/24/130624fa_fact_lepore

4. Joyce Pettigrew explains a composite of factors explained the state's discomfort and insecurities: 'Three features of Sikh life—that they farmed rich agricultural land, were adjacent to the border, and were prominent in Indian institutions, especially the army—made the process of consolidation of state power in this region essential' (2006, 90).
5. Unshorn hair is one of the five markers of Khalsa or the dominant form of identity within the community. The five *ks*: *kes* or hair, *kangha* or comb, *kirpan* or ceremonial dagger, *kara* or steel bracelet and *kachchera* or breeches form a sacred composite of Khalsa personhood.
6. *Panth* means path and means the Sikh community.
7. Jagjit Singh Chauhan was a former state finance minister residing in London and an early advocate of Khalistan.
8. *Darbar Sahib*.
9. In my interviews, I found that mostly first-generation men are doing memory work in 1984. Among the second generation there is greater gender parity.

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CHAPTER 9

Media, Social Media, and the Gorkhaland Agitation in Darjeeling

BINU SUNDAS AND DIVYA PRADHAN

INTRODUCTION

The Gorkhaland movement has a long history. It started with the Hillmen's Association submitting a memorandum for a 'separate administrative set-up' for the district of Darjeeling to the then Governor General of Bengal in 1907. Subsequently, many memoranda have been submitted for separating the Gorkha-dominated areas from the province of Bengal. Since 1907, the creation of Gorkhaland has been entrenched in the collective conscience of the people. Another memorandum, a refined version of the 1907 memorandum was again submitted to the authorities in 1917, the representative of the Darjeeling district to the Chief Secretary, Government of Bengal, demanding the 'creation of a separate unit'. The unit in the memorandum was defined as the territory of the Darjeeling district and the Doars areas of Jalpaiguri district (Subba: 1992). Soon the declaration by the Indian National Congress in its 1920 Nagpur Session, that in post-independence India, states would be formed based on linguistic identity further fueled the imagination of Gorkhaland.

Even though the British did not separate the region from Bengal Province it did give it a special status like the Backward Track Region, etc. at different points in time. However, this did not satisfy the aspirations of the people and the demand perpetually sustained itself.

After independence the Hillmen's Association ceased to exist and the onus of sustaining the movement was spearheaded by different groups. The movement lost its momentum after Independence and only after the 1980s did it resurface in a sustained and organized form. During the 1980s when the movement was violent and widespread, it failed to capture the imagination of the 'national mainstream media'. Media, primarily print capitalism is considered to be an important medium through which nationalism and collective identity are forged, but not until the advent of social media and 24x7 news channels did the Gorkhaland movement receive any attention from the fourth pillar of democracy. This happened because of the marginalized status of Gorkhas in the national imagination.

HISTORY OF THE MEDIA IN DARJEELING

After taking over from the Rajah of Sikkim, the British shaped and moulded Darjeeling according to their imagination. They experimented with Darjeeling and helped in developing the infrastructure of the region. From the steam engine to the Hill Cart Road, the British built everything according to their requirements. Though the British were doing things for the better administration and sustenance of their rule, it needs to be acknowledged that they were instrumental in laying the foundation for the growth in the socio-political and economic consciousness of the people.

Numerous vernacular newspapers were published in Darjeeling due to the efforts of various individuals (Subba: 1992). The precursor to these publications were the English dailies and weeklies as well as monthly journals published by the British themselves. In 1892, many newspapers were in circulation in English. *The Darjeeling News* and *Darjeeling Standard* were published weekly. On the other hand, *News and Notes* was a monthly journal. Towards the end of the nineteenth century, between 1897 and 1898 there was a newspaper *Darjeeling-Kalimpong-Sikkim News* covering a wide area, and published every month (Darjeelinghistoryclub: 2020). The first monthly in the Nepali language *Gorkha Bharat Jiwan* was published in 1886 from Banaras and was edited by Motiram Bhatta (Subba: 1992). From the time *Gorkha Bharat Jiwan* came into circulation many other dailies,

weeklies and monthlies were published from Darjeeling, Kalimpong, Kurseong and Dehradun till the first decade of the 1900. Some of the prominent magazines and periodicals published when Darjeeling was under the colonial rule were *Gorkhey Khabar Kagat* (1901), *Suktisudha* (1904), *Madhavi* (1906), *Chandra* (1914), *Gorkhali* (1915), *Janmabhumi* (1922), *Himalayan Times* (1926), *Tarun Gorkha* (1928), *Adarsha* (1930), *Nepali Sahitya Sammelan* (1932), *Nebula and Parivartan* (1934), *Goan Sudhar* (1939), *Gorkha Samachar* (1946) (Subba: 1992). There were some like the *Gorkha Sevak* (1935) published in northeastern parts of India, *Gorkha Samachar* was published in Delhi. *Himalayan Times* was edited by Saheb Narendrabikram and was in English. *Adarsha* a monthly periodical was the only one published in Nepali that discussed the financial situation and the economic activities of the people of Darjeeling Hills (Darjeelinghistoryclub: 2020). However, some of these had to be taken out of circulation due to many factors and one such factor was the lack of a sizeable readership and the other was the lack of entrepreneurship on the part of the editors to sell their products. The spread of the Nepali diaspora warranted the need for newspapers to shed light on the socio-economic and political conditions of the Nepali population hence there were numerous print media in circulation. However, the absence of a sizeable readership forced many of these periodicals to stop publication as it was not financially sustainable.

After independence there were few other newspapers and periodicals that emerged in Darjeeling and Kalimpong districts. Some of the prominent among them were the *Himalayan Observer*, *The Swatantra Manchko Bulletin*, *Abo*, *Himali Bela*, *Gorkha*, *Ganthi Kura Dristikon* and *Himalchuli*. *Himalchuli* was the only one which was still in circulation when the Gorkhaland agitation started in the 1980s. The writers in these papers and especially in *Aba* played a significant role in politically mobilizing the masses the beginning of the agitation in the 1980s (Subba: 1992). There was a paradigm shift in the writings of the early 1900s to the beginning of the mobilization for Gorkhaland agitation. These writings, however, did contribute in a latent manner in constructing the collective consciousness of the people converting them into a collectivity rather than just a joining

together of discrete individuals without any common denominator. The writings which emerged after this period were more politically assertive and not as defensive as the earlier ones. The political imagination of the people by this time was already established due to the politics of Akhil Bharatiya Gorkha League (ABGL) and the pan-India Nepali Bhasa Andolan.¹ The latter had especially contributed immensely to the forging of a strong collective consciousness of the Gorkha population. The freshly developed collective identity made people aware of the political, social and cultural capital they possessed and provided a sense of ownership of history, geography and their location within it. The collective strength gave them the belief that they could challenge all the wrong notions most of Indian people and the government had about Gorkha history and existence. The writings started questioning their being labelled as foreigners and by implication their citizenship. This was and still is one of the most important reasons for the demand for the creation of a separate state of Gorkhaland.

MEDIA AND SOCIAL MOVEMENT IN DARJEELING REGION

As mentioned above the demand for separation from Bengal started in 1907. The political situation of Darjeeling then and when the movement erupted again in the 1980s under the leadership of the Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF) was completely different. However, the only thing that was common during these two historical periods was the conspicuous absence of the media. Media is a very essential component in social movement as it helps in propagating the issues, legitimizing the claims made by the movement and more importantly it helps in shaping the public perception and understanding of the political necessity of the movement (Rohlinger & Vaccaro: 2013). Though media plays an important role in social and political movements, it did not contribute anything to propagating the issues of the Gorkhaland movement at the national level.

By the time the movement started in the 1980s only the vernacular media was present. The absence of national dailies was

visible. The only national daily that was in circulation was *The Telegraph* and it would not reach the people on time. At the earliest, it would reach the place only in the evening. It was more or less the same with *The Statesman*. The other national newspapers had negligible presence in the region. The above mentioned two newspapers that were in circulation among Gorkhas were not interested in disseminating the facts of the agitation, as the government had a firm grip on the news it was printing. Radio was another medium to reach people but being part of the governmental structure it did not play any significant role in disseminating and propagating the ideology of the movement. Moreover, radio was also not a commodity that was owned by the entire population which further restricted its efficacy. Even in post-independent India, media in Darjeeling was at its nebulous stage. It could not boast of a newspaper. The media had not yet found a location of its own in the lifeworld of the people. Media was still a component of the high culture and had not yet been part of the mass popular culture. In such a situation the only medium to disseminate and circulate information and news was the *bhitta* or the wall.

Every place had a designated *bhitta* for disseminating all kinds of news to the people. For the common people the *bhitta* for a long time had been a site for collective participation in the political discourse. *Bhitta* was the site for not just participation but also for dissent and protest and a medium for articulating one's political ideology and activism. People from all walks of life gathered to read the posters as well as dictates of political parties regarding what they thought of a particular development as well as their future course of action and the role the civil society and the community had to play. Standing in front of the *bhitta* and reading had been part of the everyday ritual for the reticent as well as the vocal political participant. People reading the news/announcement pasted in the *bhitta* would relay it to people in their locality and in this manner, the news spread far and wide. *Bhitta* was and is part of the cultural as well as political capital of the Gorkhas demand for Gorkhaland for over a century. Mainstream media in all its forms did not have a role to play during the Gorkhaland movement in the 1980s. The media was neither functional nor

dysfunctional for the activists as well as the government. However, things were to change drastically when the movement started again in the new millennium.

Society and Change in Darjeeling

During the agitation, many lives were lost and property worth crores of rupees was damaged. It is believed that approximately 1,200 lives were lost from 1986 to 1988 when the agitation was at its peak. Atrocities and violence were inflicted by the state and central police forces among the people without any discrimination based on age or gender. The agitation came to an end when the Central Government, State Government and the GNLF came into an agreement and signed the tripartite agreement for the creation of Darjeeling Gorkha Hill Council, a semi-autonomous body. However, one of the clauses in the agreement mentions that the agreement is the final settlement with regard to the demand of Gorkhaland, thereby putting an end to the aspiration of the people. This understanding created an ecosystem of animosity and the trust and support that GNLF enjoyed was gradually on the decline. GNLF was in power for almost three decades and in 2007 a reality show on television changed the political course of the region and the people.

The political dominance of the GNLF was challenged by one of its leaders, Bimal Gurung. He was able to garner the support of the people and it was very easy for him to gain the confidence of the people. GNLF had created a reign of terror and the demographic profile of the population had also undergone transformations. The young people who had witnessed the demand for Gorkhaland had internalized the importance of collective identity. In 2007 'Indian Idol', the reality show became instrumental in bringing the Gorkha population spread across India as well as abroad in support of a Gorkha contestant in the show thus highlighting the collective strength of the Gorkhas. Solidarity among the people was once again at the forefront. Soon GNLF was overthrown by Gorkha Janmukti Morcha (GJM).

The GJM vehemently opposed the GNLF efforts to include the Darjeeling region under the Sixth Schedule until and unless the

entire Gorkha community was included in the Scheduled Tribe list of India. The population in the hills has undergone not just quantitative but also qualitative change. The educational as well as economic status of the people had improved. The population had increased from 16.09 lakhs in 2001 to 18.47 lakhs in 2011 and the literacy rate had improved from 71.79 in 2001 to 79.56 in 2011 (*Darjiling (Darjeeling) District Population Census 2011-2021-2023, West Bengal Literacy Sex Ratio and Density*, n.d.). This population also had access to the media that had developed leaps and bounds since the 1980s.

The GJM was more fortunate than the GNLF as far as access to media was concerned. The prominent sources of media during the GJM-led agitation was *Himalaya Darpan* a local daily in Nepali published from Siliguri, the darjeelintimes.com, and many cable television channels like the *Hamro Channel*, *Himali Channel* and *Darjeeling Television*. All these media outlets helped in the cause of GJM. Except *Himalaya Darpan* the proprietorship of the rest belonged to the natives of Darjeeling, *Himalaya Darpan* to establish itself took the cause of Gorkhaland and helped GJM in propagating their stories and news. GJM thus became successful in changing the narrative of the politics of the hills and once again the agitation for Gorkhaland erupted and again a tripartite agreement was signed for the creation of Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA). Two differences emerged in the two agreements signed. First, it was the word Gorkhaland and second, the agreement on GTA acknowledges that the movement for Gorkhaland would sustain and carry on. With regard to polity, a very significant distinction emerged. GNLF and its leader, the Chairperson of the DGHC was seen as a puppet in the hands of the Government of West Bengal while GJM and its leader the Chief Executive Officer of GTA were cordial but was seen as indifferent of the State Government control. Bimal Gurung even led the masses when the Government did not fulfil its responsibilities towards the GTA. The media was supportive of his politics and assisted in taking his grievances against the government to the people thus making his ideas and narratives the dominant political discourse. These cable television networks had become so prominent in facilitating the connection and bonding between the people and the

GJM that the District Magistrate, Darjeeling banned the telecast of cable television from 8 August to 11 August 2013, invoking the provisions of the Cable Television (Regulation) Amendment Act, 2011 (Dural: 2015).

The society in Darjeeling was witnessing rapid changes. The educational and economic status of the people were improving and many were now migrating to other places in search of better livelihood opportunities and to pursue educational aspirations. The migrant population later played a preemptive role in the movement.

Gorkhaland Movement in 2017

The relationship between the state government and the GTA was not stable and cordial, there were allegations and counter-allegations made by both parties. The GTA accused the state government of withholding transfer of departments that were listed in the agreement for the development of the region while the state government accused the GTA of embezzlement of development funds. Further, the GTA was not happy with the government for setting up Development Boards on the basis of community which they thought interfered with the functioning of the GTA. The political situation in the hills reflected the low point of the relationship between the two institutional actors, both manifesting their indignation against each other.

Particularly, the situation for the GJM, who was in power, was stable as the people were dissatisfied with the achievements and the state government was constantly accusing them of corruption and using it as a threat to discontinue the agreement. Under such a situation the West Bengal Government undertook the policy of implementing Bengali language in all the schools of the state. This was unacceptable to the people of Darjeeling and this policy implementation was perceived as language imperialism. Civil society and GJM were against the implementation of the Bengali language in place of the Nepali language. There was a protest not just from GJM but by all the Gorkha population living inside and outside of Darjeeling against this policy. Soon this gave way to the demand of Gorkhaland as it was thought that only the creation of Gorkhaland would put an end to the suppression and oppression experienced by

the Gorkha people of India. During this phase of the movement, it was not just confined to Darjeeling hills alone but the demand for the creation of Gorkhaland was raised from many parts of the country.

The hills were closed for 107 days. There were hardships and troubles but the people were relentless in sustaining the *bandh*. Calls for the bandh to be withdrawn were made by the state and the central governments but it fell on deaf ears. The atrocities of the state became severe with every passing day. In no time 11 people were killed by the state apparatus. All the leaders of GJM were forced to go underground and it was common people who sustained the movement. The national media was mute to the happenings in the hills as usual. Only Republic Bharat reached Darjeeling to report the atrocities that people were facing. *The Telegraph* soon became the mouthpiece of the state government which was followed by the local vernacular *Himalaya Darpan*. These newspapers were printing only the government version of the story. Depending on the ideology of the owner's television channels broadcasted news accordingly, either in favour or opposed to the state. News which till then had been more or less unbiased and objective now tended to be determined by political ideology. News became more of a propaganda tool for the government and the political order. Reality soon became what the news channels constructed to be and flooded the screen. All ideologies in the political spectrum started using television and news channels and only representational culture was given space in the news. News anchors gradually became agents of the representational culture denying space to alternative thoughts and dissenting voices.

Media and its Role During the Agitation

The agitation in 2017 was very different than the earlier ones. The leader of GJM, Bimal Gurung proclaimed in 2014 that henceforth all agitation will be peaceful according to the principles of Gandhi. The agitation in 2017 was also peaceful and the mode of dissent was to go on a strike, public rallies, street corner speeches and sloganeering. These actions were an endeavour to build the movement and the morale of all actors and also to communicate with them (Piven:

2008). However, the state apparatus was on the offensive and started using both the allocative and authoritative resources to show their power and to end the agitation. False cases were filed against all the leaders and the prominent associates of the leaders. Most of these people had more than 100 cases against them and many of them were also charged with the draconian Unlawful Activities Prevention Act. Such a situation forced all the leaders and their subordinates to hide leaving the onus of spearheading the movement to the lower cadres and the common people. The strike was sustained for 107 days till two leaders betrayed the movement and the people and forcefully withdrew the strike. There was no supply of necessary everyday requirements. People had to face tremendous hardship. Under these circumstances, there were few media which covered what was happening in the region but it soon faded out.

With the use of force and atrocities, the state was able to suppress everything and maintain its dominance in the region. The state censored all the news and the media fraternity could not get or report the actual happenings from the hills. Getting the word out on important news events from the region was such a challenge those days. In addition, countering distorted, biased and unverified news and narratives spewed by mainstream media and even social media platforms paid for by the state was almost impossible due to the lack of internet (*The Centre for Internet and Society*, n.d.). The hills were experiencing an existential crisis more than a political crisis as the tea gardens were closed and all form of communication was restricted by the state. The state could have acted in a humanitarian manner and showed its largess by allowing ration and other commodities to reach the people but it did not do so. The crisis in the region was much deeper than it could meet the eyes. Even in such a dire situation the media was propagating for the state and prophesizing the benefits the Chief Minister could accrue from the situation rather than reporting on the plight of the people. The Scroll wrote, 'The agitation in West Bengal's hill areas may end up benefitting the chief minister politically' (Daniyal: 2017). The government used the media as an instrument to polarize public opinion. The media played its role as an instrument at the hands of the government by manufacturing false news those were detrimental to the movement. The agitation in 2017 was

coordinated by the Gorkhaland Movement Coordination Committee (GMCC) comprising members from all the parties but one of the media based on the opinion of a government official reported, 'It is clear from the decisions taken during the all-party meeting in the hills that the Morcha leadership has started compromising with the demands of other hill parties. This is a clear hint that the Morcha leadership is weakening' (*Scoopwhoop*: 2017).

Social Media and the Gorkhaland Agitation

The setting in of the vernacular marked a new beginning in terms of the dissemination of opinions and news. It offered a new platform for many to understand, articulate, reflect and reflect on the political economy of the region and to an extent of those nearby places dominated by the Gorkha population. It also assisted in forging a relation among the imagined community giving a new but desired traction to the common cause of identity and the predominant politics associated with it. Furthermore, the dailies also led to the beginning of modernity and the establishment of a community, that connected by sharing their concerns and opinions about the urgent issues of the community. The dailies also helped in bringing modern technology and technological developments closure to the people. Soon technology became common which further pushed the community into a new direction of modernity and information. By the time the 2017 agitation started internet became a source of all development social, political and economic (Navarria: 2019). Internet in the guise of social media filled the vacuum that a biased and prejudiced or passive media had left.

Social media platforms like Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp, and Instagram were all proactively used by the people to talk and write about the movement as well as the police atrocities. The activism of the people through these platforms helped in galvanizing support from those who were not in Darjeeling. *The Telegraph* reported on this aspect of the movement and the government was quick to ban the internet. In the absence of the Internet, it was difficult for the movement activists to synchronize and execute their plans. The use of social media helped the common people to organize themselves

and connect (Lopes: 2014) and establish a pro-movement narrative. 'The possibility to access, recombine and distribute knowledge freely or with minimum restriction can help subvert established hegemonic power positions by providing new entry points to the political process for those actors usually relegated in a non-active position by the predominant influence of existing power-holders over mainstream media networks' (Navarria: 2019).

The use of social media helped the movement in taking the ground realities to people across the globe. With the help of social media, the movement gained momentum and protests and demonstrations were held not just in Darjeeling and other places in the country but across different countries where even a handful of people from Darjeeling were residing. There was coordination among activists from different places and also from other countries which helped in 'gaining regional and global resonance in diverse audiences across the world' (Porta & Mattoni: 2015, 53).

Another very important dimension of the movement was the use of WhatsApp. WhatsApp helped the activists to construct for themselves an autonomous communication, which very essential for the movement to relate with the society (Castells: 2015). This platform was used by the activists as well as the leaders to connect and to discuss and propose ideas that were important for the movement in which the main actors were missing from the scene. The multiple features of WhatsApp like voice messages and the facility to use languages other than English also helped greatly as all activists were not well versed in the English language. The voice message facility was used to the fullest. The leaders would also use this to pass on the messages in tones that were effective in arousing the sensibilities of the activists towards the movement. The activists in turn would forward these messages to the general public. The act of forwarding the messages would ensure that the message would reach the entire population. WhatsApp was very instrumental as well as successful as a medium to sustain the connection between the leaders, the activists and the general population.

The leaders who had betrayed the movement and the people had by coercion and use of state repressive apparatus usurped power and were in control of the GTA. The movement activists were hounded

by the state and the police. In such a situation the general election of 2019 was pertinent to show the support that the movement and GJM enjoyed from the people. Along with WhatsApp, it was also Google Meet that played a very significant role in planning and executing the plans. According to the Secretary and President of GJM if it had not been for Google Meet and WhatsApp it would not have been possible for them to organize participation in the election. The candidate was discussed over Google Meet and WhatsApp and approval from all the stakeholders was sought. There were over 100 meetings with the use of Google Meet among party cadres hiding at different locations. The candidate for the election was also decided using these platforms. The significance of WhatsApp can be analysed from the fact that according to one of the parties functionaries, the candidate was decided at around two at night in consultation with the alliance party. All the members of the party were informed through WhatsApp immediately but by six in the morning, the candidate had to be changed as the cadres had disapproved of the candidate who was again replaced by another candidate.

Apart from the core party members making use of these platforms, they also used these platforms to generate support for the issue of Gorkhaland. Numerous Facebook pages like the *Darjeeling Chronicles* and *Gorkhaland Flag Campaign* started functioning as the spokesperson of the movement. Pro-movement information and activities in any form started being shared on these pages. The ordinary citizens who were witnessing the making of history were using their mobile phones to record (Castells: 2015). Everybody with a smartphone participating in the movement thus inadvertently became a broadcaster (Porta & Mattoni: 2015) of events which was of interest and importance for the movement and could transfer to these pages for the consumption of wider audiences. They also ridiculed the leaders who had betrayed the movement and went against the ruling party in West Bengal. These Facebook pages were instrumental in communicating with the masses and disseminating and propagating the importance of Gorkhaland and the agitation for preserving the distinct identity and cultural heritage of the region and community. They became an effective tool and the government reacted to their influence and impact by filing many false cases against

them to the extent that one of the editors of *Darjeeling Chronicles* could not even attend his father's funeral. Internet in the hills during the 2017 agitation and after became a medium which assisted the public and activists alike to organize and execute their everyday interactions (Fuchs: 2015) 'in ways beyond the control of the state' (Salem: 2015, 172).

Apart from acting in a repressive manner the government and its agencies also was proactive in surveillance. The police and other state machinery had completely overtaken the public spaces and had established their grip with the help of those who had betrayed the movement. The government tried to change the political discourse and the dominant narrative with repression at the earlier stage of the movement and when this did not have the desired effect, they tried to counter the narrative with the help of social media. The government in this endeavour was assisted by those who had joined hands with the leaders who had betrayed the movement and those who were against GJM. They also started using Facebook pages to propagate misinformation about the movement particularly about the GJM and Bimal Gurung. They would run an online voting campaign and the results would always be the candidate of the opposition winning the online voting. Along with these tactics, the agency hired by the ruling party of West Bengal to strategize their election campaign offered monetary and other benefits to the platforms that were pro-Gorkhaland. The government tried to use its agents to polarize the population through the use of these platforms and establish a narrative which showed that they were good and the movement actors were bad (Lukito et al.: 2022).

CONCLUSION

The Gorkhaland movement can be traced to 1907 when for the first time a memorandum to the then Viceroy of Bengal Presidency was submitted. Since then, the separation from Bengal has been sought after by the people of the Darjeeling region. However, this separation has still not been achieved even after more than 115 years. It is well known that media plays an important role in social movements as these movements try to 'communicate their grievances' and 'build

the movement and its morale' (Piven: 2008, 23) and also communicate with the larger public. In the case of the Gorkhaland agitation due to its long history, different forms of media have come into being and the direction in which the movement has been reflected is not uniform. In the initial period, the media and the writings on it were more subdued and apologetic. In the 1980s the media became more offensive and aggressive while vehemently defending the demand and rubbishing the foreigner tag that was labelled against the Gorkha population. But this was only in the vernacular press and did not contribute much to change the perception and narrative that was dominant at the national level.

In the new millennium when the entire world was experiencing a boom in information technology, Darjeeling was readying itself to embrace this social change. There was socio-economic improvement in the people taking place and many had also socialized to this new way of life. In 2007 when the agitation again started internet became the tool for manifesting the grievances that lay dormant for years under the rule of GNLFF. After a hiatus of another decade when the agitation started in 2017 the use of the internet was at the core of the movement. The press and television were to a large extent under the control of the government. Therefore, social media was the only resource in the hands of the people to fight the repression and atrocities of the state and its apparatuses collectively. Any form of physical gathering or collectivity was not possible due to the brutality of the state. Social media helped people to collectively raise pertinent issues and make one another aware of what the state was doing. Internet and social media have provided an alternative to mobilization and have provided a platform where individuals can perform different roles. They can manifest their power by breaking rules and interacting with many other like-minded actors. Social media provided a space where people could exercise their agency not just individually but also collectively without being identified by the authorities and making them victims of their brutality. Social media empowered common people in their fight against the state by providing them an identity of anonymity.

Anonymity gave people the courage to act against the combination of all state actors along with the leaders who had betrayed the

movement and their team but at the same time, it did not all the time facilitate sameness and oneness of activities carried by different individuals. This anonymity also acted as an impediment towards the movement as many opposed to the movement and the leadership using the internet and social media also propagated—anti-movement narratives. However, Darjeeling being a small region and with not so big population it was not very difficult for the state to at least roughly identify the users as they controlled to internet service providers. On the one hand, the nexus between the corporates and the state became detrimental to achieving effective results on the other social media has provided a viable space for non-state actors to challenge the dominance and hegemony of the state (Trottier & Fuchs: 2015).

Darjeeling during the agitation witnessed an increase in the use of social media. GJM was successful in using it to fulfil its political objective by mobilizing people and passing its message across the people. This helped the people to realize the potential power of collective identity and solidarity. As a consequence, they were able to win election in the 2019 general elections and prove that the people were in support of their demand for Gorkhaland. Most importantly the use of social media was instrumental in raising sensibilities towards the movement and one another. From being defensive in the media in the earlier phase to actively partial writings in the 1980s, the use of social media in the agitation of 2017 and after, helped the leaders and most importantly, the majority of the people to be legally, constitutionally and socially erudite and fight the state in their just and rightful demand of separation from the state of West Bengal.

NOTE

1. Nepali Bhasa Andolan was the agitation for the inclusion of Nepali Language in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution thereby granting it a recognition as one of the Indian languages.

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